THY KINGDOM COME · VOLUME ONE

The World Dossier

The history, institutions, beliefs and places that produced Eden's story, and the scripture the Empire inherited.

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How this volume works

Volume One is about the world: the history, institutions, beliefs and places that produced Eden's story. The people and the chapters belong to Volume Two. When a fact about the world matters to one particular person, this volume points to her dossier instead of working it out here.

Parts I through V cover the scripture the Empire inherited: what the Bible is, the books, the people in them, Jesus and the prayer the novel is named for, and how Christianity has been used by power. Parts VI through XI cover the world itself: the Fall, the Empire's institutions, its doctrine, its women and households, the twelve Dominions and the Trials. The world parts are written from your source files, your Final Rulings and the rulings you made in the calibration doc. The scripture parts are rebuilt from the old Companion's research and checked again. A canon register at the back collects every conflict, superseded fact and open question in one place.

Reading the labels

Anything established by your files carries a source tag and no label. Everything else is labeled at the start of the sentence or paragraph it governs.

TAG	SOURCE
TL	Timeline Updated
TR	The Covenant Trials Updated
TR-orig	The original Covenant Trials file. Used only where the updated file is silent, and superseded wherever they disagree.
DOM	The Dominions Update
MEN	Men in the Covenant Empire
CR	The Crownward
DR3	Draft Three (Chapter One so far)
WR	Writing Rules
FR 0–44	Final Rulings, by number
AM	Audit Master (the old Companion)
Ruling	A ruling you made in the calibration doc on October 23

LABEL	MEANING
RESEARCH	Outside fact, with a source
INTERPRETATION	A reading of the material, offered as a reading
CONTESTED	A real scholarly or theological dispute
INFERENCE	A conclusion drawn from your files that they don't state
POSSIBLE	An idea worth considering, and not canon.
OPEN QUESTION	Something you still have to decide
CONFLICT	Two of your sources disagree
SUPERSEDED	Older material that no longer controls
DECIDED	A call you handed to me. Treated as canon until you overrule it.

Every part closes with working questions and a blank page to work on. Framed spaces mark where portraits, maps and diagrams go, so you can paste or draw them in.

How the scripture parts work

Parts I through V cover the book the Empire inherited: what the Bible is, how it's read, the books themselves, the people in them, and how states have used it. They're rebuilt from the old Companion's research, rewritten in the new voice, with every claim checked again. A spot check turned up real errors in the old version, so nothing was carried over on trust.

One convention is different here. Most of this material is outside research, and a RESEARCH label on every paragraph would bury the page, so in Parts I–V unlabeled prose is RESEARCH. TKC material carries its source tag as usual. CONTESTED, INTERPRETATION, POSSIBLE and the other labels still mark everything that isn't settled fact. Scholars are named in the text where a position belongs to them. Each part ends with a short "For TKC" section that connects the research to the world parts, and with working questions.

The standard references behind this material are the ones in the old Companion's Sources and Editions pages: Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia, Rahlfs–Hanhart, NA28 and UBS5 for the texts, BDB and HALOT for Hebrew, the Anchor commentaries (Milgrom on Leviticus, Weinfeld on Deuteronomy), and Sanders and Ehrman on the New Testament. Page-level references are still an open proofing task, as they were in the old version.

PART I

Scripture as a Library

The Bible is a library, not a single book. It's a collection of documents written over roughly a thousand years in three languages, by many hands, for audiences who mostly didn't know the other documents existed. Its writers sometimes disagree with one another, and the collection keeps both sides. To write a world in which an empire quotes this book, you need to know what's in it, how it came together, what kinds of writing it holds, and where its readers have always divided.

I.1 What the Bible is

The sixty-six-book Protestant Bible has thirty-nine books in the Old Testament and twenty-seven in the New. It's written in Hebrew, some Aramaic (parts of Daniel and Ezra) and Greek. No single author or editor produced it, and it never had an original title page.

Other traditions draw the edges differently, and the order of the books is itself an argument about what the story is.

COLLECTION	BOOKS	HOW IT'S ARRANGED	WHERE IT ENDS
Tanakh (Jewish)	24	Torah, Prophets (Nevi'im), Writings (Ketuvim). A complete scripture, not an "Old Testament."	Chronicles, with Cyrus's decree to go up and rebuild. The story closes on return.
Protestant	66	39 Old Testament books (the same Hebrew books as the Tanakh, counted and ordered differently) and 27 New Testament books	Malachi, then Revelation. The Hebrew scriptures end on a promise, which frames them as prologue.
Catholic	73	Adds the deuterocanonical books: Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, Baruch, 1–2 Maccabees, and additions to Esther and Daniel	Includes the Maccabean revolt, armed resistance to an empire that outlawed the faith
Orthodox	76 or more	Varies by communion. The Greek, Slavonic and Ethiopian traditions differ from each other. The Ethiopian canon is the largest.	No single answer. Canon has never been uniform worldwide.

The old Companion had a typo here ("28 New"). The Protestant New Testament has twenty-seven books.

The Bible also doesn't speak in one voice. It holds conversations its own writers never resolved.

THE TENSION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE
Deuteronomy and Job	Deuteronomy ties covenant faithfulness to flourishing. Job gives a righteous man catastrophe and lets his friends make the simple version of that argument until it fails. The dispute is over retributive theology used as a rule.
Ezra and Ruth	Ezra–Nehemiah records foreign marriages being dissolved as restoration policy. Ruth makes a Moabite woman David's great-grandmother. Each gives a different answer to the same question about who belongs.
Proverbs and Ecclesiastes	Proverbs teaches that wisdom can be learned and generally pays. Ecclesiastes looks at the same world and reports that the pattern doesn't hold.
Court and prophet	The court histories tell kingship from inside the palace. The prophets address the same kings from outside, about the poor, the widow, the foreigner and the worker, and also about idolatry, false worship and foreign alliances.

INTERPRETATION These read best as tensions inside one tradition, not as authors calling each other liars. The old overview page's line that "Job says that is a lie told by comfortable men" overstated it, and the old Companion corrected it a few pages later.

I.2 How the canon was assembled

No single meeting ever decided the Bible. Communities read, copied and prayed with these texts for generations before anyone published a list, and the lists mostly ratified habits that were already in place. A congregation in Alexandria and one in Carthage could disagree about a book for a century without either one considering itself in schism.

The Hebrew scriptures settled in three stages. The Torah worked as authoritative law for the restored Judean community by the Persian period, around the fifth century BCE. Nehemiah 8 shows it being read in public. The Prophets were recognized as a body later. By the second century BCE, writers could refer to "the law and the prophets" as a known pair. The Writings settled last. Psalms and Proverbs were uncontroversial, and Esther, Ecclesiastes and Song of Songs were still being discussed in the rabbinic period. The Septuagint, the Greek translation made for Greek-speaking Jews starting in Alexandria in the third century BCE, held a wider and looser collection. Most New Testament writers quote it, which is why the Christian Old Testament inherited a different shape.

The Dead Sea Scrolls, found between 1947 and 1956, include biblical manuscripts about a thousand years older than the standard medieval Hebrew codices. They show a text that's remarkably stable in most places and genuinely variable in others. The scrolls correct both the idea that the Hebrew Bible never changed and the idea that it was rewritten wholesale.

The New Testament came together over about three centuries.

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENED
c. 50–60 CE	Paul's letters, the earliest New Testament documents, written before any Gospel
c. 70–100 CE	The Gospels, written after the Temple's destruction in 70
Mid-2nd century	Marcion publishes a deliberately reduced collection: an edited Luke and ten of Paul's letters. The reaction sharpens everyone's sense that the boundary matters.
c. 180	Irenaeus argues for exactly four Gospels. Arguing for the number shows it was contested enough to need defending.
Date disputed	The Muratorian fragment lists much of what becomes the New Testament and leaves some of it out. Most scholars date it to the late second century, and a minority place it in the fourth. CONTESTED
Early 4th century	Eusebius sorts books into accepted, disputed and rejected. It's a working scholar's triage, not a ruling.
367	Athanasius's Easter letter lists the twenty-seven books of today's New Testament
393 and 397	Regional councils at Hippo and Carthage in North Africa affirm lists close to today's
c. 382–405	Jerome produces the Latin Vulgate and flags the books he considers secondary, a distinction Rome didn't adopt
1546	The Council of Trent affirms the deuterocanonical books for Catholics. Protestant reformers had moved them to a separate section or dropped them.

Emperors did fund copies and convene meetings. Constantine's role at Nicaea in 325 was real, but Nicaea wasn't about the canon. **INTERPRETATION** The defensible claim is that the people who could convene, fund, copy and distribute had outsized influence over which texts stayed in circulation, and circulation is most of what canon means in practice.

Some books took longer to be accepted than others, and each had its own recorded objection.

BOOK	THE OBJECTION
Esther	The Hebrew text never names God, and its festival, Purim, isn't in the Torah. The Greek version adds explicitly religious material.
Song of Songs	Explicit love poetry with no overt theology. Reading it as an allegory of God and Israel, or Christ and the church, became the standard defense.
Ecclesiastes	Its conclusions sit awkwardly beside the rest of wisdom literature. Many scholars read its closing verses as a later frame.
Hebrews	Anonymous. The West accepted it more slowly because Pauline authorship couldn't be shown, and nearly all scholars now agree Paul didn't write it.
James	Slow to circulate. Later Luther ranked it, along with Hebrews, Jude and Revelation, below the rest and placed it at the back of his 1522 New Testament.

BOOK	THE OBJECTION
2 Peter	The most doubted New Testament book in antiquity, on grounds of style and attribution
Jude	Quotes 1 Enoch, a book outside the canon it ended up in
Revelation	Long resisted in the Greek East. It's accepted as scripture by the Eastern Orthodox churches and still isn't read aloud in their liturgy.

Revelation's place in Orthodox worship shows that a book can be fully canonical and still never be read aloud.

I.3 Genres

Genre determines what a passage is capable of establishing, and misreading it is the most common way a sincere reader reaches a confident wrong answer.

GENRE	WHAT IT'S TRYING TO DO	WHAT IT CAN'T ESTABLISH
Law	Set a community's obligations, ritual, civil and moral, usually without separating them	Timeless policy for every society
Narrative	Tell what happened, shaped for a purpose. It often reports behavior without endorsing it.	Approval. A story about polygamy isn't an argument for it.
Poetry	Make something felt through image and parallel lines	Doctrine built on a metaphor read literally
Wisdom	Teach how the world generally works, and (in Job and Ecclesiastes) how often it doesn't	Promises. A proverb is a pattern, not a guarantee.
Prophecy	Deliver a message to a particular people at a particular moment: indictment, warning, consolation, sometimes prediction	A calendar. Most prophecy addresses its own audience's present, though later readers often read it forward.
Gospel	Present a life so the reader has to reckon with it. Ancient biography with a purpose.	A transcript. Selection and arrangement are part of the form.
Letter	Address a live situation in a named community, often with sustained theological argument	Rules without context. You're reading one side of a conversation.
Apocalyptic	Reveal what's really happening behind visible power, in symbols, for people who can't say it plainly	Forecasts of technology. Its symbols were legible to its first readers.

Inside these genres are smaller forms. A genealogy is a claim about belonging, and Matthew's list deliberately includes four women. A lament is structured complaint, often addressed to God and often unresolved, and its place in the canon makes protest a sanctioned form of prayer. A parable usually turns on one hinge, and

allegorizing every detail is how it gets defused. A court history is a record written near power, so ask who commissioned it and what it leaves out.

Before a character quotes anything at anyone, ask what kind of writing it is, who it was addressed to, and what the speaker gains by treating it as a rule.

I.4 Translation

No original manuscript of any biblical book survives. What exists is thousands of copies, and they differ, overwhelmingly in spelling, word order and obvious copying slips, and occasionally in something substantive. Textual criticism reconstructs the earliest recoverable text from that evidence. A few famous passages are missing from the earliest manuscripts, and reputable Bibles say so in a footnote: the longer ending of Mark (16:9–20), the woman caught in adultery (John 7:53–8:11), and the Trinitarian clause in 1 John 5:7–8.

Hebrew was originally written without vowels. The vowel points were added centuries later by the Masoretes, scribes preserving how the text was read aloud, so a consonantal text can sometimes be vocalized more than one way. The New Testament is in Koine, the common Greek of the eastern Mediterranean. It isn't uniform: Mark's Greek is rough, and Hebrews' is polished.

Translations sit on a spectrum, and every point on it gives something up.

APPROACH	EXAMPLES	WHAT IT PRIORITIZES	WHAT IT GIVES UP
Formal ("literal")	KJV, NASB, ESV	The original's structure and ambiguity	Clarity in places. An ambiguity preserved is still one you have to resolve.
Middle	NIV, NRSV, CSB	Accuracy in natural English	Some seams
Functional ("dynamic")	NLT, Good News	What the sentence does, in idiomatic English	The translator has already chosen for you where the original was ambiguous
Paraphrase	The Message	Immediate impact	Any claim to precision

Most differences between translations aren't ideological. They come from a genuinely ambiguous word, a construction with no clean English equivalent, a choice about register, or a choice between manuscripts. Some differences are theologically motivated, and those are worth finding, but if you assume every difference is, you won't be able to spot the real ones.

The King James Version matters most for TKC. It was commissioned by James I in 1604, completed in 1611 by about fifty scholars working in six companies, and based heavily on the earlier Bishops' Bible. Its rules allowed no marginal notes except brief explanations of Hebrew or Greek words. The rule was a direct response to the Geneva Bible, the Puritans' Bible, whose notes James considered seditious. One Geneva note praised the Hebrew

midwives for disobeying Pharaoh (Exodus 1:19). Another faulted King Asa for only deposing his idolatrous mother instead of executing her (2 Chronicles 15:16). **INTERPRETATION** The Bible most English-speaking Protestants grew up with was shaped, in part, by a king who wanted the commentary on obeying kings taken out.

Chapters, verses and headings aren't scripture. Chapter divisions date to the early thirteenth century and are usually credited to Stephen Langton. Numbered New Testament verses first appeared in Robert Estienne's Greek New Testament of 1551. Jewish scribes had already marked verse divisions in the Hebrew text, though not numbered in the modern way. Section headings are modern editorial additions. Divisions make the text findable and quotable, and they also impose breaks the author didn't write.

There are four times when comparing English Bibles isn't enough and you need a lexicon, a commentary or a scholar:

- the argument rests on a single word
- translations split along denominational lines
- a footnote says the text is uncertain
- you're about to say what the original "really" means

I.5 Reading a passage in context

There are eight questions, and they should be asked in order. Most confident misuse of scripture comes from skipping one.

1. **What kind of text is this?** Genre first. It decides what the passage can establish.
2. **Who's speaking?** The narrator, a character, God as quoted, or a friend who turns out to be wrong. Job's comforters are in the Bible, and the book says they're mistaken.
3. **To whom?** A congregation with a particular problem, a king, a foreign nation, or one person.
4. **What comes before and after?** Read the paragraph, then the chapter. Most weaponized verses only work once the sentences on either side have been cut.
5. **What world produced it?** Empire, exile, monarchy, the household economy, and the legal status of women and slaves. The setting is often the subject.
6. **What do the words do?** Command, describe, lament, promise, threaten, concede or argue. Check two translations to see whether they agree.
7. **Who gains from this reading?** Ask it of every reading, including the one you prefer.
8. **What does this reading cost, and who pays?**

The method can't make anyone an authority. What it does is let you tell a reading that has done the work from one that skipped a step, and say which step was skipped.

I.6 Contested readings

Disagreement comes in different kinds, and the most important skill in this part is telling them apart.

1. **Serious scholarly dispute.** Specialists who know the languages and the manuscripts disagree, and each side can state the other's evidence. Examples are the meaning of *kephalē* and the authorship of Ephesians. In a scene, this earns two credible characters.
2. **Denominational disagreement.** Communities differ because of their confessions, their governance and inherited practice, not because the evidence is contested. Examples are who may be ordained and whether Revelation is read aloud.
3. **Open theological questions.** These are questions the text raises and leaves open, like what the conquest narratives say about God or whether Job is ever answered. They're where a novel does its best work.
4. **Unsupported claims.** Invented etymologies, a word supposedly mistranslated in every Bible, a council that decided something it never discussed. These aren't contested. They're wrong, though a character can sincerely believe one and build a life on it.

Eight fault lines run through the book. Each is a place where readers divide, and each is somewhere the Empire has a doctrine.

FAULT LINE	WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE	WHERE TKC TOUCHES IT	WHERE THE EMPIRE LANDS
Headship	The range of one Greek noun, how far the mutual-submission verse reaches, and what carries over from a Roman household code	The Binding and the household authority line (Part IX)	
Women speaking	Restriction passages in the Pauline letters set against the undisputed letters, which name women as coworkers, a deacon (Phoebe) and an apostle (Junia, Romans 16:7). Authorship and dating matter here.	The Vowed, and who may teach versus only recite	
Slavery	Texts that regulate slavery without abolishing it, and the principle a tradition later used to call it wrong	Labor tracks and designation	
Divine violence	Whether the conquest narratives are history, theological rhetoric, later reflection or ancient war convention	Every Imperial purge described as cleansing	
Obedience to rulers	Romans 13 set against the prophets, Revelation and the movement's own martyrs	The Empire's legitimacy	
Wealth	Whether the warnings target attachment, structural injustice or wealth itself	Blessing as evidence of favor in the Crownward	

FAULT LINE	WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN DISPUTE	WHERE TKC TOUCHES IT	WHERE THE EMPIRE LANDS
Purity and the body	Which regulations are ritual and which are moral, and who gets to sort them. The distinction is a later category applied to the texts, not a label printed in them.	The Designation, the Salt Ceremony, fertility review	
The end of things	Whether apocalyptic writing addresses its own moment, a future program, a recurring pattern, or worship	Whose reading is orthodox and whose is sedition	

I.7 Worked example: the household code (Ephesians 5:21–6:9)

Ephesians 5 is one of the passages most often cited in Christian teaching on marriage and male headship. The Empire's official line, "the husband leads, the wife supports, the household reflects divine order in miniature" (CR), is a version of one reading of it. Your files don't say which verses the Temple cites.

The letter. Ephesians presents itself as Paul writing to congregations in the Roman province of Asia. The words "in Ephesus" in 1:1 are missing from some of the earliest manuscripts (P46, Sinaiticus, Vaticanus), so many scholars think it was a circular letter. **CONTESTED** Many critical scholars think a follower of Paul wrote it after his death, citing differences in vocabulary, style and theology from the seven letters nearly everyone accepts as his (Romans, 1–2 Corinthians, Galatians, Philippians, 1 Thessalonians, Philemon). Others defend Pauline authorship. This matters for any argument that sets Ephesians 5 against Romans 16, where Paul greets women who lead and work in the churches.

The shape of the passage. The household instructions come at the end of a long sentence that begins in 5:18 with "be filled with the Spirit." A series of participles follows: speaking to one another in psalms, singing, giving thanks, and in 5:21, "submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ."

VERSES	ADDRESSED TO	IN SUMMARY
5:21	Everyone	Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ
5:22–24	Wives	Submit to your husbands as to the Lord. The husband is head of the wife as Christ is head of the church. "In everything."
5:25–33	Husbands	Love your wives as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her. Love them as your own bodies, and nourish and cherish them. Quotes Genesis 2:24.
6:1–3	Children	Obey your parents
6:4	Fathers	Don't provoke your children to anger

VERSES	ADDRESSED TO	IN SUMMARY
6:5–8	Slaves	Obey your earthly masters with fear and sincerity, as you would Christ
6:9	Masters	Do the same to them, stop threatening, and remember you share a Master in heaven

The husbands' section is the longest in the code. One count makes it about 116 Greek words to the wives' 40 (Mowczko). Husbands are commanded to love, three times (5:25, 28, 33), and they're never told to rule, enforce or correct. The headship sentence (5:23) is addressed to wives.

The missing verb. The earliest manuscripts disagree about whether 5:22 has its own verb. P46 and Codex Vaticanus have none, and Clement of Alexandria quotes it that way, so the verse borrows "submitting" from 5:21. Codex Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus and many others add "let them submit" (*hypotassesthōsan*). Most later Byzantine manuscripts add "submit" (*hypotassesthe*). **CONTESTED** Bruce Metzger's committee preferred the verbless reading, and Peter Gurry argues in *New Testament Studies* (2021) that *hypotassesthōsan* is original. Either way, 5:22 grows out of 5:21. The real disagreement is over what that connection means. The old Companion listed Sinaiticus as verbless, and that's wrong.

"Head" (*kephalē*). CONTESTED, and argued in print since the 1950s.

- **Source.** Stephen Bedale (1954) started the modern debate with "source or origin." Jerome Murphy-O'Connor, Catherine Kroeger and Philip Payne took it further.
- **Authority over.** Wayne Grudem surveyed 2,336 instances (*Trinity Journal*, 1985) and argued that "authority over" is well attested and "source" is rare. Joseph Fitzmyer (1989) agreed.
- **Prominence.** Richard Cervin's reply to Grudem (1989) is usually grouped with readings like "prominence" or "preeminence."

INTERPRETATION The senses overlap more than the debate's tone suggests. What isn't in dispute is the text itself, which defines the husband's role by self-giving and by nourishing, and never tells him to exercise authority.

"Submit" (*hypotassō*). The verb means to arrange oneself under someone. The New Testament uses it for citizens toward governing authorities (Romans 13:1), slaves toward masters (Titus 2:9), the Son toward the Father (1 Corinthians 15:28), and in Ephesians 5:21 everyone toward everyone. **INTERPRETATION** The middle voice is often read as describing something the subject does herself, but scholars disagree about how much weight that can bear. A voluntary act under a legal system where refusal is ruinous is voluntary only in a limited sense.

The household-code form. Aristotle's *Politics* (Book I) organizes household management around three pairs, master and slave, husband and wife, father and children, with the male head ruling each, and treats the household as the basic unit of the state. The New Testament has versions in Colossians 3:18–4:1, Ephesians 5:21–6:9 and 1 Peter 2:18–3:7. David Balch (*Let Wives Be Submissive*, 1981) argued that 1 Peter's code helped present the movement as respectable to suspicious outsiders. Ephesians departs from Aristotle by addressing wives, children and slaves directly as moral agents, by giving the stronger party obligations, and by grounding the arrangement in Christ instead of nature.

READING	WHAT IT HOLDS	ITS HARDEST PROBLEM
Ordered roles (complementarian)	The husband leads and the wife submits, and they're equal in worth	Nothing in the passage tells a husband to enforce anything, and 5:21 addresses everyone
Mutual submission (egalitarian)	5:21 governs the whole section	The instructions are still asymmetrical, and only wives are told to submit
Historically situated	A minority movement taught to live inside Roman household law	It needs a principle for deciding what carries over to other centuries
Accommodation	A step back from the earlier practice of Paul's undisputed letters	It depends on unsettled questions of authorship and dating

In American history. Proslavery preachers quoted the slave instruction in the same code (6:5) constantly, and enslaved and free Black Christians and abolitionists answered with Exodus, Galatians 3:28 and the prophets. In 1807 a London society printed *Parts of the Holy Bible, Selected for the Use of the Negro Slaves, in the British West-India Islands*. It kept 232 of the 1,189 chapters of a standard Protestant Bible, kept Ephesians 6:5, and dropped Galatians 3:28 (NPR, 2018). The modern American debate over Ephesians 5 took its current form in 1987, with the Danvers Statement (complementarian) and the founding of Christians for Biblical Equality (egalitarian). Those dates still need checking against primary sources.

For TKC

INFERENCE The Empire's scripture is in King James wording. Bell reads Proverbs 31:29 from the Book of Covenant as "Many daughters have done virtuously, but thou excellest them all" (**DR3**), which is the KJV text. A Bible shaped in part by a king's dislike of seditious margin notes is a fitting inheritance for an empire.

The Empire's official marriage theology is the ordered-roles reading, taken further than the passage goes. Male headship is written into civil law, enforced at the counter, and attached to a Binding no one has to consent to (**CR, DR3, DOM**). See Part IX.

POSSIBLE The Empire never has to change the canon. The old Companion listed six instruments that are all documented somewhere in history and none of which touches a word of scripture: the calendar, the public readings, clergy training, schoolbooks, regional editions with their own notes, and Broadcast commentary. A book can be fully canonical and still never read aloud, as Revelation is in Orthodox worship.

POSSIBLE The Temple's public reading of the household code starts at 5:22 and leaves out 5:21. The omission changes the passage's meaning without changing a word.

Working Questions

1. Which collection is the Book of Covenant: the 66, the 73, or something else? Does it have notes, and who wrote them?
2. Which passages are read aloud in Aurem's Temples, and which books are in the Book of Covenant but never read?
3. Does any character own a different Bible: a Geneva, a Catholic edition, one with the Apocrypha, or an old study Bible with footnotes? What happens if it's found?
4. How does the Empire's schoolbook tell the story of how the Bible came to be?
5. Which of the eight fault lines does Eden first notice from the inside, and in what scene?
6. Who in the cast can read Greek or Hebrew, and who learned it, and where?
7. Does the Temple print 5:21 in its household teaching, and how does it handle 6:5–9, the slave instructions, in Aurem?
8. Which unsupported claim (category 4) does the Empire teach as settled fact?

Working pages

PART I

DECIDED

DATE

PART II

THE BOOKS

This part is a working map of the library: a short entry for every book, then longer studies of the books TKC leans on hardest. The old Companion gave most books a full page. Here the quick map is compressed into two tables, and the depth goes to the focused studies (II.2) and the four Torah deep dives (II.3).

II.1 THE SIXTY-SIX BOOKS: A QUICK MAP

In the last column, every TKC use is POSSIBLE unless it carries a source tag.

The Hebrew Bible / Old Testament (39 books, in Protestant order)

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT ARGUES ABOUT	WHERE TKC MIGHT USE IT
Genesis	Origins, then one family across four generations. No state, no priesthood, only households.	Blessing as something scarce that's won or stolen. Naming as authority. Whether obedience is trust or terror (the binding of Isaac is left without comment).	Hagar, the first person in scripture to give God a name (16:13). Sister rivalry. See II.3.
Exodus	A labor population inside an empire, an escape, a covenant at a mountain	Whether freedom is the point or only the precondition for law. It doesn't soften the deaths of Egypt's firstborn.	Two midwives disobey a royal order and are named while the king isn't (1:15–21). DR3 uses 20:12 in the Assessment. See II.3.
Leviticus	Priestly law: sacrifice, purity, holiness, festivals	Holiness as separation, and the machinery needed to maintain it. It also contains the Jubilee (ch. 25).	The vocabulary of a surveillance theocracy: clean, unclean, permitted, withheld. See II.3.
Numbers	Two censuses and a generation dying in the wilderness	Legitimate authority and the cost of questioning it. Korah is swallowed by the ground, and Zelophehad's daughters win their petition (ch. 27).	A census as a tool of control. The Torah's precedent for women changing a law by asking. See II.2.
Deuteronomy	Moses' farewell speeches. The law restated for a settled people.	The retribution formula: obey and prosper, disobey and lose the land. It also limits the king (ch. 17) and releases debts (ch. 15).	The Empire's founding logic, ready-made. The law of the king indicts an emperor by inventory. See II.3.

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT ARGUES ABOUT	WHERE TKC MIGHT USE IT
Joshua	The conquest of Canaan and the division of the land	Whether divine promise licenses violence. Whether belonging is blood or allegiance (Rahab and the Gibeonites are kept).	Rahab, a woman with no standing who reads a political situation faster than her whole city. Achan as the case for collective punishment (ch. 7).
Judges	A cycle of apostasy, oppression and deliverance, each turn worse	Whether life without a king is freedom or collapse. It argues for monarchy by showing what happens to women when nobody's in charge.	Deborah's unquestioned authority. The closing verse (21:25) as an Empire slogan. The woman of chapter 19.
Ruth	Four chapters about two widows, set in the same era as Judges	Who belongs. A Moabite woman is written into David's line on purpose.	The most famous vow of devotion in scripture is spoken by a woman to a woman (1:16).
1–2 Samuel	The founding of the monarchy: Samuel, Saul, David	Whether an anointed king can be held to account. The text keeps David's crimes in.	Samuel's itemized warning about what a king will take (1 Sam 8). Nathan's "You are the man" (2 Sam 12:7). Tamar's case buried to protect the dynasty (2 Sam 13).
1–2 Kings	The kingdom from Solomon's temple to its destruction	Why the state fell, answered theologically: the kings were unfaithful	Naboth's vineyard, a man killed by correct legal procedure (1 Kgs 21). Huldah authenticating a scroll for the king (2 Kgs 22). The widow's oil (2 Kgs 4), used in DR3's Assessment.
1–2 Chronicles	The same monarchy retold after the exile	Lineage and legitimacy. David's affair with Bathsheba and Absalom's revolt are left out.	Two official histories of one reign, one of them cleaned up. See II.2.
Ezra	A return from exile under Persian license, a rebuilt temple, then a purity crisis	Belonging. The community is told to send away foreign wives and their children (ch. 9–10).	Ethnic purity legislated as obedience. See II.2.
Nehemiah	A Persian official rebuilds Jerusalem's walls	Walls, registers and enforcement, plus a debt crisis where the poor are pledging their children (ch. 5)	A reformer aimed at his own class. See II.2.
Esther	A Jewish orphan becomes queen of Persia. God is never named in the Hebrew text.	How to act with no power and no guarantee. Its ethics are improvised, and it never says whether they're admirable.	A state search that gathers young women for a year of preparation (ch. 2). Vashti, who says no in chapter one. DR3's Assessment uses Esther's crown.

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT ARGUES ABOUT	WHERE TKC MIGHT USE IT
Job	A blameless man loses everything, and three friends explain why he deserved it	Whether suffering is earned. God rebukes the friends who defended him with correct doctrine (42:7).	Scripture's own proof that the pious answer can be wrong.
Psalms	150 songs and prayers for worship, assembled over centuries	Whether God can be addressed honestly. About a third, by common counts, are laments.	The liturgy bank. Lament gives a character a sanctioned way to say the unsayable in public. Selah appears seventy-one times here.
Proverbs	Instruction for young men entering public life	Wisdom as learnable and generally rewarded. Wisdom herself is a woman present at creation (ch. 8).	The register of Imperial advice literature. Proverbs 31 is printed on the Assessment and read before the scores (**DR3**).
Ecclesiastes	A man with everything tests every route to meaning	Whether anything lasts. Its answer is hevel, vapor.	The voice of a courtier who's stopped believing the palace means anything. See II.2.
Song of Songs	Love poetry with no mention of God	Desire. The woman speaks most of the lines and is never rebuked.	Desire with scriptural standing. **CONTESTED** human love poetry or allegory.
Isaiah	A prophetic scroll covering the Assyrian crisis, the exile and the return	Whether God's people are the point or the instrument. It keeps widening the circle, to foreigners and to eunuchs. **CONTESTED** Most scholars see three sets of authors, and traditional readers one.	"Your hands are full of blood" (1:15). The suffering servant, a model of power the Empire can't use.
Jeremiah	Forty years of telling a capital it would fall	True prophecy against the licensed prophets, who promise the city can't be taken	Stocks, a cistern, a treason trial, and a scroll burned by the king and dictated again (ch. 36).
Lamentations	Five poems over the ruins of Jerusalem. Four are alphabetical acrostics.	Grief that refuses easy resolution	The register for the book's worst chapter. Scripture the Empire can't ban and can't use.
Ezekiel	Visions of a deported priest	Whether God can leave the temple. Whether guilt is inherited (ch. 18 says no).	The shepherds who fed themselves (ch. 34). See II.2.

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT ARGUES ABOUT	WHERE TKC MIGHT USE IT
Daniel	Court stories, then apocalyptic visions	Integrity inside a regime that owns your career. **CONTESTED** Most critical scholars date the visions to the persecution of the 160s BCE, and traditional readers date the book to the sixth century.	The manual for a character inside Imperial service. Serve well, refuse at one exact point, and make the refusal public.
Hosea	A prophet's marriage staged as national metaphor	Covenant as marriage, tender and disturbing at once	The theology underneath the Empire's language of wifely duty
Joel	A locust plague read as the day of the Lord	The spirit poured out on sons and daughters, old and young, and servants (2:28–29)	Prophecy democratized. A problem for any institution with a monopoly on speaking.
Amos	A herdsman from Judah preaching in prosperous Israel	Economic injustice. "I hate, I despise your festivals" (5:21).	The most quotable indictment of a comfortable religious state
Obadiah	One chapter against Edom	Complicity: standing by and profiting while a city falls	The bystander Dominion
Jonah	A prophet runs from his assignment and resents God's mercy to the enemy	Mercy extended to the enemy, and a believer who can't bear it	Satire inside scripture
Micah	Judgment on rulers who "eat the flesh of my people" (3:3)	Do justice, love mercy, walk humbly (6:8)	Three phrases that fit on a wall and indict whoever owns the wall
Nahum	The fall of Nineveh, the Assyrian capital	An empire's end, celebrated	What the provinces sing when the center burns
Habakkuk	A prophet argues with God about injustice	Faith as an argument you lose and stay in	Selah appears in its closing prayer (ch. 3)
Zephaniah	A day of judgment, officials named first	A purge with a humble remnant left	The purge sermon aimed at the Temple itself
Haggai	Rebuild the temple	State religion as a construction project	Religion and public works
Zechariah	Night visions, and a king who rides a donkey (9:9)	Power that refuses the warhorse	Ceremony as legitimacy

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT ARGUES ABOUT	WHERE TKC MIGHT USE IT
Malachi	Disputations with priests and people after the return	An audit of the priesthood, and men discarding their wives (2:14–16)	Corrupt clergy on the record in the Empire's own book. In Christian order it's the last book of the Old Testament.

Correction to the old Companion: it said "the last word of the Old Testament is an accusation against clergy." Malachi's closing verses are a promise about Elijah and a warning. The audit of the priests comes earlier, in chapters 1–2.

THE NEW TESTAMENT (27 BOOKS)

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT ARGUES ABOUT	WHERE TKC MIGHT USE IT
Matthew	A Gospel built in five teaching blocks, with heavy use of scripture	Jesus as the fulfillment of the Law. The genealogy names four women.	The Sermon on the Mount, the Lord's Prayer (6:9–13), and a whole chapter denouncing religious leaders by title (ch. 23)
Mark	The earliest and shortest Gospel	Discipleship as misunderstanding. The earliest manuscripts end at 16:8, with women fleeing the tomb afraid.	An ending later scribes found too abrupt and added to
Luke	A Gospel attentive to women, foreigners and the poor	Reversal. Mary's song (1:46–55). Jesus' first sermon announces release (4:16–30).	Names the women who funded the movement (8:1–3). See Part IV.
John	Long discourses, seven signs, high theology	Who Jesus is	His longest conversation is with a Samaritan woman (ch. 4). Mary Magdalene is the first witness sent to tell the men (ch. 20).
Acts	The early movement, from Jerusalem to Rome	Who's allowed in, and who decides (ch. 15). Shared property (2:44–45).	An unlicensed network meeting in women's houses (Lydia, ch. 16).
Romans	Paul's longest letter	Who belongs to God's people and on what basis	Romans 13 on authorities. Phoebe the deacon carried it, and Junia is greeted as "prominent among the apostles" (16:1–7).
1 Corinthians	A divided congregation	Status, food, sex, worship and resurrection	The silence passage (14:34–35). **CONTESTED** Some manuscripts place those verses after 14:40.

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT ARGUES ABOUT	WHERE TKC MIGHT USE IT
2 Corinthians	Paul defends his ministry	Authority through weakness	
Galatians	A furious letter about Gentile converts and the Law	Whether outsiders must assimilate to belong. "No longer slave or free, no longer male and female" (3:28).	The verse the 1807 Slave Bible removed (Part V)
Ephesians	A letter on the church as one body	Unity, plus the household code (5:21–6:9). CONTESTED authorship.	See I.7.
Philippians	Written from prison	Joy, and a hymn about power surrendered (2:5–11)	
Colossians	Christ over all powers, with a household code (3:18–4:1)	CONTESTED authorship	
1 Thessalonians	Paul's earliest surviving letter	The return of Christ	
2 Thessalonians	Correcting speculation about the end	CONTESTED authorship	
1 Timothy	Church order	Who may teach and lead. The restriction on women teaching (2:11–15). Enrolled widows (ch. 5).	The Temple's clergy handbook. CONTESTED authorship, along with the other Pastorals.
2 Timothy	A farewell letter from prison	Faithfulness under pressure	
Titus	Appointing elders	Order in households and churches	
Philemon	A short letter about Onesimus, an enslaved man	What a believer owes an enslaved brother	Argued over by both sides in the abolition debate
Hebrews	An anonymous sermon-letter	The old sacrificial system fulfilled	Nearly all scholars agree Paul didn't write it

BOOK	WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT ARGUES ABOUT	WHERE TKC MIGHT USE IT
James	Practical wisdom	Faith that does nothing, favoritism toward the rich (2:1–7), and withheld wages (5:4)	The bluntest economic text in the New Testament
1 Peter	To believers scattered and suspected	Endurance as outsiders, with a household code (2:18–3:7)	Balch's "respectability" reading (I.7)
2 Peter	Warnings about false teachers	The delay of the end	The most doubted book in antiquity (I.2)
1 John	Love and truth	Who is really in the community	
2 John	A short letter to "the elect lady"	Hospitality and false teachers	
3 John	A short letter to Gaius	A local power struggle over hospitality	
Jude	One chapter against intruders	Faithfulness. Quotes 1 Enoch.	
Revelation	Visions written from Patmos to seven churches under Rome	Whether empires end. The throne belongs to a slaughtered lamb (ch. 5).	Marks, seals, beasts, a bride and a city mourned by its merchants (ch. 18). "Come out of her, my people" (18:4).

II.2 Focused studies

These seven books get more than a line because TKC uses them as raw material: registers, petitions, licensed religion, court advice, a prophet whose body becomes the message, and twelve short books that argue with power. The old Companion's later spreads on these books were its most careful work, and several of them corrected its own earlier claims. Those corrections are kept.

NUMBERS: COUNTING, THE CAMP, AND TWO PETITIONS

The English name comes from the book's two censuses. The Hebrew name, *Bemidbar*, means "in the wilderness." The book moves in three stages: Sinai (chapters 1–10), the wilderness (11–21) and the plains of Moab (22–36).

The census. It counts men twenty and older who can fight, by ancestral house. Women and children aren't counted, and the Levites are registered separately. The totals are 603,550 in chapter 1 and 601,730 in chapter 26. Taken literally, that implies a population in the millions. **CONTESTED** Proposals include a different meaning for

the word translated "thousand," schematic totals, and later expansion. None is settled. By chapter 26 the whole first generation is dead except Caleb and Joshua (26:64–65). The camp in chapter 2 assigns every tribe a fixed position on four sides around the tabernacle, and the same arrangement is reproduced at every stop.

Miriam and Aaron (ch. 12). Both speak against Moses. Verse 1 uses a feminine singular verb while naming both of them, and verse 2 shifts to the plural. The occasion is Moses' Cushite wife, but the claim is about prophetic authority: has the LORD spoken only through Moses? Only Miriam is struck with a skin disease. Aaron pleads for her, and she's shut outside the camp for seven days. The people don't move on until she's brought back. The text never explains why only she is marked.

Two petitions. Korah's revolt (ch. 16) and the petition of Zelophehad's daughters (ch. 27) are a matched pair.

	KORAH, CH. 16	ZELOPHEHAD'S DAUGHTERS, CH. 27
Who	Korah the Levite, Dathan, Abiram and 250 men of standing	Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah and Tirzah, each named
What they ask for	Priestly access, contesting Aaron's office	Their dead father's inheritance, since he had no sons
How they ask	An assembly against Moses and Aaron, then a censer test	They stand before Moses, Eleazar, the chiefs and the whole congregation and state their case
Outcome	The ground opens, and fire consumes the 250	Granted, and made a general law of inheritance
Afterward	The sons of Korah survive as singers named in the Psalms headings	Chapter 36 fences the win: they must marry within their father's tribe

INTERPRETATION The pair shows which petitions an authority can hear. A petition that works through the system's own procedure, asks for a defined thing and leaves the office alone can be granted and written into law. One that contests the office gets the ground.

The wilderness middle. Ten scouts report the land can't be taken, and two dissent. The generation that believed the ten is denied entry. Moses complains at length and isn't punished. The bronze serpent Moses made at God's command (21:4–9) is destroyed centuries later by Hezekiah because people had started making offerings to it (2 Kgs 18:4), so a commanded object becomes one that has to be destroyed. The Balaam of chapters 22–24 blesses Israel, while later texts treat him as a villain. Joshua is commissioned publicly, by laying on of hands, while Moses is still alive (27:12–23).

1–2 CHRONICLES: THE RETELLING

The Hebrew title means "the events of the days." The Greek tradition called it *Paraleipomena*, "things left out." It's anonymous and generally dated to the Persian period. Whether the same writer produced Ezra–Nehemiah was long assumed and is now widely doubted. In the Jewish order it's the last book of the Bible, ending with Cyrus telling the exiles to go up. In Christian Bibles it sits after Kings.

It opens with nine chapters of genealogy, then David, Solomon and the temple, then the kings of Judah only, down to the exile. It draws on Samuel and Kings, often word for word.

MATERIAL	WHAT CHRONICLES DOES WITH IT
Bathsheba and Uriah	The story is left out. Bathsheba herself stays, in David's genealogy as Solomon's mother (1 Chr 3:5, as Bath-shua).
Amnon, Tamar and Absalom	Not retold
David's census	Kept, with the plague. Samuel says the LORD incited David (2 Sam 24:1), while Chronicles says an adversary did (1 Chr 21:1).
Levites, singers and musicians	Added at length, with guilds, rotas and duties
Hezekiah's Passover	Added, with invitations sent to the north
Manasseh	Added: Judah's worst king is taken to Babylon, prays and is restored (2 Chr 33:10–20)

> Correction to the old Companion: its early page said "Bathsheba is gone." The affair is gone, and she isn't.

The genealogies name more women than their reputation suggests. Sheerah builds three towns (7:24). Sheshan's daughter marries his Egyptian servant, and the line is traced through them (2:34–35). Bithiah, a daughter of Pharaoh, appears as a wife (4:18), and Jabez's mother names him (4:9).

INTERPRETATION "Cover-up" is one way to read the omissions. Another is a history written for worship, not for judgment, for readers who already knew the older account, which Chronicles cites. Hold both, and say which one you're using.

EZRA: RESTORATION UNDER LICENSE

Ezra and Nehemiah were transmitted as one book in the Hebrew tradition. Chapters 1–6 cover the first returns and the rebuilt temple, decades before Ezra appears. Chapters 7–10 bring Ezra, a priest and scribe sent from Babylon with a royal commission, and the crisis over intermarriage. Part of the book (4:8–6:18, 7:12–26) is in Aramaic, the Persian administrative language, and much of it is correspondence. **CONTESTED** Whether the documents are authentic, edited or composed is debated.

Nothing happens without imperial authorization. Cyrus issues the decree, and the temple vessels are counted back out of a royal treasury (ch. 1). A returnee register decides standing on arrival, and families who can't document their descent are kept from the priesthood until a ruling (2:59–63). At the foundation-laying, the young shout and the old weep, and the noise can't be told apart (3:12–13). The work is stopped by a letter calling the rebuilding a security risk. An archive search halts construction, and a later search reverses it (chs. 4–6). Local people who offer to help build are turned away (4:1–3).

In chapters 9–10, men of the community, priests and Levites included, are found to have married women of the surrounding peoples. An assembly agrees to send away the wives and the children born to them, a commission examines cases household by household, and about a hundred men are listed. A few men object (10:15). No woman speaks or is named, and nothing records where they went. The book simply stops. **CONTESTED** Whether "foreign" means ethnic, religious or a land dispute between returnees and those who never left, and whether the policy was carried out fully.

The old Companion's later spread refused the phrase "ethnic cleansing with a liturgy" because it imports a modern legal category into a text whose scale and terms are disputed. The refusal is kept here, and the ethical problem stays on the page in full.

NEHEMIAH: WALLS, REGISTERS AND A DEBT CRISIS

Nehemiah is cupbearer to the Persian king, a trusted court office with personal access, and then governor of the province. Much of the book is a first-person memoir with lists and documents set into it. He arrives with letters of safe passage, a timber requisition and a cavalry escort (2:7–9). He inspects the ruined walls at night and tells no one (2:11–16). The wall goes up in fifty-two days (6:15), built by named crews that include priests, goldsmiths, perfumers and one official working with his daughters (3:12). Half the workers are armed while the other half build (4:16). The opposition works through ridicule, invitations to a trap, an open letter accusing him of wanting to be king, and a hired prophet (ch. 6). Once the wall stands, he sets gate hours and immediately convenes a genealogical enrollment (ch. 7).

Chapter 5 interrupts the building for a debt crisis. People and their wives raise a great outcry. Some have mortgaged fields to buy grain, some have borrowed to pay the king's tax, and their children are being enslaved for debt, daughters first. The creditors are the community's own nobles and officials. Nehemiah confronts them publicly, orders the fields, houses and interest restored, makes them swear before the priests, and gives up his governor's food allowance.

INTERPRETATION The people say they borrowed to pay the king's tax. The reform reaches the local creditor and never the empire behind the tax.

The middle of the book is a day-long public reading of the law to men and women, with Levites "giving the sense" (8:8). **CONTESTED** Whether that includes translating into Aramaic. A sealed covenant follows with named signers (ch. 10). The book ends with enforcement. A temple room given to an outsider is cleared. Sabbath trade is shut down by locking the gates. Nehemiah reports contending with men over their marriages, cursing them, striking some and pulling out their hair (13:25), and driving out a high priest's grandson married into a rival governor's family (13:28).

ECCLESIASTES: THE COURT PASSAGES

The Hebrew name, *Qohelet*, means roughly "the one who assembles." It's a role, not a personal name. The speaker is "son of David, king in Jerusalem," but Solomon is never named. **CONTESTED** Most scholars date the Hebrew well after Solomon, to the Persian or Hellenistic period. A third-person epilogue (12:9–14) frames the book, and readers disagree over whether it endorses, domesticates or corrects what came before.

The word the book turns on is *hevel*, which appears about thirty-eight times. Its concrete sense is vapor or breath, something real that won't stay in your hand.

RENDERING	THE BOOK IT PRODUCES
"Vanity" (KJV, from the Latin vanitas)	Sounds like a sermon against pride, which isn't the sense
"Meaningless"	The strongest rendering and the most misleading, since the book keeps recommending things
"Futile"	Fits the labor passages and fits the enjoyment passages badly
"Vapor" or "breath"	Keeps the image. It shares its consonants with Abel's name in Genesis 4.

The book also tells its reader again and again to eat, drink, find good in work and enjoy life with the person you love (2:24, 3:13, 5:18, 9:7–9). A summary that keeps only the bleak half isn't a summary of this book.

The political passages read like someone who's watched government from inside. The oppressed have "no one to comfort them" (4:1). The difficult verses about one official watching over another (5:8–9) are translated very differently. "Keep the king's command" (8:2–4) is grounded in the fact that he has power, not that he has a right. "Do not curse the king, even in your thought... for a bird of the air shall carry the voice" (10:20). "The race is not to the swift" (9:11) directly denies that the strong reliably win.

INTERPRETATION Fatalism is useful to a government: if nothing can change, nothing needs changing. It also protects people. A woman who believes the outcome was never hers to decide can survive a verdict that would otherwise destroy her.

EZEKIEL: A PRIEST IN EXILE

Ezekiel, son of Buzi, is a priest deported to Babylonia in an early wave, about a decade before Jerusalem and the temple fall (1:1–3). His whole recorded ministry takes place in exile. He dates his oracles by years since King Jehoiachin was deported, not by Babylonian reigns. The book has three movements: judgment before the fall (1–24), oracles against the nations (25–32), and restoration after the fall (33–48).

He's made into a demonstration. He lies on one side and then the other for a set number of days, eats siege rations, shaves his head and divides the hair, and digs through a wall at dusk with a packed bag (chs. 4–5, 12). The divine glory leaves the temple in stages, from the sanctuary to the threshold to the east gate and out of the city (chs. 8–11), and returns by the same gate to a rebuilt house (ch. 43). He's told in advance that his wife, "the delight of your eyes," will die, and that he must not mourn her publicly, as a sign. She dies, and he obeys (24:15–27). The text gives her no name and no words.

Chapters 16 and 23 cast Jerusalem, and Samaria and Jerusalem as two sisters, as unfaithful women whose punishment is described as stripping, exposure and violence. The imagery is explicit. A large body of modern scholarship, much of it feminist (Renita Weems, Julie Galambush), argues the violence can't be treated as

incidental to the theological point. This entry doesn't quote it.

Chapter 18 rejects the exiles' proverb about sour grapes: the one who sins bears it, and a person who turns isn't held to their record. The chapter sits against Exodus 20:5 and Lamentations 5:7. The shepherds of chapter 34 fed themselves, wore the wool, ruled with force and didn't seek the lost. God removes them, takes over the work personally, and then promises one shepherd, "my servant David." The dry bones of chapter 37 are interpreted in the text itself as the whole house of Israel, a people who believe they're finished. The last nine chapters are a measured temple and a redivided land. **CONTESTED** Whether it's a blueprint, a vision or a protest.

THE TWELVE

In Jewish tradition the twelve short prophetic books are one book, written on a single scroll. "Minor" refers to their length. The Hebrew and Greek orders differ in the first six books, and the printed order isn't chronological.

BOOK	SETTING	THE POWER IN THE ROOM
Amos	Northern kingdom, 8th century	Prosperity before Assyria. A Judean speaking in the north.
Hosea	Northern kingdom, 8th century	Assyrian pressure and collapse
Micah	Judah, 8th century	Assyrian campaigns. A rural voice against the capital.
Nahum	Judah, 7th century	Nineveh about to fall or newly fallen
Zephaniah	Judah, 7th century	Late Assyrian period. Aimed at officials and merchants.
Habakkuk	Judah, late 7th century	Babylon rising, named as God's instrument
Haggai	Persian period	Dated by a Persian king's reign. Rebuilding the temple.
Zechariah	Persian period, with later material	The same moment as Haggai in chapters 1–8
Jonah	Set in the Assyrian era	Generally thought to be written later
Joel	Uncertain	No king named
Obadiah	Uncertain	Most often tied to the aftermath of Jerusalem's fall
Malachi	Persian period	A functioning temple with slack practice. "Malachi" may be a title ("my messenger").

Some of the old Companion's own corrections are kept.

- **Amos.** He calls himself a herdsman and a dresser of sycamore figs (7:14), which isn't a poor farmer and possibly a man of some means. His reply to the priest Amaziah is usually read as denying that he belongs to the professional prophetic guild. The Hebrew is terse and argued over.

- **Hosea.** "A God who keeps taking the nation back" is accurate to the reconciliation passages, and it leaves out the mechanism, which is a husband's authorized violence. Say both or neither.
- **Joel 2:28–29.** The third group is translated as household servants in some versions and enslaved men and women in others. Check translations before quoting.
- **Jonah.** Satire is one strong genre classification, not settled fact. Parable and didactic novella are serious alternatives.
- **Micah 6:8.** "Do justice, love mercy, walk humbly" is the answer to a question about what offerings can buy, after chapters about land seizure (2:1–2) and prophets who "cry peace" when they're fed (3:5).
- **Habakkuk.** God's reply doesn't answer the question that was asked, and the book ends in waiting, with a psalm that chooses trust without claiming anything has improved.
- **Nahum.** It's the voice of people who lived under Assyrian terror, watching it end. The gendered humiliation of the city is doing real work too.
- **Malachi.** The closing verses are about Elijah and turning parents' and children's hearts toward each other, not about priests.

INTERPRETATION The Twelve contains both kinds of prophet, the ones who tell an institution to finish its building (Haggai) and the ones who tell it its worship is worthless while it sells the poor (Amos 5:21–24). Any state that licenses a prophetic office is choosing from that range.

Micah offers a working test, as an application and not a command: prophets who "cry peace" while they're being fed (3:5). Follow the money, and see whose interest the message serves.

FOR TKC

- **The register as an instrument.** It appears in Numbers 1, the returnee list of Ezra 2, Chronicles' genealogies and Nehemiah 7, and it does a different job each time: muster, standing on arrival, continuity, enrollment. The Registry (Part VII.7) and the household authority line belong to the same family. **POSSIBLE** Chronicles keeps a register to include a scattered people, and the Empire keeps one to rank a gathered one.
- **Numbers 27 and 36.** A successful petition by women that's immediately fenced. **POSSIBLE** The Temple preaches Korah, and Zelophehad's daughters never appear in the schoolbook.
- **Ezra.** Religion licensed and funded by an empire, with the paperwork quoted. It's the closest biblical parallel to Governor-Prelates and a Temple that's also a branch of government.
- **Nehemiah 5.** Debt bondage of daughters inside the community, driven by the king's tax. **POSSIBLE** This is the shape of an Imperial economy in which a household loses a daughter to debt.
- **Ecclesiastes 10:20.** A surveillance proverb already in the canon. **POSSIBLE** The Temple teaches "keep the king's command" (8:2) as an endorsement and quotes only the last two verses of the book.
- **Ezekiel 18.** Guilt isn't inherited, which is a direct problem for a system that classifies children by household registration (**FR 32**) and punishes families for one member's offense.

- **Ezekiel 16 and 23.** The Empire already treats a woman's body as the place where a household's loyalty is measured. It has scriptural warrant for that, at length, in a major prophet. Whether the Temple quotes these chapters or keeps them from public reading is an open question.

WORKING QUESTIONS

1. Who in Eden's world is counted, who is only registered, and who is on no list at all?
2. Which petition is Eden bringing, Korah's or the daughters'? Does she know which one it looks like to the Temple?
3. Is there an Imperial bronze serpent, a relic once commanded and now worshipped, that someone will eventually have to destroy?
4. Does the Empire have an official history and an older one, a Kings and a Chronicles? Who has read both?
5. Write one of the women sent away in Ezra 10. Give her a name and the sentence the text didn't give her.
6. How does a household in Aurem lose a daughter to debt? Write the mechanism.
7. Who in the cast believes Ecclesiastes' fatalism sincerely, and who teaches it knowing better?
8. Does the Empire inherit guilt by household or by person, and does it say the same thing every time?
9. Which of the Twelve is in the Temple's approved readings, and which is never read aloud?
10. Is there a prophet in the novel, licensed or not? Who decides?

Working pages

PART II

DECIDED

DATE

II.3 Deep dives: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus and Deuteronomy

Four books of the Torah get full treatment because the Empire's founding logic draws on all four, and because the Trials name two of their three phases after Genesis and Exodus (**TR**). Numbers is covered in II.2. Each entry follows its book in order, marks where readers divide, and notes where the text has been put to uses it doesn't support. Corrections to the old Companion are stated where they fall. Content notes come before the hardest material, which is reported and not quoted at length.

GENESIS

Genesis runs from creation to Joseph's coffin in Egypt (50:26). Chapters 1–11, the primeval history, are about humanity as a whole. Chapters 12–50 follow one family across four generations. There's no king in the book, no priesthood and no temple. Everything happens in households, and households decide who inherits. **CONTESTED** Most critical scholars read Genesis as woven from more than one source, and the two creation accounts are the clearest seam. The classic documentary hypothesis has been heavily revised since the 1970s, and traditional readers hold to a single author.

Two creation accounts. The first runs from 1:1 to 2:3 (many scholars end it at 2:4a). The second starts at 2:4b and runs through chapter 2. They're placed side by side and never harmonized.

	GENESIS 1:1–2:3	GENESIS 2:4B–25
Name for God	Elohim, "God"	YHWH Elohim, "the LORD God"
Starting point	Dark water, the deep	Dry ground with no plants, no rain and no one to work it
Order	Light, sky, land and plants, lights, sea creatures and birds, land animals, then humans last	The human first, then a garden, trees, animals, then the woman
How God makes	By speaking and separating	By shaping dust, breathing, planting and building
Humans	Male and female created together, both in God's image (1:27)	The human (ha'adam) shaped from the ground (ha'adamah), the woman built from his side
Their task	Be fruitful, fill the earth, subdue it, have dominion (1:28)	Work the garden and keep it (2:15)
Food	Plants only, for humans and animals (1:29–30)	Every tree but one
Ends with	God resting on the seventh day	Two people naked and unashamed

The helper. In 2:18 God says it isn't good for the human to be alone and makes "a helper fit for him," ʿezer kenegdo. The noun ʿezer appears about twenty times in the Hebrew Bible, and most of those uses describe God helping Israel (Exod 18:4, Deut 33:29, Ps 121:1–2). It names the one who supplies what the other can't, so "helper" doesn't mean assistant. Kenegdo means "corresponding to him" or "opposite him." The word usually translated "rib" (tsela) means "side" nearly everywhere else, including the sides of the tabernacle (Exod 26:20). The man's line in 2:23 is the first human speech the Bible quotes, and it's a poem of recognition.

The primeval history in four movements.

MOVEMENT	CHAPTERS	WHAT HAPPENS
Creation	1–2	Two accounts of the making of the world and the first humans
The garden and after	3–4	The fruit, the pronouncements, the expulsion. Cain kills Abel. Lamech boasts of killing a man for wounding him (4:23–24).
The flood	5–9	A genealogy to Noah, the "sons of God" and human women (6:1–4), the flood, a covenant with every living creature, Noah's drunkenness and the curse on Canaan
Nations and Babel	10–11	The table of nations, the tower, and a genealogy that narrows to Terah, Abram and Sarai, who is barren (11:30)

Genesis 3. The serpent asks a question, and the woman answers it, adding that they mustn't even touch the tree (3:3). She eats and gives fruit to her husband, "who was with her" (3:6). God questions the man first. He blames "the woman whom you gave to be with me" (3:12), and she blames the serpent. The pronouncements follow, and only two things are cursed: the serpent (3:14) and the ground, "because of you" (3:17). The woman isn't cursed, and the man isn't either. Her pain in childbearing and his toil on the land are the same Hebrew noun, ʿitstsavon (3:16, 3:17). The man names her Eve, Ḥawwah, "mother of all living," only after the judgment (3:20). The chapter never uses the word "sin." Its first appearance is 4:7, spoken to Cain. The fruit is never called an apple. The apple came from a Latin pun on malum, which means both "evil" and "apple."

CONTESTED Genesis 3:16 ends "your desire shall be for your husband, and he shall rule over you." One reading takes it as prescription: God sets male rule in place as the order of things. The other takes it as description: the verse names what the break has done to the pair and what will now go wrong between them. The word for "desire" (teshuqah) appears only three times in the Hebrew Bible: here, in 4:7, where sin's desire is for Cain and he must rule over it, and in Song of Songs 7:10, where it's the man's desire for the woman. Readers who line up 3:16 with 4:7 hear a struggle for control. Readers who start from the Song hear longing. 1 Timothy 2:13–14 reads the garden story as grounds for restricting women's teaching, and how far that argument reaches is its own dispute (I.6).

Four generations and seven promises. The ancestral story runs through Abraham and Sarah, Isaac and Rebekah, Jacob with Leah, Rachel, Bilhah and Zilpah, and finally Joseph and his brothers, with Judah rising beside him. A promise is made or renewed at each turn.

TO WHOM	WHERE	WHAT'S PROMISED	SIGN OR TERMS
Noah and every living creature	9:8–17	No flood will destroy the earth again	The bow in the clouds. No conditions.
Abram at the call	12:1–3	A land he'll be shown, a great nation, a great name, blessing for "all the families of the earth"	He has to leave
Abram, between the pieces	15	Descendants like the stars, the land, and four hundred years of oppression in a foreign land first	A smoking firepot and a torch pass between the halves. God alone passes through, and Abram sleeps.
Abraham, circumcision	17	Many nations, kings, an everlasting covenant, a son by Sarah	Circumcision of every male, slaves included. Abram and Sarai are renamed.
Hagar	16:10–12, 21:17–18	Descendants too many to count, and a great nation from Ishmael	None
Jacob at Bethel	28:13–15	The land, descendants like dust, "I am with you"	Jacob answers with a conditional vow of his own (28:20–22)
Judah	49:8–12	His brothers will bow, and the scepter won't leave him	Spoken by the dying Jacob, not by God. The phrase "until Shiloh comes" (49:10) is one of the most disputed in the book.

Hagar's is the only one of the seven spoken to a woman. She's also the only person in scripture who gives God a name: El-roi, "the God who sees me" (16:13).

The family line. In every generation the promise passes over the firstborn.

FIRSTBORN	PASSED OVER FOR	WHERE
Cain	Seth, after Abel's death	4:25
Ishmael	Isaac	21:10–12
Esau	Jacob	25:23, 27
Reuben	Judah for rule and Joseph for the double portion	49:3–4, 8–12, 22–26 (and 1 Chr 5:1–2)
Manasseh	Ephraim, by Jacob's crossed hands	48:13–20
Zerah	Perez, who breaks out first at birth	38:27–30

Women decide several of these. Sarah demands Hagar's expulsion, and God tells Abraham to do as she says (21:12). Rebekah engineers Jacob's blessing and takes the risk on herself: "Upon me be your curse, my son" (27:13). Tamar forces Judah to acknowledge her son. **INTERPRETATION** Genesis treats inheritance as election and never as law. The legal heir is the one person the story reliably doesn't choose.

Six women.

Hagar. An Egyptian slave woman belonging to Sarai, who gives her to Abram as a wife (16:3). When Hagar conceives, Sarai "dealt harshly with her," the same verb used for Egypt's treatment of Israel (Gen 15:13, Exod 1:11–12), and Hagar runs. A messenger finds her at a spring, sends her back, and promises her descendants. She names God there. Years later, after Isaac is born, Sarah demands that Hagar and Ishmael be sent away, and Abraham sends them into the wilderness with bread and a skin of water (21:9–14). When the water runs out she puts the boy under a bush and sits a bowshot away so she won't have to watch him die. God hears the boy and opens her eyes to a well. She later takes a wife for Ishmael from Egypt (21:21), acting as the head of her own household. Paul reads her as an allegory of slavery (Gal 4:21–31). Phyllis Trible counted her story among the "texts of terror" (1984), and Delores Williams built a womanist theology on her survival in Sisters in the Wilderness (1993).

> Correction to the old Companion: Hagar isn't "driven out twice." She flees once (ch. 16) and is expelled once (ch. 21).

Sarah. Barren from her first mention (11:30). Twice Abraham presents her as his sister and she's taken into a king's household, in Egypt (12:10–20) and in Gerar (ch. 20). Isaac later does the same with Rebekah (ch. 26). She laughs at the promise of a son and then denies laughing (18:12–15). The name Isaac, "he laughs," is given by God (17:19) and by Abraham (21:3), and Sarah plays on it: "God has made laughter for me" (21:6). She's absent from the binding of Isaac (ch. 22), and her death follows in the next chapter. A later rabbinic tradition connects the two. Her grave is the first land Abraham owns in Canaan, the cave of Machpelah, bought for four hundred shekels (ch. 23).

Rebekah. Chosen at a well because she offers water to a stranger's ten camels (24:14–20). Her family asks whether she'll leave at once, and she answers "I will go" (24:58). **INTERPRETATION** The question put to her is about timing, and the marriage itself had already been agreed. She's barren for twenty years (25:20–26). When the pregnancy becomes painful she goes "to inquire of the LORD" herself and receives the oracle that the older will serve the younger (25:22–23). She acts on it in chapter 27. Her death is never narrated. Only her nurse's is (35:8).

Leah. Her eyes are described with a word, rakkot, that means either "weak" or "tender" (29:17). Her father substitutes her for Rachel on the wedding night. The text says she was "hated" (29:31, often softened to "unloved"), and the LORD opens her womb. She names her first four sons as running commentary on her marriage: seen, heard, joined, and finally Judah, "this time I will praise the LORD" (29:32–35). She buys a night with Jacob from Rachel for mandrakes (30:14–16). Levi and Judah are her sons, so the priesthood and the kings both come through her. She's buried beside Jacob at Machpelah (49:31). Rachel is buried by the road (35:19).

Content note: the next entry concerns sexual violence and a massacre.

Dinah. Leah's daughter, the only daughter of Jacob the text names. She goes out "to see the daughters of the land," and Shechem "took her and lay with her and humbled her" (34:1–2). **CONTESTED** Most translators and readers take this as rape. Lyn Bechtel (1994) argued the verb ʿinnah marks social shaming and not necessarily force, and others answer that the sequence of verbs signals force. Shechem then wants to marry her. Her brothers

demand that the city's men be circumcised, and while they're recovering Simeon and Levi kill them and take the women and children (34:25–29). Jacob complains about his reputation (34:30). The brothers get the last word: "Should he treat our sister like a prostitute?" Dinah never speaks, and no one asks what she wants. Anita Diamant's novel The Red Tent (1997) gives her a voice.

Tamar. Judah's daughter-in-law (ch. 38). Her husband Er dies. His brother Onan is obliged to give her a child in Er's name and won't, and he dies. Judah keeps his third son from her and sends her back to her father's house as a widow. She veils herself and waits on the road, Judah takes her for a prostitute, and she keeps his seal, cord and staff as a pledge. When she's found pregnant Judah orders her burned. She sends the pledge with a message: "Identify whose these are." Judah answers, "She is more righteous than I" (38:26). Her son Perez is an ancestor of David (Ruth 4:18–22), and Matthew names her in Jesus' genealogy (1:3). The custom she invokes, a brother's duty to a dead man's widow, becomes law in Deuteronomy 25:5–10. Onan's offense was refusing his brother an heir. Using his name for masturbation is a later misreading.

> Correction to the old Companion: Three matriarchs are barren, Sarah (11:30), Rebekah (25:21) and Rachel (29:31). The old text said "four of the central women." Leah is the fertile one.

> Correction to the old Companion: it says Sarah "names her son for laughter." God gives the name and Abraham confers it. Sarah's line about laughter comes after.

Joseph's famine administration. Joseph reads Pharaoh's dreams and is put over the land, and in the seven good years he stores a fifth of the harvest (41:34–36). When the famine comes, the people buy grain with all their money (47:14). When the money's gone they hand over their livestock (47:16–17). In the second year they offer the last thing they have: "Buy us and our land for food, and we with our land will be slaves to Pharaoh" (47:19). Joseph buys every field in Egypt for the crown. The Hebrew text says he moved the people into the cities (47:21), and the Samaritan Pentateuch and the Greek say he made them slaves. The priests keep their land and their allowance (47:22). A fifth of every harvest goes to Pharaoh permanently, "to this day" (47:26), and the people thank him: "You have saved our lives" (47:25). Meanwhile Jacob's family is given land in Goshen (47:11, 27).

Exodus opens on the result. A new king who didn't know Joseph sets Israel to forced labor building store cities (Exod 1:8–11). **CONTESTED** Whether Genesis presents Joseph's policy as wise government or as the start of a trap. The text praises his wisdom and records the cost without comment.

Fault lines and documented misuses. Some disputes over Genesis are real scholarly arguments, and they're marked CONTESTED above. Four uses of the book are a different kind of thing (I.6, category 4). The text doesn't say what they claim, and the history of the claim can be traced.

THE CLAIM	WHAT GENESIS SAYS	HOW IT WAS USED
The curse of Ham	Ham sees his drunken father naked and tells his brothers. Noah wakes and curses Canaan, Ham's son: "a servant of servants shall he be" (9:25). Ham himself isn't cursed. Nothing in the passage mentions skin, color or Africa. In Genesis, Canaanites are the people of the land Israel will occupy.	David Goldenberg's The Curse of Ham (Princeton, 2003) traces how later interpreters attached blackness to Ham and slavery to blackness, and shows that the supposed derivation of "Ham" from a word for "black" doesn't hold. The link was retrofitted onto the text. In the Atlantic world it became a standard justification for enslaving Africans, and Stephen Haynes documents its central place in American proslavery argument in Noah's Curse (Oxford, 2002).
The order of creation as permanent rank	In chapter 1 humans are made last and together. In chapter 2 the man is formed first and the woman last, with the animals in between.	Read as a decree that women are subordinate by nature, in law as well as in church. **INTERPRETATION** Order alone settles rank in neither account, since in chapter 1 the animals come before both humans. The separate New Testament argument from creation order (1 Tim 2:13) is CONTESTED and belongs to I.6.
Dominion as license	"Have dominion" (1:26, 28) sits beside "work it and keep it" (2:15). The humans of chapter 1 are given plants to eat, and meat isn't permitted until after the flood (9:3).	Read as permission to use the earth without limit. Lynn White Jr. made the charge famous in "The Historical Roots of Our Ecologic Crisis" (Science, 1967). The stewardship reading is the main answer to it.
Childbearing as a sentence	Pain is announced in 3:16, with the same noun as the man's toil in 3:17.	Read as a punishment women are meant to bear. When James Young Simpson began using chloroform in labor in 1847, he published an answer to religious objections to it. How widespread clerical opposition really was is debated by historians.

Other fault lines. CONTESTED: What "the image of God" (1:27) means. Proposals include a capacity like reason, a royal status, a function as God's representative, and a relationship. The text doesn't define it, and each definition has been used to decide who fully qualifies. **CONTESTED** What Sodom is condemned for. The narrative centers on a mob's violent demand against guests under a host's protection (19:4–11), and Ezekiel names Sodom's guilt as "pride, excess of food, and prosperous ease," and not helping the poor and needy (Ezek 16:49). **CONTESTED** The binding of Isaac (ch. 22). Readers have taken it as a test passed, a polemic against child sacrifice, or a horror the text leaves unexplained. Jon Levenson's The Death and Resurrection of the Beloved Son (1993) is the standard study. Sarah is never told, and in the narrative Abraham and Sarah never speak to each other again. **CONTESTED** The genre of chapters 1–11. Communities differ on whether they're historical report, theological narrative or a kind of writing modern categories don't divide well. Two other points belong here. Cain is protected with a mark instead of executed (4:15), and the first city in the book is founded by him (4:17). The flood story counts in two ways at once, pairs of animals and sevens (6:19–20, 7:2–3), forty days and a hundred

and fifty (7:17, 7:24), which source critics read as two accounts woven together. **INTERPRETATION** Babel (11:1–9) is a single people with a single language building so they won't be scattered. Read beside an empire that standardizes speech and centralizes construction, it's the most politically pointed story in the first eleven chapters.

The Dominions are named after a verse about stewardship of the earth (**AM**). **INFERENCE** The verse is Genesis 1:28 or its preface in 1:26, the only place in Genesis where humans are told to "have dominion." OPEN QUESTION: Who named the Dominions, and does the Temple teach the verse as rule or as care?

EXODUS

Exodus moves from a labor population inside an empire (1–15) to the wilderness (15–18) and to a covenant at Sinai, followed by the plans and building of the tabernacle (19–40). The golden calf (32–34) sits between the instructions for the tabernacle and its construction. The Hebrew name, Shemot, means "names," from its first line, and the Greek exodos means "a going out." There's no external record of the departure as the book describes it, and proposals for its date, scale and route vary widely. This entry treats the narrative as scripture and literature and prints no reconstruction as history.

Six women before Moses. The deliverance begins with women, and most of them act against a royal order.

WHO	WHERE	WHAT SHE DOES
Shiphrah and Puah	1:15–21	Ordered to kill Hebrew boys at birth, they "feared God" and didn't. Questioned by the king, they tell him Hebrew women give birth before the midwife arrives. God gives them households.
Moses' mother	2:1–10	Hides him three months, then puts him in a basket in the reeds. She's paid wages by Pharaoh's daughter to nurse her own son. She's named Jochebed only later (6:20, Num 26:59).
His sister	2:4–8	Watches from a distance and offers Pharaoh's daughter a Hebrew nurse
Pharaoh's daughter	2:5–10	Sees the child crying, pities him, knowingly keeps a Hebrew boy alive against her father's order, and names him
Zipporah	2:16–22, 4:24–26, 18:2–6	A Midianite priest's daughter, one of seven sisters Moses defends at a well. She saves his life in the night scene below.

The midwives are named, and the king isn't. **CONTESTED** "Hebrew midwives" (1:15) can also be read as "midwives to the Hebrews," which would make them Egyptian. The Greek translation reads it that way. Whether the sister of chapter 2 is Miriam is also a reading. She's unnamed there, and Miriam is first named in 15:20, as "the sister of Aaron."

Pharaoh's stated fear is numbers: the Israelites are "too many and too mighty" and might join an enemy (1:9–10). The policy escalates from forced labor to harsher labor to killing newborn boys.

The name. Moses is working his father-in-law's flock in Midian when the call comes. What God says first is a report of having heard: "I have seen the affliction of my people… I have heard their cry because of their taskmasters" (3:7). At the bush Moses asks what he should say when Israel asks God's name. The answer is ʾehyeh ʾasher ʾehyeh (3:14). "I am who I am" is the familiar rendering. The Hebrew verb form can also mean "I will be what I will be," so the tense is genuinely open. The next verse gives the name itself, four consonants, YHWH (3:15). Jewish readers traditionally don't pronounce it and say Adonai, "my Lord," or HaShem, "the Name," in its place. Most English Bibles print LORD in small capitals wherever it stands. "Jehovah" is a hybrid of the four consonants with the vowels of Adonai, and "Yahweh" is a scholarly reconstruction. **CONTESTED** 6:3 says God wasn't known to the ancestors by this name, though Genesis uses it throughout. Source critics take that as a seam between traditions, and others read it as a claim about the name's meaning being revealed.

Five objections. Moses argues back five times: who am I (3:11), what's your name (3:13), they won't believe me (4:1), I'm "heavy of mouth" (4:10), and please send someone else (4:13). Only the last makes God angry, and the answer is Aaron.

The bridegroom of blood. On the road back to Egypt, at a lodging place, "the LORD met him and sought to put him to death" (4:24). Zipporah takes a flint, cuts off her son's foreskin, touches it to "his feet," and says, "Surely you are a bridegroom of blood to me." After that the LORD lets him alone (4:24–26). The text doesn't say whom God was attacking (Moses or the son), whose feet she touched, why, or what her words mean. Every translation that makes it clear has supplied the answers. It's left unsmoothed here.

The signs. Ten plagues run from 7:14 to 12:30. Pharaoh's magicians match the first signs, the staff turned to a serpent, water turned to blood, and the frogs. They fail at the gnats and tell Pharaoh, "This is the finger of God" (8:19). From the flies on, the plagues distinguish Goshen from the rest of Egypt. Before the hail, some of Pharaoh's officials heed the warning and bring their workers and livestock inside (9:20–21), and before the locusts his courtiers beg him to let the people go (10:7). God says the last plague is judgment "on all the gods of Egypt" (12:12). **INTERPRETATION** The plague cycle works as a contest over legitimacy. Two powers claim the right to command the same people, and the narrative keeps score.

The hardening. Who hardens Pharaoh's heart is the oldest problem in the book, and it isn't resolved here. There are three patterns. God announces in advance that he'll harden it (4:21, 7:3). Pharaoh hardens his own heart (8:15, 8:32, 9:34). And in other places his heart simply "was hardened" (7:13, 7:22, 9:7). From the sixth plague on, the narrator mostly says God hardened it (9:12, 10:20, 10:27, 11:10). Three verbs share the work: one means to strengthen (ḥazaq), one to make heavy (kaved) and one to make hard (qashah), and translations flatten them into one word.

Passover. Chapter 12 sets up the rite before the escape happens. It belongs to the household. Each family takes a lamb, small households share one, the blood goes on the doorposts and lintel, and the meal is eaten standing, dressed for the road. There's no priesthood yet (Aaron and his sons aren't ordained until Lev 8). The rite builds in the child's question, "What do you mean by this service?" (12:26, 13:8, 13:14), and the answer is a story. A "mixed multitude" leaves with Israel (12:38), and a resident foreigner who's circumcised may keep the Passover under "one law" for native and stranger alike (12:48–49).

The Egyptians' silver. Israel "asks" (sha'al) the Egyptians for silver, gold and clothing and so "plunders" them (3:21–22, 11:2, 12:35–36). The King James "borrow" made it read like a trick. **CONTESTED** Ancient readers, Philo among them (Life of Moses 1.141) and a story in the Talmud (Sanhedrin 91a), took the goods as back wages for generations of unpaid labor. Others read the verb as asking for a parting gift, and still others take the plunder language at face value.

The firstborn. Content note: the death of children. The last plague kills every firstborn in Egypt, "from the firstborn of Pharaoh who sits on his throne to the firstborn of the slave girl who is behind the handmill," along with the firstborn of the livestock (11:5, 12:29). God had already called Israel "my firstborn son" (4:22–23). Afterward every firstborn male in Israel belongs to God and has to be redeemed (13:1–2, 11–16). The text doesn't soften the deaths, and neither does this entry.

The sea, twice. The crossing is told in prose (13:17–14:31) and then sung (15:1–18), with Miriam's short song after it (15:20–21).

	THE PROSE, CH. 14	THE SONG, 15:1–18
How the water moves	A strong east wind blows all night and drives the sea back	"At the blast of your nostrils the waters piled up" and the deeps congealed (15:8)
The Egyptians	Chariot wheels clog, the army turns to flee, the water returns at morning	Horse and rider are thrown into the sea, they sink like a stone, the earth swallows them
Israel	Walks through on dry ground with water as a wall on both sides	Barely appears. The song is about God.
Point of view	Narrator's	The enemy speaks in the first person (15:9)
How far it looks	Ends at the shore, with Israel believing	Looks ahead to Philistia, Edom, Moab and Canaan trembling, and to the sanctuary on God's mountain (15:14–17)

Miriam is called "the prophet" (15:20), the first woman in the Torah given that title. She leads the women with a hand drum and dancing, and her two lines match the song's opening. **CONTESTED** Frank Moore Cross and David Noel Freedman (1955) argued that the song was once credited to Miriam, and feminist scholars including Phyllis Trible and Rita Burns developed the case. One Qumran manuscript (4Q365) has extra lines of a song for Miriam after 15:21. It's a proposal and not a result. Many scholars count the song among the oldest poetry in the Bible, and that dating is also disputed. Miriam's challenge to Moses and her exclusion from the camp are in Numbers 12 (II.2). Micah 6:4 names her with Moses and Aaron as the three God sent.

After the sea. Three days later there's no water (15:22–25). By chapter 16 the people say they ate their fill of bread in Egypt (16:3). Manna comes with a rule that nobody can hoard it, since what's kept overnight rots, except on the day before the sabbath (16:16–30). Moses' father-in-law Jethro watches him judging the people alone

from morning to evening and tells him to appoint officers over thousands, hundreds, fifties and tens and hear only the hard cases himself (18:13–26). The first administrative structure in Israel comes on the advice of a Midianite priest.

Sinai in treaty form. George Mendenhall (1954–1955) compared the Sinai covenant to Hittite treaties between an overlord and a vassal: a preamble naming the overlord, a history of what he's done for the vassal, stipulations, provisions for keeping and reading the text, witnesses, and blessings and curses. The Decalogue opens with the first two parts in one sentence: "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery" (20:2). The law is presented as a response to something already done.

The text calls them the "ten words" (34:28) and doesn't number them. Traditions divide them differently.

TRADITION	FIRST	WHERE THE TENTH FALLS
Jewish	"I am the LORD your God who brought you out" (20:2)	All coveting is one commandment
Catholic and Lutheran	No other gods, with the ban on images inside it	Coveting is split in two, the neighbor's wife and then his goods
Reformed, Orthodox and Anglican	No other gods, with images as the second	All coveting is one commandment

The sabbath (20:8–11) is labor law as much as worship. Rest is owed to the son and daughter, the male and female slave, the livestock and the resident foreigner. Exodus grounds it in creation (20:11), and 23:12 adds a second reason, "that the son of your female slave and the foreigner may be refreshed." The coveting command lists the neighbor's house first and then his wife, his male and female slaves, his ox and his donkey (20:17), so the wife appears inside an inventory of what a man owns. Deuteronomy puts her first and gives her a separate verb (5:21). After the ten words, the people stand at a distance and ask Moses to speak to them instead of God, "lest we die" (20:18–19). The mediator is their request. The covenant is then read aloud, the people answer "All that the LORD has spoken we will do," and Moses throws blood on the altar and on the people (24:3–8).

The covenant code and its slavery laws. Chapters 21–23 begin with slavery. A Hebrew man who's bought serves six years and goes free in the seventh with nothing owed (21:2). If he came married, his wife leaves with him, and if the master gave him a wife, she and the children stay with the master (21:3–4). If he chooses to stay, his ear is pierced at the door with an awl and he serves for life (21:5–6). A daughter sold by her father "shall not go out as the male slaves do" (21:7). She has protections: she can't be sold to foreigners, and if the man takes another wife he can't reduce her food, clothing or her third due, ʿonah (traditionally "marital rights," and the meaning is disputed). If he does, she goes free without payment (21:8–11).

Penalties follow status. Kidnapping a person to sell is a capital crime (21:16). A master who beats a slave to death is punished, but if the slave survives a day or two there's no penalty, "for he is his money" (21:20–21). A slave who loses an eye or a tooth goes free (21:26–27). An ox that kills a free person is stoned and its negligent owner may die, and an ox that kills a slave costs its owner thirty shekels paid to the master (21:28–32).

The same code protects the vulnerable. A poor man's cloak taken in pledge must be returned by sunset, "for that is his only covering," and God says he'll hear the man's cry (22:26–27). Foreigners aren't to be wronged or oppressed, "for you know the heart of a foreigner, since you were foreigners in Egypt" (22:21, 23:9). Widows and orphans aren't to be mistreated (22:22–24). Impartiality runs both ways: don't favor the poor man in his lawsuit (23:3), and don't pervert the justice due to the poor (23:6).

All three of these things are true at once. The code doesn't abolish slavery. It also isn't a charter for the plantation system, since it limits Hebrew debt servitude, makes kidnapping a capital crime and frees a slave for a lost tooth, and American slave codes did none of those things. And it gives women fewer exits than men. Permanent slavery of foreigners is authorized elsewhere (Lev 25:44–46), and proslavery writers cited it.

The calf. While Moses is on the mountain, the people ask Aaron to make them gods. He collects their gold earrings and makes a calf, they say "These are your gods, O Israel, who brought you up out of Egypt," and Aaron announces "a feast to the LORD" (32:1–5). God tells Moses to stand aside so he can destroy them and make a great nation from Moses instead (32:10). Moses argues God down, appealing to what the Egyptians will say and to the promise to Abraham, and "the LORD relented" (32:11–14). He breaks the tablets, burns the calf, grinds it to powder and makes the people drink it. Aaron's explanation is that he threw the gold in the fire "and out came this calf" (32:24). The Levites rally to Moses and kill about three thousand people, and Moses tells them "today you have been ordained for the LORD," each at the cost of a son or brother (32:28–29). The priesthood's ordination is narrated as a purge. Moses intercedes a second time and offers to be blotted out of God's book with the people (32:31–32). Aaron isn't punished in Exodus. Deuteronomy later says God was angry enough with him to destroy him and Moses prayed for him (Deut 9:20). Afterward Moses asks to see God's glory and is told no one can see God's face and live. He's put in a cleft of the rock and sees God's back (33:18–23). What he receives instead of the face is a spoken self-description, "merciful and gracious, slow to anger," forgiving, and by no means clearing the guilty (34:6–7), which later books quote and argue with (Num 14:18, Jonah 4:2, Ps 103:8). The tablets are rewritten, and the book ends with the tabernacle built from offerings so generous that the people have to be told to stop bringing them (36:5–7).

Reception. Enslaved Christians in America made Exodus their book. "Go Down, Moses," with its refrain "Let my people go," was among the first spirituals published, in 1861, and Harriet Tubman was called Moses (Albert Raboteau, Slave Religion, 1978). Slaveholders cited the covenant code and Leviticus 25 to show that scripture regulates slavery and therefore allows it. In 1776 Benjamin Franklin proposed a Great Seal showing Pharaoh drowning in the sea under the motto "Rebellion to tyrants is obedience to God." James Cone made the God of the exodus the center of A Black Theology of Liberation (1970) and God of the Oppressed (1975). Robert Allen Warrior's "Canaanites, Cowboys, and Indians" (Christianity and Crisis, 1989) read the story from the side of the Canaanites, since the exodus ends in a conquest, and for Native Americans the Puritans had played Israel. The civil rights movement preached it constantly. Martin Luther King Jr.'s last sermon, in Memphis on April 3, 1968, ended at Moses' view of the promised land: "I may not get there with you."

LEVITICUS

Leviticus is priestly instruction delivered at Sinai. The English name comes from the Greek for "about the Levites," though Levites as a group appear only once (25:32–33). The Hebrew name, Wayyiqra, means "and he called." The book falls into offerings (1–7), the ordination of the priests (8–10), purity (11–15), the Day of Atonement (16), the Holiness Code (17–26, named by August Klostermann in 1877) and vows (27). Jacob Milgrom's three-volume Anchor commentary (1991–2001) is the standard reference behind this entry.

The offerings as a sliding scale.

OFFERING	HEBREW	WHAT IT IS	BUILT-IN SCALE
Burnt offering	ʿolah	The whole animal is burned	A bull, a sheep or goat, or birds (1:3, 10, 14)
Grain offering	minḥah	Flour, oil and frankincense. A handful is burned and the rest goes to the priests.	Cooked or raw, in several forms
Well-being offering	shelamim	A shared meal. The fat is burned and the worshipper's household eats the meat.	Herd or flock
Purification offering	ḥatta't, traditionally "sin offering"	Its blood purges the sanctuary of the impurity a person's error or condition has caused (Milgrom)	Graded by status: a bull for the anointed priest or the whole community, a male goat for a leader, a female goat or lamb for anyone else. Two birds for someone who can't afford a lamb, and a tenth of an ephah of flour for someone who can't afford birds (4:1–5:13).
Reparation offering	'asham, traditionally "guilt offering"	For misuse of holy things and for defrauding a neighbor under oath	The full amount is restored to the wronged person, plus a fifth, before the ram is offered (5:14–6:7, numbered 5:14–26 in Hebrew Bibles)

INTERPRETATION In the reparation offering, a wrong against a person can't be cleared at the altar until the person has been repaid with interest.

Purity. Ritual impurity in Leviticus is a status, not a moral judgment. It comes from childbirth, bodily discharges, contact with a corpse and certain skin conditions. It's temporary, it spreads by contact, and it ends with washing, waiting and sometimes an offering. Priests incur it too, and they live under stricter rules about corpses (21:1–4, 10–12). Mary Douglas (Purity and Danger, 1966) read the system as a map of categories, with the unclean as whatever doesn't fit its place. She revised her reading of Leviticus in Leviticus as Literature (1999). Jonathan Klawans (Impurity and Sin in Ancient Judaism, 2000) distinguishes ritual impurity, which is unavoidable and not sinful, from moral impurity, which comes from grave sins like sexual transgression, idolatry and bloodshed, defiles the land, and can't be washed off. The later Christian division of the law into moral and ceremonial parts doesn't map neatly onto either.

Dietary law. Chapter 11 sorts animals by stated criteria (split hooves and chewing the cud, fins and scales) and never explains them. Proposals include hygiene, separation from neighbors and Douglas's anomaly reading. None is settled, and the only reason the text gives is holiness (11:44–45).

Skin inspection. Chapters 13–14 concern tsara'at, a surface condition that can appear on skin, cloth and the walls of houses (13:47, 14:33). It isn't leprosy in the modern sense (Hansen's disease), though the Greek lepra carried that name into English. A priest inspects, isolates the person for seven days, inspects again and declares. Someone declared unclean tears their clothes, leaves their hair loose, covers their upper lip, calls out "Unclean, unclean," and lives alone outside the camp (13:45–46). Restoration involves two birds, one killed and one released into the open field (14:4–7). Miriam's skin disease in Numbers 12 belongs here (II.2).

Chapters 12 and 15 together. A woman who gives birth to a son is impure for seven days, and then for thirty-three more days she can't touch holy things or enter the sanctuary. For a daughter both numbers double, to fourteen and sixty-six (12:1–5). The text gives no reason, and the explanations offered over the centuries are guesses. At the end she brings a lamb and a bird. If she can't afford a lamb, two birds will do (12:8). Luke records Mary bringing the poorer offering after Jesus' birth (Luke 2:22–24).

Chapter 15 sets out discharges for men and women in matching sections: an abnormal male discharge, a seminal emission, intercourse, menstruation and abnormal female bleeding. A man with an abnormal discharge brings the same two birds as a woman with abnormal bleeding (15:14, 15:29). After intercourse both partners are impure until evening (15:18). Seven days of impurity follow menstruation (15:19). The chapter states its own purpose: to keep the people from defiling the tabernacle among them (15:31). The woman with bleeding who touches Jesus' clothes (Mark 5:25–34) lives under 15:25–30 (Part IV).

The Day of Atonement. Chapter 16 opens "after the death of the two sons of Aaron." In chapter 10 Nadab and Abihu had offered "strange fire," and fire came out from the LORD and consumed them. Aaron was silent (10:1–3). He's forbidden to mourn in public, and the next instruction bans wine for priests on duty (10:6–9). On the Day of Atonement the high priest enters the inner sanctuary once a year. The blood of the purification offerings is sprinkled to cleanse the sanctuary itself "because of the uncleannesses of the people of Israel and their transgressions" (16:16). The sanctuary is purged first, and the people's atonement follows from that. Two goats are chosen by lot. One is for the LORD. Over the other, "for Azazel," the high priest confesses all the people's iniquities with both hands on its head, and it's sent into the wilderness (16:8–10, 21–22). The day applies to the resident foreigner as well as the native (16:29).

CONTESTED What Azazel means. William Tyndale coined "scapegoat" in 1530, reading the word as "the goat that departs." Other proposals are a place name for a rugged cliff, a wilderness demon (Azazel is a fallen angel in 1 Enoch 8–10), and an abstract noun meaning complete removal.

Content note: the next entry concerns sexual law and death penalties.

Chapters 18 and 20. Chapter 18 is addressed to Israelite men. It opens with a refusal of the practices of Egypt and Canaan (18:3) and closes with the land vomiting out peoples who did them (18:24–30). The list is mostly forbidden unions with kin, set out from the man's side: his mother, his father's wife, his sister, his granddaughter, his aunt, his daughter-in-law, his brother's wife. A man's own daughter isn't named, which scholars have long

noticed and explained in different ways. The list also forbids marrying a wife's sister as a rival while the wife lives (18:18), sex during menstruation (18:19), a neighbor's wife (18:20), giving children to Molech (18:21), lying with a male "as with a woman" (18:22), and sex with animals (18:23), the only verse in the chapter that makes a woman the one acting. Chapter 20 assigns penalties to many of the same acts, often death.

The word to'evah, usually "abomination," covers the whole list (18:26–30). It's used elsewhere for what Egyptians found offensive about eating with Hebrews (Gen 43:32), for unclean food (Deut 14:3), for dishonest weights (Deut 25:16, Prov 11:1) and for haughty eyes and a lying tongue (Prov 6:16–19).

CONTESTED Leviticus 18:22 and 20:13. The positions are printed here and no verdict is given.

POSITION	WHAT IT HOLDS	ASSOCIATED WITH
A general prohibition	The verses forbid all sexual relations between men, and the New Testament carries the principle forward (Rom 1:26–27, 1 Cor 6:9)	Robert Gagnon, The Bible and Homosexual Practice (2001), and most historic church teaching
A specific act	The phrasing points narrowly to anal intercourse between men	Saul Olyan, "And with a Male You Shall Not Lie the Lying Down of a Woman" (1994). Jacob Milgrom also limited the law to that act and to Israelite men in the land.
The Code's own concerns	The chapter is organized around lineage, seed and category boundaries, and the verse has to be read inside that system	Various, building on Douglas
Applicability	Whether the Holiness Code binds Christians at all, and by what principle some of its laws are kept and others aren't	The moral, ceremonial and civil division (below) and its critics

Chapter 19 in full. "You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy" (19:2) opens a chapter that puts ritual and ethics side by side without ranking them. Revere your mother and father (mother first) and keep the sabbaths (19:3). Leave the edges of the field unharvested, and leave the gleanings and the fallen grapes, for the poor and the foreigner (19:9–10). Don't steal, lie or swear falsely (19:11–12). Don't hold a hired worker's wages overnight (19:13). Don't curse the deaf or put a stumbling block before the blind (19:14). Don't favor the poor or defer to the great in judgment (19:15). Don't slander, and don't stand by while your neighbor's blood is shed (19:16). Don't hate your brother in your heart, reprove him openly, take no vengeance and bear no grudge, and "love your neighbor as yourself" (19:17–18). Don't mix kinds of cattle, seed or cloth (19:19). Don't make your daughter a prostitute (19:29). Rise before the aged (19:32). The foreigner living with you is to be treated as a native, "and you shall love him as yourself, for you were foreigners in Egypt" (19:33–34). Keep honest scales, weights and measures (19:35–36). Jesus quotes 19:18 as the second great commandment (Mark 12:31), and Ruth gleans under 19:9 (Ruth 2).

Content note: 19:20–22 concerns an enslaved woman. A man who lies with an enslaved woman promised to another man isn't put to death, "because she was not free." There's an inquiry or a penalty (the word is disputed), and he brings a reparation offering. The text says nothing about her.

Chapter 25: the sabbath year and the Jubilee. Every seventh year the land rests (25:1–7). After seven times seven years, a horn sounds on the Day of Atonement and the fiftieth year is proclaimed: "proclaim liberty throughout the land to all its inhabitants" (25:10). Land returns to the families it came from, "for the land is mine, and you are foreigners and sojourners with me" (25:23). Houses in walled cities are an exception (25:29–30). An impoverished Israelite isn't charged interest (25:35–37), and one who sells himself isn't to be worked as a slave, but as a hired worker until the Jubilee (25:39–43).

The boundary of that protection is printed in the same chapter. Male and female slaves may be bought from the surrounding nations and from foreigners living in the land. They're property, they can be passed to children as an inheritance, and "you may make them slaves forever" (25:44–46). Whether the Jubilee was ever practiced is unknown. Sabbath years are attested in the Second Temple period (Neh 10:31, 1 Macc 6:49, 53), and there's no clear record of a Jubilee being kept.

Chapter 21: bodies at the altar. A descendant of Aaron with a "blemish" (mum) may not offer at the altar: a man who's blind or lame, has a mutilated face or a limb too long, a broken foot or hand, a hunched back, dwarfism, a defect of the eye, scabs or crushed testicles (21:16–23). He may still eat the priests' food. The same word marks animals unfit for sacrifice (22:20–25). Saul Olyan (Disability in the Hebrew Bible, 2008) reads the passage as one place where the Hebrew Bible ranks bodies. The same chapter restricts whom a priest may marry, more tightly for the high priest, limits which dead he may mourn, and orders that a priest's daughter who becomes a prostitute be burned (21:7–15). Priests and their households live on set portions of the offerings (22:10–16). The blemish list sits two chapters after 19:14, which protects the deaf and the blind from abuse. Isaiah 56:3–5 later promises eunuchs a name in God's house better than sons and daughters.

Salt. Every grain offering is seasoned with salt: "you shall not let the salt of the covenant with your God be missing" (2:13).

Reception. Inside the Bible, the release language of chapter 25 returns in Isaiah 61:1–2, and Luke has Jesus read that passage in the synagogue at Nazareth and say it's fulfilled today (Luke 4:16–21). John Bergsma's The Jubilee from Leviticus to Qumran (2007) traces its later uses. Rabbinic Judaism developed the purity, dietary and agricultural laws into living practice, sabbatical-year observance included. In Acts 15 the early church decided which of these laws applied to non-Jewish believers. The Pennsylvania State House bell, cast in 1752 and recast in 1753, carries 25:10. Abolitionists adopted it in the 1830s. The Anti-Slavery Record called it the Liberty Bell in 1835, and a poem William Lloyd Garrison's Liberator printed in 1839 spread the name.

> Correction to the old Companion: it says the word "jubilee" is on the bell. The bell reads "Proclaim LIBERTY Throughout all the Land unto all the Inhabitants Thereof" with the reference Lev. XXV. v X. The word jubilee isn't on it.

The Jubilee 2000 campaign for cancelling the debts of the poorest countries took its name and its argument from chapter 25. Thomas Aquinas divided the Old Testament law into moral, ceremonial and judicial precepts (Summa Theologiae I–II, q. 99), and the Westminster Confession (1646, ch. 19) made the same division Reformed doctrine. Christians who keep some of Leviticus and set aside the rest usually rely on that division, and the text doesn't contain it. The book's purity vocabulary, "unclean" and "leper" above all, has long been used outside its system as an insult for people a community wants to keep out.

DEUTERONOMY

Deuteronomy is Moses' farewell on the plains of Moab, a series of speeches that restate the law for a generation about to enter the land without him. It ends with his death and a burial place no one knows (34:5–6). The Hebrew name, Devarim, means "words." Moshe Weinfeld's Anchor commentary and his Deuteronomy and the Deuteronomic School (1972) stand behind much of this entry.

The name. "Deuteronomy" comes from the Greek deuteronomion, "second law." It's a mistranslation. In 17:18 the king is told to write for himself "a copy of this law" (mishneh hattorah hazzot), and the Greek translators rendered the phrase as "this second law." The book presents itself as the same law restated, not a new one.

Josiah's scroll. In 2 Kings 22–23, during repairs to the temple under King Josiah (about 622 BCE), the high priest Hilkiah finds "the book of the law." The king tears his clothes when it's read to him and sends to the prophet Huldah, who authenticates it. A covenant renewal, a purge of outlying shrines and a centralized Passover follow. W. M. L. de Wette argued in 1805 that the scroll was a form of Deuteronomy, since the reform matches its demands. **CONTESTED** Most critical scholars accept some version of the link. They divide over whether the core was written for the reform, came south from the northern kingdom after 722 BCE, or was largely shaped later, during and after the exile. Traditional readers attribute the book to Moses.

Treaty form.

TREATY PART	WHAT IT DOES	IN DEUTERONOMY
Preamble	Names the sovereign and the setting	1:1–5
Historical prologue	Recounts what the sovereign has done	1:6–4:43, recalled again through 5–11
General stipulation	Demands exclusive loyalty, called "love"	5–11, with the Shema at 6:4–5
Specific stipulations	The laws	12–26
Deposit and public reading	Where the text is kept and when it's read	10:1–5 and 31:9–13, 24–26. It's read every seventh year, at the feast of Booths, to men, women, children and foreigners.
Witnesses	Called to observe the oath	Heaven and earth (4:26, 30:19, 31:28, 32:1)

TREATY PART	WHAT IT DOES	IN DEUTERONOMY
Blessings and curses	The consequences of keeping or breaking it	27–28

William Moran (1963) showed that "love" in ancient treaties names political loyalty, which is the sense of "you shall love the LORD your God" (6:5). **CONTESTED** Whether the closer model is the Hittite treaties of the second millennium BCE (Mendenhall), which would support an early date, or the Neo-Assyrian treaties of the seventh century (Weinfeld), which fit Josiah's time.

Chapter 6 and the household. The Shema, "Hear, O Israel" (6:4), is followed by its instructions: keep these words on your heart, teach them to your children, talk about them sitting in your house and walking on the road, lying down and rising, bind them on your hand and write them on your doorposts and gates (6:6–9). Teaching happens in the household, and no priest is present. When a child asks what the laws mean, the answer is a story: "We were Pharaoh's slaves in Egypt" (6:20–21).

Two Decalogues. Deuteronomy 5 repeats the ten words with differences. Exodus says "remember" the sabbath and Deuteronomy says "observe" it. Exodus grounds it in creation, and Deuteronomy grounds it in the memory of slavery: "that your male and female slave may rest as well as you. You shall remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt" (5:14–15). Deuteronomy's coveting command puts the wife first, gives her her own verb, and adds the neighbor's field (5:21).

The prosperity warning. The people are told they'll inherit cities they didn't build, houses full of good things they didn't fill, cisterns they didn't dig, and vineyards and olive trees they didn't plant, and they're warned that this is exactly when they'll forget (6:10–12). Later the warning is sharper. Don't say "my power and the might of my hand have gotten me this wealth" (8:17).

Chapter 12: one place. Sacrifice is limited to "the place the LORD your God will choose" (12:5). Jerusalem is never named. Every other altar is to be destroyed. Because people far from the one altar can no longer slaughter there, ordinary slaughter at home is made secular: eat meat in your towns as you like, and pour out the blood (12:15, 20–25). The tithe can be converted to money if the place is too far, carried there, and spent on "whatever you desire, oxen or sheep or wine or strong drink," eaten in celebration with the household and the Levite (14:22–27). Every third year the tithe stays in the local towns for the Levite, the foreigner, the fatherless and the widow (14:28–29, 26:12). The local Levites are left without altars and appear again and again as dependents "within your gates." A Levite who comes to the central place may serve there equally (18:6–8). In Josiah's reform, the priests of the outlying shrines didn't serve at the Jerusalem altar (2 Kgs 23:9), so the law and the history don't match.

Chapter 17: the law of the king. Israel may set a king over itself, one God chooses and one of their own people (17:14–15). He must not acquire many horses or send the people back to Egypt to get them. He must not acquire many wives, "lest his heart turn away." He must not acquire much silver and gold (17:16–17). When he takes the throne he's to write out a copy of the law for himself, keep it with him and read it all his life, "that his heart may not be lifted up above his brothers" (17:18–20). There's no enforcement clause. Nobody is named who

can remove a king who breaks it. Solomon breaks all four: he imports horses from Egypt (1 Kgs 10:28–29), marries Pharaoh's daughter (3:1) and has seven hundred wives (11:3), and makes silver "as common as stone" in Jerusalem (10:27).

Chapter 15: release. Every seventh year debts between Israelites are released. A foreigner's debt can still be collected (15:1–3). The chapter says both "there will be no poor among you" (15:4) and "the poor will never cease out of the land" (15:11). The first is conditional on obedience, and the second is the reason for the command to open your hand. Jesus quotes the second (Mark 14:7). A Hebrew man or a Hebrew woman sold into service goes free in the seventh year (15:12). They're not to be sent away empty-handed. The master must supply them liberally from the flock, the threshing floor and the winepress, "as the LORD your God has blessed you" (15:13–14). A slave who chooses to stay has the ear pierced with an awl against the door, and "to your female slave you shall do the same" (15:16–17). **CONTESTED** Whether Deuteronomy revises Exodus 21:7, which kept a sold daughter from going free, or addresses a different case. An escaped slave who takes refuge with you isn't to be returned to his master and may live wherever he chooses (23:15–16). Neighboring law ran the other way. The Code of Hammurabi makes harboring a runaway slave a capital offense (§§15–20). In Jeremiah 34 the king and the people of Jerusalem release their slaves under siege and then take them back, and Jeremiah answers with a "release" to the sword. Nehemiah 5 is the debt crisis of II.2.

Content note: the next two entries concern war law, the killing of noncombatants and captive women.

Chapters 7 and 20: war. The seven nations of the land are to be "devoted to destruction," ḥerem, with no covenant and no mercy (7:1–2). The stated reason is contamination: "they would turn away your sons from following me" (7:4), and later, "so that they may not teach you to do according to all their abominable practices" (20:18). The same chapter that commands destruction also forbids intermarriage with these peoples (7:3), which assumes they'll still be there. War law has two tiers. A distant city is offered peace first, and if it accepts, its people become forced labor. If it refuses, its men are killed and its women, children and livestock taken (20:10–15). The cities of the land itself are to leave nothing alive that breathes (20:16–17). Fruit trees may not be cut down in a siege: "Are the trees in the field human, that they should be besieged by you?" (20:19). Some men are sent home before battle: those with a new house, an unharvested vineyard, a fiancée, or fear (20:5–8).

A woman taken captive may be married. She shaves her head, cuts her nails, puts off her captive's clothing and mourns her father and mother a full month first. If her husband later doesn't want her, he must let her go where she wants and may not sell her, "since you have humbled her" (21:10–14).

The ḥerem idea isn't unique to Israel. The Moabite king Mesha's inscription (about 840 BCE) boasts of devoting an Israelite town to his god and killing seven thousand people. **CONTESTED** Archaeology doesn't support a sweeping conquest. Excavations at Jericho (Kathleen Kenyon, 1950s) and Ai found no city of the right period matching the account, and many archaeologists see Israel emerging gradually in the central highlands. Judges 1 itself lists peoples not driven out. Kenneth Kitchen, James Hoffmeier and others defend more of the narrative's historical basis.

Chapters 22 and 24: marriage law. A husband who claims his bride wasn't a virgin goes before the elders, and her parents bring out the cloth from the wedding night. If his charge is false, he's fined a hundred shekels, paid to her father, and can never divorce her. If it's true, she's stoned (22:13–21). If a betrothed woman lies with another man in the city, both are put to death, on the reasoning that she didn't cry out. If it happens in the field, only the man dies, because "she cried out and there was no one to rescue her" (22:23–27). The field gives her the benefit of the doubt, and the city doesn't. A man who seizes an unbetrothed virgin pays her father fifty shekels of silver, must marry her, and can never divorce her (22:28–29). Exodus 22:16–17 lets the father refuse the marriage. Deuteronomy doesn't mention refusal.

A husband who finds "some indecency" in his wife may write her a certificate of divorce and send her away (24:1). She may remarry, but she can't later return to the first husband (24:2–4). The certificate lets her prove she's free. Only the husband can initiate. The phrase ʿervat davar, "some indecency," divided the rabbis: the house of Shammai allowed divorce only for unchastity, and the house of Hillel for anything, even a spoiled dish (Mishnah Gittin 9:10). Jesus is asked about this verse (Matt 19:3–9, Mark 10:2–12).

Comparison with neighboring law cuts in more than one direction. The Middle Assyrian Laws (A 55) let a raped virgin's father hand the rapist's own wife over to be raped and give his daughter to the rapist in marriage. The Code of Hammurabi (§130) puts to death a man who rapes a betrothed virgin and declares the woman free of blame. "Better than its neighbors" and "good" are different claims, and some neighbors weren't worse.

Chapters 27–28: blessings and curses. Twelve curses are pronounced from Mount Ebal with the people answering "Amen" (27:11–26). Almost every one names an act done where no one can see it: an idol made in secret, a boundary stone moved, a blind man sent the wrong way, justice perverted for the foreigner, the orphan and the widow. In chapter 28 the blessings take fourteen verses (28:1–14) and the curses fifty-four (28:15–68), a little under four times as many. The curses end with siege, famine so severe that parents eat their children (Content note: 28:53–57), and the people shipped back to Egypt to be sold, with no buyer (28:68). Several curses closely match the Succession Treaty of Esarhaddon of Assyria (672 BCE), known from copies found at Nimrud and from another found at Tell Tayinat in Turkey in 2009. The sky as bronze and the earth as iron (28:23) is one match, and the order of several curses is another. **CONTESTED** Hans Ulrich Steymans argues that Deuteronomy 28:20–44 borrows directly from the treaty, and others think the shared language came through common treaty convention. Chapter 13, which requires reporting and executing even a brother, son, daughter, wife or friend who secretly urges the worship of other gods (13:6–11), has close parallels in the treaty's demand that subjects report anyone, even family, who speaks against the king. The book closes its argument with a choice: "I have set before you life and death, blessing and curse. Therefore choose life" (30:19). Just before, it says the commandment "is not too hard for you, neither is it far off. It is not in heaven" (30:11–12).

Two smaller laws matter for TKC. "Fathers shall not be put to death for their children, nor children for their fathers" (24:16). Wages are owed to a poor worker, Israelite or foreigner, the same day, before sunset (24:14–15).

> Correction to the old Companion: it says the curses run "more than four times as many" verses as the blessings. Fifty-four to fourteen is just under four times.

Reception. Martin Noth argued in 1943 that Joshua through Kings form a "Deuteronomistic History," written to judge Israel's kings by this book's standard, especially chapter 12. Jesus answers all three temptations with Deuteronomy (Matt 4:1–11, quoting 8:3, 6:16 and 6:13) and names the Shema as the first commandment (Mark 12:29–30). John Winthrop closed "A Model of Christian Charity" (1630) by paraphrasing 30:15–20, "Therefore let us choose life," and Puritan covenant theology read New England through the book's terms (Part V). Abolitionists cited 23:15–16 against the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850, and 24:7 with Exodus 21:16 against kidnapping and the slave trade.

FOR TKC

- **The phases are named for these books.** Phase One belongs to the Temple and is called Genesis, "Who are you?" Phase Two belongs to the Crown and is called Exodus, "How smart are you?" (TR). POSSIBLE The Crown's phase is named for the book about a ruler who loses an argument to two midwives and a labor force.
- **Eden's name and the Eve problem.** Eden is named for the garden (TL), and the Broadcast's name for its narrative against a candidate whose intelligence becomes the story is the Eve problem: the woman "blamed for asking rather than thanked" (TR). INTERPRETATION Genesis 3 doesn't curse the woman and doesn't blame her for asking. The blame in the chapter comes from the man (3:12). The Broadcast's narrative runs his defense.
- **Genesis 3:16 in the Doctrinal Assessment.** The Temple's marriage theology (CR) depends on reading 3:16 as prescription. POSSIBLE One of the three questions the Prelate writes for Eden personally (TR, with the name changed under FR 33) asks her to explain 3:16, and the grade depends on which reading she gives.
- **The Dominions' name.** The Dominions are named after a stewardship verse (AM). INFERENCE Genesis 1:28. POSSIBLE Whoever chose the name knew the grant is over the earth and its creatures and never over other people, and chose it anyway.
- **Leah.** Eden's sister Leah is a Commonwife under Temple review for not conceiving within the Covenant timeline (TL, MEN). In Genesis, Leah is the fertile wife, and the three barren matriarchs are the women the promise runs through. POSSIBLE The Temple's review quotes "be fruitful and multiply" and never mentions Sarah, Rebekah or Rachel.
- **Reassignment and Tamar.** Miriam was reassigned to another man's household after Thomas left (FR 0), and how reassignment works is deliberately left open. POSSIBLE The Temple grounds Commonwife reassignment in levirate logic (Gen 38, Deut 25:5–10), which in scripture protects a widow's claim, and the Empire uses it to keep an abandoned wife inside the quota.
- **Hagar and naming.** Hagar is the one person in scripture who names God. Celeste gave Eden a second name that's used only in the house (TL). INTERPRETATION Both are names the official record doesn't hold.
- **Succession.** Crest's claim came through survivorship and not birth order, and Dorian is the rightful heir's son (FR 35, 39). POSSIBLE The Temple preaches Jacob over Esau and Judah over Reuben to make the 2061 succession sound like election.
- **Joseph's administration.** POSSIBLE: Imperial schoolbooks teach Joseph as the model administrator and the Fracture Years as Egypt's famine, with the Coalition as the steward who stored grain. The Restoration Act

made rights conditional (TL), and Genesis 47 is the scriptural picture of a people trading freedom for food and thanking the crown for it.

- **The curse of Ham.** Aurelia was built over Atlanta's Black memory (DOM, X.1). OPEN QUESTION Does the Temple teach the curse of Ham? If a character uses it, the narration has to know it's a documented misuse (WR 38–39).
- **Shiphrah and Puah.** Professionals with licensed access who refuse the one thing the license exists for, and answer the king with a statement he can't check. POSSIBLE The model for a Vowed officer who quietly doesn't comply. INTERPRETATION Eden's Public Testimony, where every sentence is defensible and the whole is incendiary (TR), is the midwives' answer to Pharaoh at book length.
- **Exodus 20:12 in the Assessment.** Draft Three turns "Honor thy father and thy mother" into a question about reporting an Unbound woman who housed her children without male authority (DR3). Celeste is that woman. In Exodus the command sits in a Decalogue grounded in liberation from forced labor.
- **Miriam.** Eden's mother carries the name of the first woman the Torah calls a prophet, whose song the text gives to Moses first and whose exclusion from the camp is in Numbers 12 (II.2). In Numbers the camp doesn't move until she's brought back.
- **Passover and the household.** Passover and Deuteronomy 6 put the founding rite and religious teaching in the household, with no priest. INTERPRETATION Celeste's kitchen table (TL), the Salt Ceremony and the old way of burial (DOM, VIII.4) are household religion of exactly that kind, which is why the Temple can't license them.
- **Salt.** Leviticus 2:13 requires "the salt of the covenant" on every grain offering. POSSIBLE The women's Salt Ceremony (DOM) uses the Temple's own covenant salt, and nobody in the Temple has noticed.
- **Inspection.** A priest inspects, isolates, re-inspects and declares (Lev 13–14). POSSIBLE The Vowed household assessments (MEN) and the Designation (DOM) borrow the procedure, with a moral weight that Leviticus keeps out of it.
- **Leviticus 21 and the Trials.** POSSIBLE: The Temple cites the blemish list as precedent for screening candidates, and for Mountain's physical assessment at Designation (DOM).
- **The scapegoat.** POSSIBLE: The Broadcast's antagonist narrative, assigned to the candidate who threatens a comfortable outcome (TR), is the Empire's Azazel goat. The confession is spoken over her and she's sent out.
- **Leviticus 25:10.** POSSIBLE: The Empire can't read the Liberty Bell verse aloud, and in Pacific, where people remember trying to leave (DOM), somebody still can.
- **Deuteronomy 13.** The command to report a family member who secretly worships other gods matches the Assyrian loyalty oath's demand to report anyone, family included, who speaks against the king. POSSIBLE It's the Temple's warrant for the Vowed as surveillance (CR) and for the Assessment's reporting question (DR3).
- **Deuteronomy 24:16 and FR 32.** "Children shall not be put to death for their fathers." The Empire classifies children by household registration (FR 32). INTERPRETATION Deuteronomy, Ezekiel 18 (II.2) and the Empire disagree about where guilt lives.

- **Runaways.** Deuteronomy 23:15–16 forbids returning an escaped slave. **POSSIBLE** Ungoverned crossings through Sable (**DOM**) are the case the verse was written for, and the Temple never reads it in that Dominion.
- **Josiah's scroll and the ledger.** In 2 Kings 22 a document found during repairs, authenticated by a prophet, turns a king. Azrael found the ledger in the east wing archive, Dorian removed it with the Covenant of Dissent, and Judah has been looking for the Dissent since before his brother's exile (**TL, FR 41–43**). **POSSIBLE** Judah is a Josiah who hasn't found his scroll.
- **The emperor and Deuteronomy 17.** POSSIBLE: The Emperor is declared the law's author and not its subject. The law of the king forbids horses, Egypt, wives and treasure and requires the king to copy the law by hand. The Temple can't delete it, so it exempts him, and that exemption is the theological center of the Empire.
- **What the Temple teaches and what it shelves.** POSSIBLE throughout. Built from the old Companion's three "Dominion's" spreads.

BOOK	WHAT THE TEMPLE CIRCULATES	WHAT IT LEAVES OUT OF PUBLIC TEACHING
Exodus	The sea, as a deliverance already accomplished in the founding	Chapter 1, where the resistance starts with two midwives who lied to a king and were rewarded
Exodus	The commandments from the second clause on	The preamble, which grounds the right to command in having ended someone's forced labor
Exodus	Sabbath as public observance	Sabbath as a limit on what an owner can take from a worker, an animal or a foreigner
Exodus	Moses the obedient lawgiver	Moses arguing God out of a decision twice
Leviticus	Holiness as personal purity, and chapters 18 and 20 as household law	Chapter 25 entire, and the harvest edge, the same-day wage and the interest ban of chapter 19
Leviticus	Inspection and readmission as public order	That impurity is temporary, mostly non-moral, and falls on priests too
Leviticus	Restitution as an offering paid to the Temple	That the wronged person is paid first, plus a fifth
Deuteronomy	One sanctuary, one calendar, one authorized place	The third-year tithe that stays in the town
Deuteronomy	The curses of chapter 28 as the explanation for every disaster	The law of the king
Deuteronomy	Teaching as the Temple's office	Chapter 6, where parents teach at home with no priest present
Deuteronomy	The conquest chapters as precedent for cleansing a province	The runaway-slave clause and the seventh-year release

INTERPRETATION The pattern is the same in all three. The Empire keeps Deuteronomy's enforcement and drops its constitution, keeps the machinery of exclusion in Leviticus and drops the machinery of release, and teaches the exodus as finished so that only the obedience half applies now.

SUPERSEDED The old Companion's Exodus page marks "Prelate Huldah's office" as canon and gives that office the Empire's handling of the liberation material. FR 33 renamed the Prelate. The working name is Prelate Aurelia, which is POSSIBLE. Whether the Prelate's office manages the Temple's teaching of Exodus is itself only POSSIBLE now.

WORKING QUESTIONS

1. What does the Book of Covenant print at Genesis 3:16, and what does the Aurelia Temple preach from it on the Sunday before a Binding?
2. Write the Doctrinal Assessment question on 3:16 that the Prelate gives Eden. What answer gets full marks, and what answer does Eden give?
3. Who named the Dominions, and did that person know what Genesis 1:28 says? Was it piety or a private joke?
4. Which of Genesis's six women does Celeste teach Eden about at the kitchen table, and which one does the Temple teach girls at Designation age?
5. What does Leah Osei know about the Genesis Leah, and who told her?
6. How does the Temple explain Commonwife reassignment from scripture, if it explains it at all? Who signed Miriam's?
7. Which licensed professional in the Empire is a Shiphrah, and what does she say when she's summoned?
8. What does the Empire's own liberation liturgy say God delivered the people from, and when does a character stop believing it?
9. Which household in the cast would a Jubilee free, and who would lose by it?
10. What disqualifies a body from service in the Empire? Who wrote the list, and does it cite Leviticus 21?
11. Who in the cast has read Deuteronomy 17 all the way through, and what did they do the next day?
12. If the Covenant of Dissent turned up in the Registry tomorrow, who would be asked to authenticate it, the way the prophet Huldah authenticated Josiah's scroll?

Working pages

PART II

DECIDED

DATE

PART III

People of the Text

This part gives one entry per person. Each entry says what the text actually gives, where, what's disputed, and how the person has been used. Women and minor figures get the same weight as patriarchs and kings, because the Empire's curriculum doesn't give them that weight and the scripture often does. People already worked through in II.3 (Sarah, Rebekah, Leah, Dinah, Shiphrah and Puah, Zipporah) are cross-referenced instead of repeated. The old Companion's profiles were built around what each person is "usually reduced to," and that's kept where it's accurate. Its errors are corrected in the entries.

Many women in the collection have no name: Lot's wife, Jephthah's daughter, the woman of Judges 19, the woman with the hemorrhage, the woman at the well, the woman who anoints Jesus. Who got a name in the record tells you who was doing the recording. The Empire's Registry (VII.7) makes the same choices.

Content note: several entries below report sexual violence, a child sacrifice and a murder. They're reported, not quoted at length.

Women of the Hebrew Bible

Eve (Genesis 2–4). The woman of the garden, called ishshah, "woman," by the man (2:23) and named Ḥawwah, "mother of all living," only after the judgment (3:20). Her conversation with the serpent is the first dialogue in the Bible. She's the one who names her sons, and both times she speaks of God: "I have gotten a man with the LORD" (4:1) and "God has appointed for me another offspring" (4:25). For what Genesis 3 does and doesn't say, see II.3. The blame came later and from outside the chapter. Sirach (a deuterocanonical book, about 180 BCE) says "from a woman sin had its beginning, and because of her we all die" (25:24). 1 Timothy 2:14 says "Adam was not deceived, but the woman was deceived." Tertullian (about 200 CE) told women "you are the devil's gateway" (On the Apparel of Women 1.1). Paul, in his undisputed letters, puts the responsibility on Adam: "sin came into the world through one man" (Rom 5:12).

Hagar (Genesis 16, 21). The Egyptian slave woman given to Abram, who flees once, is expelled once, and is the only person in scripture to give God a name (II.3). She's usually reduced to a subplot, the mistake made while waiting for the promise. Paul makes her an allegory of slavery under the law (Gal 4:21–31). Islamic tradition honors her as Hajar, the mother of Ishmael, and pilgrims at Mecca retrace her run between two hills in search of water. Delores Williams built womanist theology on her survival in the wilderness (Sisters in the Wilderness, 1993).

Tamar (Genesis 38). The widow who forces Judah to acknowledge her claim (II.3). She's usually skipped in public reading, or remembered as the woman who pretended to be a prostitute. Scripture remembers her otherwise. The elders bless Ruth's marriage with "may your house be like the house of Perez, whom Tamar bore

to Judah" (Ruth 4:12), and Matthew names her in Jesus' genealogy (1:3). Her method was evidence. She didn't accuse Judah. She sent back his seal, cord and staff and let him identify them.

Miriam (Exodus 2, 15, Numbers 12, 20, Micah 6:4). Moses' sister, if the unnamed girl at the river is her (II.3). The first woman the Torah calls a prophet. She leads the women's song at the sea (Exod 15:20–21), challenges Moses' sole authority and is struck with a skin disease while Aaron isn't (Num 12, II.2), and dies at Kadesh. The next verse says there was no water for the congregation (Num 20:1–2), and the rabbis built on that the tradition of Miriam's well, which traveled with Israel for her sake (Talmud Ta'anit 9a). Micah names her with Moses and Aaron as the three God sent (6:4). Her name in Greek is Mariam, which is where every Mary in the New Testament gets hers.

Deborah (Judges 4–5). Already a prophet and the judge of Israel when she's introduced, hearing cases under a palm tree (4:4–5). The text gives no emergency to excuse it and offers no apology. **CONTESTED** 'eshet lappidot can mean "wife of Lappidoth" or "a woman of torches." She summons the commander Barak, who says he won't go unless she goes with him. She goes, and tells him the glory will go to a woman (4:8–9). It goes to Jael, a civilian who kills the enemy general Sisera with a tent peg in her own tent (4:17–22). The victory song of chapter 5, among the oldest poetry in the Bible, calls Deborah "a mother in Israel" (5:7) and ends with Sisera's mother at her window, imagining her son delayed by dividing the spoil, "a womb or two for every man" (5:28–30). She's usually reduced to an exception, the woman God used because no man was available. The text doesn't say that anywhere.

> Correction to the old Companion: it says Deborah composed the song. The heading credits it to "Deborah and Barak" (5:1). The song speaks of her in the first person in places (5:7), and who composed it isn't stated.

Rahab (Joshua 2, 6). A woman of Jericho called a zonah, usually translated "prostitute" (Josephus calls her an innkeeper, Antiquities 5.1.2), whose house is built into the city wall. She hides two Israelite spies, lies to the king's messengers, and gives a political assessment of the war more accurate than anything her own city has produced: "I know that the LORD has given you the land" (2:9–11). She bargains for her whole household, and the spies swear an oath and tell her to tie a scarlet cord in her window (2:12–21). When the city falls, the spies bring her family out, and "she has lived in Israel to this day" (6:22–25). The New Testament remembers her three times, as an ancestor of David in Matthew's genealogy (1:5), for her faith (Heb 11:31) and for her works (Jas 2:25). She's almost never named without her profession.

> Correction to the old Companion: Rahab's deal isn't "in writing." It's an oath and a scarlet cord. The text also says only that the spies brought her out, and nothing about her house being left standing when the wall fell.

Ruth and Naomi (the book of Ruth). Naomi leaves Bethlehem in a famine with her husband and two sons, and in Moab all three men die. She tells both Moabite daughters-in-law to go home. Orpah goes, and Ruth refuses: "Where you go I will go… your people shall be my people, and your God my God" (1:16–17). The most famous vow of devotion in scripture is spoken by a woman to a woman. Naomi comes home and tells the women of the town to call her Mara, "bitter" (1:20). Ruth gleans as a foreign laborer under the harvest-edge law (Lev 19:9–10), and Boaz protects her. Naomi sends her to the threshing floor at night with instructions to uncover his feet and wait, "and he will tell you what to do" (3:4). Ruth doesn't wait. She tells him to spread his cloak over her because he's a redeemer (3:9), the same word, kanaf, he'd used for the wings of the God under whom she'd taken refuge

(2:12). **CONTESTED** How much "uncover his feet" implies. Boaz settles the matter with a nearer kinsman at the city gate (ch. 4). When the son is born, the women of the town name him and say "a son has been born to Naomi" (4:17), and they tell Naomi that Ruth is better to her than seven sons (4:15). The son is David's grandfather. Deuteronomy 23:3 bars Moabites from the assembly, and the book writes one into the royal line. Boaz calls Ruth an ʾeshet ḥayil, "a woman of worth" (3:11), the same phrase as Proverbs 31:10, and in the Leningrad Codex, the oldest complete Hebrew Bible, Ruth comes directly after Proverbs. The vow is read at weddings, almost always between a man and a woman.

> Correction to the old Companion: Ruth doesn't propose on Naomi's coaching. Naomi told her Boaz would tell her what to do, and Ruth spoke first.

Hannah (1 Samuel 1–2). One of two wives. The other, Peninnah, has children and provokes her for years. Her husband asks, "Am I not more to you than ten sons?" (1:8). She prays at the sanctuary with her lips moving and no sound, and the priest Eli thinks she's drunk. She corrects him (1:12–16). She vows her son to God's service and, after weaning him, leaves him at the sanctuary at Shiloh. Every year she brings him a little robe she's made (2:19). Her song (2:1–10) says the LORD "raises up the poor from the dust" and brings the mighty down, and it's the model for Mary's song in Luke 1. It ends with the first reference in the Bible's order to a king as God's "anointed" (2:10), from a woman praying before Israel has a king.

Abigail (1 Samuel 25). Called "discerning and beautiful," married to Nabal, a rich man described as harsh (25:3). David, then an outlaw with six hundred men, asks Nabal for provisions in return for having left his shepherds unharmed (25:5–8). **INTERPRETATION** Many readers hear a protection payment. Nabal refuses, and David arms four hundred men to kill every male in the household. A servant tells Abigail, who loads donkeys with food and rides out without telling her husband. She bows at David's feet and makes a long, carefully argued speech (25:24–31). She takes the blame on herself, keeps David from blood guilt he'd regret as king, and predicts his dynasty. David thanks God for her discernment. Nabal dies ten days later, and David marries her. The Talmud counts her among seven women prophets (Megillah 14a, below).

Michal (1 Samuel 18–19, 2 Samuel 3, 6). Saul's daughter. The narrator says she loved David (1 Sam 18:20, 28), something the Hebrew Bible rarely says of a woman. Saul uses her as bait. She saves David's life by letting him down through a window and putting an idol in his bed (19:11–17). Saul then gives her to another man, Palti (25:44). After Saul's death David demands her back as a political condition, and Palti follows her weeping until he's ordered home (2 Sam 3:13–16). When David dances before the ark in a linen ephod she despises him, they quarrel, and the chapter ends: "Michal the daughter of Saul had no child to the day of her death" (6:16–23).

Bathsheba (2 Samuel 11–12, 1 Kings 1–2). David sees her bathing from his roof. The text says she was purifying herself after her period (11:4), and it doesn't say where she was. Every verb in the scene belongs to the king: he saw, he sent, he took. Her only words are "I am pregnant," two words in Hebrew (11:5). Her husband Uriah is killed on David's written order, carried in Uriah's own hand (11:14–15). Nathan's parable makes her the poor man's lamb (12:1–4). Her first child dies. Decades later she works with Nathan to secure the throne for her son Solomon, and sits at his right hand as queen mother (1 Kgs 1:11–31, 2:19). Matthew names her in Jesus' genealogy only as "the wife of Uriah" (1:6). She's usually reduced to a temptress on a roof.

> Correction to the old Companion: it places her bathing "in her own home" and gives her first words as five. The text doesn't give the place, and the words are two in Hebrew.

Tamar, David's daughter (2 Samuel 13). Sent by her father's own instruction to her half-brother Amnon's sickroom, where he rapes her. Before it she argues with him, tells him "such a thing is not done in Israel," and offers him a lawful alternative, asking the king for her (13:12–13). Afterward she tears the long robe worn by the king's virgin daughters, puts ashes on her head and goes away crying aloud (13:18–19). Her full brother Absalom tells her to be quiet, and she lives "a desolate woman" in his house. David is very angry and does nothing (13:20–21). Absalom kills Amnon two years later, and later names his own daughter Tamar (14:27). Chronicles doesn't retell any of it (II.2). Phyllis Trible counted her among the Texts of Terror (1984).

Jezebel (1 Kings 16–21, 2 Kings 9). A Sidonian princess married to Ahab of Israel, who supports Baal worship and has the LORD's prophets killed (1 Kgs 16:31, 18:4). When Naboth won't sell Ahab his vineyard, she writes letters in Ahab's name, seals them with his seal, and arranges false witnesses so Naboth is executed by correct legal procedure (21:1–16). The crime is real, and the text doesn't soften it. Her death comes in 2 Kings 9. She paints her eyes and arranges her hair, calls down to the usurper Jehu from her window, and is thrown out of it (9:30–37). Revelation uses her name for a woman prophet in Thyatira (2:20). In English "Jezebel" became an insult for any woman with influence, and under slavery and Jim Crow "Jezebel" was the name of a stereotype of Black women as sexually predatory, used to excuse their abuse (Deborah Gray White, Ar'n't I a Woman?, 1985).

> Correction to the old Companion: it cites 1 Kings 16–21 for her death. Her death is in 2 Kings 9.

Athaliah (2 Kings 11, 2 Chronicles 22–23). The only woman to rule Judah in her own name, for six years. When her son the king is killed she has the royal family killed and takes the throne, which is how several male kings took theirs. **CONTESTED** Whether she's Ahab's daughter or Omri's (2 Kgs 8:18, 26). One infant prince survives because his aunt Jehosheba hides him in the temple for six years (11:2–3). In the seventh year the priest Jehoiada crowns the boy, Joash, who's seven, and Athaliah tears her clothes and cries "Treason! Treason!" before she's killed (11:14–16). Her reign is recorded as usurpation.

Huldah (2 Kings 22:14–20, 2 Chronicles 34:22–28). A prophet in Jerusalem, wife of Shallum, the keeper of the wardrobe. When the law scroll is found in the temple, King Josiah sends the high priest, the royal secretary and three other officials to inquire of the LORD, and they go to her. Jeremiah and Zephaniah were active at the time, and nobody in the text explains why they chose her or comments that she's a woman. She authenticates the scroll's warnings and gives an oracle: disaster will come, and Josiah will be gathered to his grave in peace before it does (22:20). Josiah dies in battle at Megiddo (23:29). **CONTESTED** Whether "in peace" means before the disaster or a peaceful death, and so whether the oracle was fulfilled. The Talmud lists seven women prophets: Sarah, Miriam, Deborah, Hannah, Abigail, Huldah and Esther (Megillah 14a). Two southern gates of the Temple Mount were called the Huldah Gates (Mishnah Middot 1:3).

The widow and the Shunammite (2 Kings 4, 8). A prophet's widow comes to Elisha because a creditor is about to take her two children as slaves. He tells her to borrow every empty jar she can, shut the door behind her and her sons, and pour her one jar of oil into them. The oil runs until the jars run out. She sells it, pays the debt and lives on the rest (4:1–7). The miracle keeps two children out of debt slavery (compare Nehemiah 5 in II.2 and

Deuteronomy 15 in II.3). In the same chapter a wealthy woman of Shunem builds Elisha a room. When her son dies she rides to the prophet, refuses to leave without him, and gets her son back (4:8–37). Years later she returns from a famine to find her land taken, petitions the king herself, and gets it back with the income it earned while she was gone (8:1–6).

Vashti (Esther 1). Queen of Persia. At the end of a seven-day feast, the king, "merry with wine," orders her brought in wearing her crown to show the officials her beauty, and she refuses (1:10–12). The king's adviser Memucan warns that every wife in the empire will hear of it and despise her husband. She's deposed by decree, and letters go to every province that every man is to be master in his own house (1:16–22). The whole plot of the book depends on her empty place.

> Correction to the old Companion: it says she's "never mentioned again." The king remembers her and what was decreed against her in 2:1, and Esther is made queen "instead of Vashti" (2:4, 2:17).

Esther (the book of Esther). Hadassah, an orphan raised by her cousin Mordecai, is "taken" in a royal search for young virgins (2:7–8). The women go through twelve months of beauty treatment, six with oil of myrrh and six with spices, then one night with the king (2:12–14). She hides her people on Mordecai's instruction. When the king's official Haman wins a decree to destroy the Jews, Mordecai tells her, "Who knows whether you have not come to the kingdom for such a time as this?" (4:14). Approaching the king unsummoned is punishable by death, and she goes anyway: "If I perish, I perish" (4:11, 4:16). She works through two banquets, exposes Haman, and wins a counter-decree. In chapter 9 the Jews kill their attackers, seventy-five thousand in the provinces (9:16). Esther then writes with full authority to fix the festival of Purim (9:29–32), so the book ends with her issuing a written decree. God isn't named anywhere in the Hebrew text. The Greek version adds prayers and names God. The Assessment in Draft Three uses "Esther's crown" as proof a woman could influence government "so long as she was beautiful, obedient, and prepared to die for the privilege" (**DR3**).

The woman of worth (Proverbs 31:10–31). An acrostic poem, each verse starting with the next letter of the Hebrew alphabet. ʾEshet ḥayil is usually translated "virtuous" or "capable" wife, and ḥayil is also the word for an army's strength and for wealth. She buys a field and plants a vineyard with her own earnings (31:16), makes garments and sells them to merchants (31:24), "opens her mouth with wisdom" and teaches kindness (31:26), and her husband is known at the city gates because of her (31:23). The chapter opens with the words "King Lemuel's mother taught him" (31:1–9). Her advice to her son is to stay away from wine when he's judging and to "open your mouth for the mute… defend the rights of the poor and needy" (31:8–9). The poem's verse 29 is printed on the Assessment and read before the scores, in King James wording (**DR3**). In Jewish practice it's sung at the Friday evening table.

The unnamed (Genesis 19, Judges 11, 19). Lot's wife looks back at Sodom and becomes a pillar of salt (Gen 19:26). Jephthah vows to sacrifice whatever comes out of his house first if he wins a battle, and his daughter comes out dancing. She asks for two months to go to the mountains with her companions and mourn, he carries out the vow, and "it became a custom" that the daughters of Israel went out four days a year to lament her (Judg 11:29–40). Content note: the woman of Judges 19 is a Levite's secondary wife. At Gibeah men surround the house demanding the guest, and the Levite pushes her outside. She's raped all night and found at dawn with her

hands on the threshold. He carries her home, cuts her body into twelve pieces and sends them through Israel. The civil war that follows ends with the abduction of four hundred women of Jabesh-gilead and the dancing girls of Shiloh to supply wives (chs. 20–21). The book's last line, "everyone did what was right in his own eyes" (21:25), is the frame. None of the three women is named. Trible's Texts of Terror reads the daughter and the woman of Judges 19 together.

Women of the New Testament

Mary of Nazareth (Luke 1–2, Mark 3, John 2, 19, Acts 1:14). Her name is Mariam, Miriam's name. Told by an angel that she'll bear a son, she asks a practical question, "How will this be?", before she agrees: "Let it be to me according to your word" (Luke 1:34–38). She goes "with haste" to her relative Elizabeth's house in the hill country and stays about three months (1:39–56). The song she sings there, the Magnificat, takes Hannah's song as its model. God has brought down the mighty from their thrones, lifted up the humble, filled the hungry and sent the rich away empty (1:51–53), and the verbs are in the past tense, as if it's already done. Simeon tells her a sword will pierce her own soul (2:35), and she "treasured up all these things" (2:19, 2:51). At Cana she tells Jesus "they have no wine," then tells the servants "do whatever he tells you" (John 2:3–5). In Mark his family comes to take him home because people are saying he's out of his mind, and when his mother and brothers arrive he points to the crowd as his family (Mark 3:21, 31–35). She stands at the cross in John (19:25–27) and is with the disciples in the upper room after (Acts 1:14). **CONTESTED** Matthew quotes Isaiah 7:14 from the Greek, "a virgin (parthenos) shall conceive." The Hebrew word, ʿalmah, means a young woman of marriageable age, and the translation is one of the oldest disputes between Jewish and Christian readers. She's usually reduced to a single word of consent.

> Correction to the old Companion: it says she "travels alone" to Elizabeth's house. The text doesn't say whether anyone went with her.

Mary Magdalene (Luke 8:1–3, Mark 15–16, Matthew 27–28, John 19–20). From Magdala in Galilee. Luke says seven demons had gone out of her, and that she and other women supported Jesus and the twelve "out of their own means" (8:2–3). She's at the cross and at the burial in all four gospels and is named first in most lists of the women. In John she's the first to see the risen Jesus and is sent to tell the disciples: "I have seen the Lord" (20:11–18). In Luke the apostles think the women's report is nonsense (24:10–11). The text never calls her a prostitute. Pope Gregory the Great merged her with the unnamed sinful woman of Luke 7 and with Mary of Bethany in a sermon in 591 (Homily 33), and the reputation stuck for fourteen centuries. The 1969 revision of the Catholic calendar dropped her identification with the sinful woman, and in 2016 her memorial was raised to a feast with the old title "apostle to the apostles." A second-century text outside the canon, the Gospel of Mary, makes her a teacher of the other disciples.

The woman at the well (John 4:1–42). A Samaritan woman drawing water at noon. Jesus asks her for a drink, and she asks why a Jewish man is asking a Samaritan woman (4:9). Their conversation is the longest Jesus has with any one person in the gospels. She raises the live political-religious dispute between their peoples, whether God is to be worshiped on Mount Gerizim or in Jerusalem (4:20), and gets a serious answer. Jesus tells her she's

had five husbands and the man she has now isn't her husband (4:16–18), and the text doesn't explain why, condemn her or have him condemn her. She's the first person in John to whom Jesus says plainly that he's the Messiah (4:25–26). She leaves her water jar, goes back to town, and "many Samaritans believed in him because of the woman's testimony" (4:28–39). She's usually reduced to her five husbands.

> Correction to the old Companion: it says "women in that world did not divorce men." Under Jewish law only a husband could initiate divorce, and Roman law allowed either spouse to. The text doesn't say whether her marriages ended in death, divorce or something else.

The woman with the hemorrhage, and the woman who anointed him (Mark 5:25–34, Mark 14:3–9). A woman who's been bleeding for twelve years, and has spent everything she had on doctors and only gotten worse, comes up behind Jesus in a crowd and touches his cloak. Under Leviticus 15:25–30 she'd count as impure (II.3). He stops and asks who touched him, and she comes forward trembling and tells him "the whole truth." He calls her "Daughter" and tells her that her faith has made her well. The story is set inside the raising of a twelve-year-old girl. In Mark 14 an unnamed woman breaks a jar of expensive ointment over Jesus' head two days before his arrest. The men present scold her for the waste, and Jesus says that wherever the gospel is preached, what she's done will be told in memory of her (14:9). Her name wasn't kept.

Martha and Mary of Bethany (Luke 10:38–42, John 11–12). In Luke, Mary sits at Jesus' feet listening, the posture of a disciple, while Martha is "distracted with much serving" and asks him to send her sister to help. He says Mary has chosen the good portion. In John, Martha meets him after her brother Lazarus's death and makes the confession Peter makes in the other gospels: "You are the Christ, the Son of God" (11:27). Mary anoints his feet with perfume and wipes them with her hair (12:1–8).

Phoebe (Romans 16:1–2). Paul commends her to the church in Rome as a diakonos of the church at Cenchreae, the same word translated "deacon" for men elsewhere, and a prostatis, a patron or benefactor, "of many and of myself as well." INFERENCE: She probably carried the letter to Rome, and couriers often read letters aloud and explained them. Translations divide. The KJV and ESV render her title "servant," and the NRSV and NIV (2011) render it "deacon."

Junia (Romans 16:7). Paul greets Andronicus and Junia, "my kinsmen and my fellow prisoners," who are "of note among the apostles" and were in Christ before him. Junia is a common Latin woman's name, and early writers including John Chrysostom read her as a woman apostle. From the Middle Ages on, many editions and translations printed a masculine "Junias," a name with no attestation in ancient sources. Eldon Epp's Junia: The First Woman Apostle (2005) traces the change. **CONTESTED** Whether the phrase means "prominent among the apostles" or "well known to the apostles." Michael Burer and Daniel Wallace argued for the second (2001), and others have answered them.

> Correction to the old Companion: it says she was "imprisoned for it," meaning for being an apostle. The text says she and Andronicus had been in prison with Paul. It doesn't say why.

Priscilla (Acts 18, Romans 16:3–5, 1 Corinthians 16:19, 2 Timothy 4:19). Also called Prisca. A tentmaker with her husband Aquila, and a church meets in their house. When the gifted preacher Apollos arrives in Ephesus knowing only John's baptism, the two of them take him aside and explain "the way of God more accurately"

(Acts 18:24–26). She's named before her husband in four of the six mentions, which most commentators read as a sign of her prominence.

Lydia (Acts 16:11–15, 40). A dealer in purple cloth, a luxury trade, from Thyatira, living in Philippi with her own household and no husband mentioned. She's the first person in Philippi to be baptized, often called the first convert in Europe. She insists that Paul and his companions stay at her house, and after their release from prison they go back there to meet the believers.

Tabitha (Acts 9:36–43). Also called Dorcas. She's the only person in the New Testament called mathētria, the feminine form of "disciple." She's known for good works and charity. When she dies, the widows show Peter the tunics and garments she'd made, and he raises her.

The widows (Acts 6:1–6, 1 Timothy 5:3–16). One of the first disputes in the Jerusalem community is a complaint that the Greek-speaking widows are being neglected in the daily distribution of food. Seven men are appointed to manage it. 1 Timothy sets out an enrolled order of widows with an age requirement (sixty), conditions and support from the church.

The letters that contain the restriction passages (1 Cor 14:34–35, 1 Tim 2:11–15) belong to the same collection that greets about ten women in Romans 16 alone, several with titles. How those fit together is the fault line in I.6.

Men of the Text

Abraham (Genesis 12–25). Held up as the model of faith. The text records him twice passing his wife off as his sister to protect himself (12, 20), sending Hagar and Ishmael into the wilderness at Sarah's demand (21), and taking his son up a mountain to sacrifice him (22). It also records him arguing with God over Sodom, bargaining down from fifty righteous people to ten: "Shall not the Judge of all the earth do what is just?" (18:22–33). Paul reads him as justified by faith (Rom 4), James by works (Jas 2:21–23). Kierkegaard's Fear and Trembling (1843) is the classic reading of chapter 22 as a horror.

Jacob (Genesis 25–35, 49). Buys his brother's birthright for stew and takes his blessing by disguise. He's deceived in turn on his wedding night and works twenty years for his father-in-law under shifting terms (31:38–41). He wrestles all night with a stranger, is renamed Israel, "strives with God," and limps afterward (32:22–32). He loves Rachel over Leah and Joseph over his brothers, openly, and says nothing when Dinah is assaulted until his sons have acted (34:5, 30).

Judah (Genesis 37–38, 43–44, 49). The fourth son of Leah. He proposes selling Joseph instead of killing him (37:26–27). He wrongs Tamar and admits it (ch. 38). In Egypt he offers himself as a slave in place of his brother Benjamin, in the longest speech in Genesis (44:18–34). Jacob's blessing gives him the scepter (49:10). His name became the tribe's, the southern kingdom's and finally the word "Jew."

Joseph (Genesis 37–50). Favored, sold by his brothers, imprisoned on a false accusation, and raised to run Egypt's grain. His famine policy ends with the whole population selling its land and itself to the crown (47:13–26, II.3). He forgives his brothers: "you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good" (50:20).

Moses (Exodus–Deuteronomy). Raised in the palace of the regime killing his people. He kills an Egyptian overseer and runs to Midian (Exod 2:11–15). He argues with God five times before he goes (II.3), and later talks God out of destroying the people (32:11–14). He's eighty when he confronts Pharaoh (7:7). He's barred from the land after striking the rock at Meribah (Num 20:2–13) and dies in sight of it, buried by God in a grave no one knows (Deut 34).

> Correction to the old Companion: it says he spent "forty years as a shepherd." Exodus doesn't give the length of his time in Midian. The forty years come from Stephen's speech in Acts 7:23, 30 and later tradition.

Aaron (Exodus–Numbers). Moses' brother and spokesman, and the first high priest. He makes the golden calf, announces "a feast to the LORD," and explains that the gold went into the fire "and out came this calf" (Exod 32:4–5, 24). He keeps his office. He joins Miriam's challenge in Numbers 12 and isn't struck. His sons Nadab and Abihu die offering "strange fire" (Lev 10). He dies on Mount Hor and the people mourn him thirty days (Num 20:22–29).

Gideon (Judges 6–9). Found threshing wheat in a winepress to hide it from raiders. He tests God twice with a fleece, and wins with three hundred men. Offered hereditary rule, he refuses: "I will not rule over you, and my son will not rule over you. The LORD will rule over you" (8:23). Afterward he makes a gold ephod from the plunder, and it becomes "a snare" to his family (8:27). His son Abimelech kills seventy brothers to make himself king. The one survivor, Jotham, answers with a fable in which the trees offer kingship to the olive, the fig and the vine, who all decline, and finally to the bramble, which accepts and threatens to burn them all (9:7–15). Abimelech dies when a woman drops a millstone on his head from a tower (9:53).

Samuel (1 Samuel 1–16, 25:1). Hannah's son, raised at the sanctuary. When the people ask for a king "like all the nations," he warns them in detail what a king will take: sons for his chariots, daughters for his kitchens, the best fields and a tenth of the flocks, "and you shall be his slaves" (8:11–18). He anoints Saul anyway, and later anoints David while Saul is still alive.

David (1 Samuel 16 – 1 Kings 2). The most fully drawn character in the Hebrew Bible, and the portrait isn't flattering. A musician, a soldier, an outlaw whose men ask Nabal for payment (1 Sam 25), a king who dances before the ark and quarrels with Michal over it (2 Sam 6). He takes Bathsheba and has Uriah killed by written order (2 Sam 11). He does nothing when Amnon rapes Tamar (13:21), and nearly loses the kingdom to Absalom. On his deathbed he gives Solomon a list of men to deal with (1 Kgs 2:5–9). God promises him a dynasty forever (2 Sam 7), which every Christian monarchy later claimed as precedent. Nathan confronts him and he lives (2 Sam 12). He's usually reduced to the boy with the sling, the harpist, and "a man after God's own heart" (1 Sam 13:14).

Nathan (2 Samuel 7, 12, 1 Kings 1). The court prophet who first delivers the dynastic promise and then walks in and tells the king a story about a rich man who stole a poor man's only lamb. David condemns the rich man, and Nathan says, "You are the man" (12:7). Later he works with Bathsheba to put Solomon on the throne over an older brother (1 Kgs 1).

Solomon (1 Kings 1–11). Bathsheba's son, who wins the succession over an older brother and has rivals killed (1 Kgs 2). His first judgment is between two women who are prostitutes, each claiming the same baby, and the king hears them both in person (3:16–28). He builds the temple with conscripted labor (5:13–18). 1 Kings 9:20–22

says the forced labor fell on non-Israelites, and 1 Kings 12 says the northern tribes revolted over the "heavy yoke" he'd laid on them, so the two passages pull against each other. He breaks all four prohibitions of Deuteronomy 17 (II.3). Proverbs, Ecclesiastes and the Song of Songs are attached to his name.

Elijah (1 Kings 17–19, 21, 2 Kings 1–2, Malachi 4:5–6). A prophet from Tishbe who confronts Ahab and Jezebel. A foreign widow at Zarephath feeds him from her last flour and oil (1 Kgs 17:8–16). He wins a contest on Mount Carmel and has the prophets of Baal killed (18:20–40). Afterward he runs from Jezebel's threat, asks to die, and is fed and told to sleep. God comes to him not in wind, earthquake or fire but in "a sound of thin silence" (19:1–12). He's taken up in a whirlwind (2 Kgs 2:11). Malachi ends with the promise that Elijah will return before the day of the LORD (4:5–6). The King James New Testament spells his name Elias (Matt 11:14, 17:3).

Jeremiah (the book of Jeremiah). Put on trial for his life for preaching that the temple would be destroyed (ch. 26). The king cuts up his scroll column by column and burns it, and he dictates it again (ch. 36). He's put in the stocks, accused of deserting to Babylon, and dropped into a muddy cistern. A Cushite eunuch in the palace, Ebed-melech, gets the king's permission and pulls him out with ropes and rags (38:7–13). He tells the exiles to "seek the welfare of the city" where they've been sent (29:7).

Peter (the gospels, Acts, Galatians 2). Impulsive and often wrong. He rebukes Jesus for predicting his death and is called "Satan" (Mark 8:32–33), cuts off a servant's ear in the garden (John 18:10), and denies knowing Jesus three times, the first time to a servant girl (Mark 14:66–72). He's restored with a question asked three times (John 21:15–17). Paul rebukes him publicly at Antioch for withdrawing from table fellowship with gentiles (Gal 2:11–14).

Paul (Acts, the letters). A Pharisee who persecuted the movement and then joined it (Gal 1:13–16). He's imprisoned repeatedly and defends himself in Roman courts. He writes that in Christ "there is no longer slave or free, no longer male and female" (Gal 3:28) and greets women leaders by name (Rom 16).

> Correction to the old Companion: it says the silencing passages and Galatians 3:28 are "both his." 1 Corinthians 14:34–35 appears at a different place in some manuscripts, and many scholars think it was added later. 1 Timothy is one of the Pastoral letters whose authorship is CONTESTED (II.1, I.6). Neither is certainly Paul's.

Judas (the gospels, Acts 1). One of the twelve, who keeps the common purse (John 12:6, 13:29). The gospels give different accounts of why he hands Jesus over. Matthew has him ask the chief priests what they'll pay (26:14–16). John calls him a thief. Luke and John say Satan entered him (Luke 22:3, John 13:27). Matthew says he returns the silver and hangs himself (27:3–5), and Acts gives a different death (1:18).

> Correction to the old Companion: it says "one gospel implies disillusionment." None does. Disillusionment is a modern reading.

Pilate (the gospels). The Roman prefect of Judea from 26 to 36 CE. All four gospels have him find no case against Jesus and order the crucifixion anyway. Only Matthew has him wash his hands before the crowd (27:24). An inscription found at Caesarea in 1961 names him.

John the Baptist (the gospels, Josephus). The son of a priest (Luke 1:5), preaching in the wilderness. He calls the crowds, or in Matthew the Pharisees and Sadducees, a "brood of vipers" (Matt 3:7, Luke 3:7). Herod Antipas imprisons him for condemning his marriage to his brother's wife and has him beheaded at a banquet at his stepdaughter's request (Mark 6:17–29). From prison he sends to ask Jesus, "Are you the one who is to come, or shall we look for another?" (Matt 11:2–3). Josephus says Herod killed him because he feared John's influence over the crowds might lead to revolt (Antiquities 18.116–119), so the political reason is on the record too.

For TKC

Many of the cast carry biblical names. The table records what the name points to. Whether each echo is meant is your call, so every application below it is POSSIBLE unless it carries a source tag.

NAME IN THE CAST	WHO IN TKC	BIBLICAL SOURCE	WHERE
Eden Selah Osei	Covenant Daughter of Aurem (**TL**)	The garden. Selah isn't a person: it's a liturgical marker of unknown meaning, seventy-one times in Psalms and three in Habakkuk.	Gen 2–3, Ps 3:2, Hab 3
Miriam Osei	Eden's mother (**TL**)	Miriam the prophet. Mariam in Greek, so every Mary in the New Testament.	Exod 15, Num 12
Leah Osei	Eden's sister (**TL**)	Leah, the fertile, unloved wife	Gen 29–30
Zion Osei	Eden's brother (**TL**)	A place, not a person: Jerusalem's hill, and the city addressed as a woman, "daughter Zion"	Ps 137, Isa 40:9, Lam 1–2
Solomon Osei	Eden's brother (**TL, FR 0**)	Solomon, Bathsheba's son, born after the household broke	2 Sam 12:24, 1 Kgs 1–11
Thomas Osei	Eden's father (**TL, FR 3**)	Thomas, the disciple who wouldn't believe without seeing	John 20:24–29
Hannah	House Mother, House Aurem (**TL**)	Hannah, who gave her only son to the sanctuary	1 Sam 1–2
Naomi	Hannah's daughter (**TL, FR 33**)	Naomi, who came home empty and planned Ruth's future	Ruth 1–4
Abigail	Debate and Protocol Advisor, House Aurem (**TL**)	Abigail, who talked an armed man out of a massacre on her knees	1 Sam 25
Ruth Gideon	Covenant Daughter of Heartland (**TR**)	Ruth, and Gideon, who refused a crown and then made an ephod that became a snare	Ruth, Judg 6–9
Judah Elijah Vane	Crown Heir (**TL**)	Judah, who offered himself in his brother's place. Elijah, who confronted a king and queen.	Gen 44, 1 Kgs 17–21

NAME IN THE CAST	WHO IN TKC	BIBLICAL SOURCE	WHERE
Elias Vane	Founder (TL)	Elias is the King James New Testament spelling of Elijah	Matt 11:14, 17:3 (KJV)
Zara Voss	Covenant Daughter of Sable (TR)	Zara is the King James spelling of Zerah, Tamar's twin son	Gen 38:30, Matt 1:3 (KJV)
Sera Callum Vane, Sera Montoya	Elias's wife (TL), Covenant Daughter of Pacific (TR)	Serah, daughter of Asher, one of the very few daughters named in the genealogies	Gen 46:17, Num 26:46
Petra Solano	Covenant Daughter of Mountain (TR)	A word, not a person: Greek petra, "rock"	Matt 16:18
Azrael Vane	Dorian's elder son (TL)	Not in the Bible. Azrael is the angel of death in later Islamic and Jewish tradition.	

- **Seven women prophets.** The Talmud's list of seven (Megillah 14a) includes Miriam, Hannah and Abigail. Eden's mother, her House Mother and her protocol advisor all carry prophets' names. POSSIBLE Celeste knows the list and has never said so.
- **Hannah.** "Six Trials. Twelve girls. None of them hers" (TL), and the twelve are a whole career (FR 26). The biblical Hannah gives her only child to the sanctuary and brings him a robe every year. Naomi has one year left in Vowed education (TL), and whether Hannah enters her in the Trials turns on what happens to Eden (FR 29). POSSIBLE Hannah's story is the biblical one run in reverse, a woman deciding whether to give her daughter to the institution she's served.
- **Abigail.** "Pressure in a pretty dress," a hand at the elbow, one soft line (WR 30). The biblical Abigail persuades by kneeling, taking the blame on herself and telling a dangerous man what he'll regret. POSSIBLE The Arrangement (IX.5) has its oldest written form here.
- **Elias as Elijah.** POSSIBLE: The Temple reads its canonized founder (TL) as the Elijah Malachi promised would return, and named the Crown Heir Judah Elijah to carry it. Elijah's story also includes the collapse after the victory, which the Temple doesn't teach.
- **Esther and Vashti.** The Trials are a state search for young women with a long preparation (TR, II.1), and the Assessment uses "Esther's crown" (DR3). POSSIBLE The Temple teaches Vashti immediately before Esther as the warning, and never teaches that Esther ends the book issuing a decree in her own name.
- **Mary and consent.** The angel waits for Mary's answer. At an Aurem Binding, "nobody asks if she consents. They ask if she is worthy" (DOM). INTERPRETATION Every Binding held in a Temple that honors Mary contradicts the story it honors.
- **Huldah.** Officials take a found scroll to a woman for a ruling, and the kingdom acts on what she says. The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent are found documents (TL, FR 41–42). POSSIBLE Huldah isn't in the

Temple's syllabus. **OPEN QUESTION** Who in the Empire would be asked to authenticate the Dissent if it surfaced?

- **Tamar's method.** She doesn't accuse. She collects evidence and lets the record speak. **POSSIBLE** Eden's method in a world run by the Registry (VII.7), and the limit of it: Tamar had a law on her side that wasn't being enforced, and Eden's law is against her.
- **Mary Magdalene and the Eve narrative.** A reputation assigned centuries after the fact by a sermon and kept after the correction. The Broadcast's Eve narrative "implies and never accuses" (**TR**). **POSSIBLE** The Broadcast keeps a file of the women it's used the narrative on, and their reputations outlast the Trial.
- **Jezebel.** The name became a stereotype used against Black women. Aurelia is built over Atlanta's Black memory (**DOM**), and Gulf candidates are penalized for warmth (**DOM**). **POSSIBLE** "Jezebel" is the word the Broadcast never says on air and its editors use in the room.
- **The women of Romans 16 and Acts.** Titles like deacon and patron are rendered as domestic words in some translations. **POSSIBLE** The Empire's designations do the same thing on purpose, and Stewardwife is the clearest case. Tabitha's widows and the Acts 6 distribution are mutual aid recorded as ministry, like Irongate's Kitchen and Meridian's Reading Circles (**DOM**).
- **The administrators.** Joseph, who builds the machine, and Pilate, who finds no case and signs anyway. **POSSIBLE** The Crown advisor in the Pairing Introduction (**TR**) is a Pilate.
- **Nathan and the missing prophet.** David's court had one man who could say "You are the man" and live. **OPEN QUESTION** Does anyone in Dorian's court have Nathan's office, licensed or not?
- **Samuel 8 and Jotham's fable.** Two anti-monarchy texts in the Empire's own canon. **POSSIBLE** Pacific's grandmothers (**DOM**) know the bramble fable by heart.
- **Ebed-melech.** A foreign palace servant who goes to the king and pulls the prophet out of the cistern. **POSSIBLE** Hannah, who knows the back staircases and the camera gaps (**TL**), is this kind of insider.
- **Jeremiah's scroll.** Burned and dictated again. Dorian removed the Covenant of Dissent (**FR 42**). **POSSIBLE** Someone can still recite it, the way Celeste can recite the Covenant of Purpose (**AM**).
- **John the Baptist.** The gospels give a personal reason for his death and Josephus gives a political one. **INTERPRETATION** The Empire's "sudden medical event" for Azrael and Petra (VI.2) works the same way, a private explanation for a public act.

Working Questions

1. Which biblical names in the cast were chosen by a character in the story, and which by the Registry? Who named Leah, Zion and Solomon?
2. Does Hannah know she's named for a woman who gave her child to the sanctuary? Does Naomi?
3. What does Abigail say to Eden that the biblical Abigail said to David: that she'll regret a thing she hasn't done yet?

4. Which of the seven women prophets does the Temple teach, and which has it left out?
5. Write the Temple's lesson on Vashti for girls at Designation age, then the version Celeste told Eden.
6. Who in the Empire is a Huldah, someone officials would quietly take a document to? Is it a woman, and does anyone know she's consulted?
7. What evidence is Eden collecting, Tamar-style, and what will she do when the court turns out to be against her?
8. Which Covenant Daughter in earlier Trials got the Mary Magdalene treatment, and where is she now?
9. Does Judah know the end of Elijah's story, the cave and the silence? Who taught it to him?
10. Is there a Nathan in the Crownward? What happens to the first person who says "You are the man" to Dorian?
11. Which unnamed woman in the Empire's records will Eden give a name to?
12. Which biblical woman does Celeste name most often at the kitchen table, and which one won't she talk about?

Working pages

PART III

DECIDED

DATE

PART IV

Jesus, the Kingdom and the Lord's Prayer

The novel takes its title from one line of a prayer Jesus taught, and the Empire takes its founding sermon's name from the same line (TL). This part covers what "kingdom" meant in the gospels, what Jesus kept doing that institutions have found hard to absorb, the prayer itself clause by clause in its two versions, and a grid for holding the four gospels side by side without flattening them. The old Companion's prayer page had real errors, and they're corrected below. Scholarly positions on the historical Jesus are named where they belong to someone. E. P. Sanders (The Historical Figure of Jesus, 1993) and Bart Ehrman (The New Testament: A Historical Introduction) stand behind much of the background.

The kingdom

The word. Basileia means kingdom, kingship or reign, and it's the word for the empire that ruled Judea. "The kingdom of God" is the center of Jesus' preaching in the first three gospels. Mark's summary of his message is "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God has come near" (Mark 1:15). Matthew usually says "kingdom of heaven," a reverent way of avoiding the word God, and means the same thing.

What it's like. The parables describe it as small, hidden and growing without permission: a mustard seed, yeast worked into flour, treasure buried in a field, a merchant selling everything for one pearl (Matt 13:31–46). It belongs to the poor (Luke 6:20). Children, tax collectors and prostitutes go into it ahead of the respectable (Mark 10:14–15, Matt 21:31). It's very hard for the rich to enter, harder than a camel going through the eye of a needle (Mark 10:25).

Rank turned over. When his disciples argue about who's greatest, he tells them the rulers of the nations lord it over their subjects, "but it shall not be so among you." Whoever wants to be first must be slave of all (Mark 10:42–44, Matt 20:25–27). In John he washes their feet, a slave's work, and tells them to do the same (John 13:1–17). When a crowd wants to make him king by force, he withdraws (John 6:15). He enters Jerusalem on a donkey, which Matthew links to Zechariah 9:9, a king "humble and mounted on a donkey" (Matt 21:1–11).
INTERPRETATION Marcus Borg and John Dominic Crossan (The Last Week, 2006) read the entry as a deliberate counter-procession to the Roman governor's arrival with troops at Passover. The charge on the cross, in all four gospels, is "King of the Jews."

Now or later. CONTESTED: Whether the kingdom is present, future or both. Albert Schweitzer (The Quest of the Historical Jesus, 1906) argued that Jesus expected an imminent end of the world. C. H. Dodd (1935) argued the kingdom was already present in Jesus' ministry. Most scholars now hold some version of "already and

not yet." Luke 17:21 says the kingdom is entos hymōn, which can mean "within you" or "among you," and the translation changes the meaning from an inner state to a present reality in the community.

Two sayings the Empire would need. "My kingdom is not of this world" (John 18:36). CONTESTED The Greek ek tou kosmou toutou means "from this world," and many scholars read it as a statement about the kingdom's source and not its location: it doesn't come from this world's kind of power, which is why his servants don't fight. "Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and to God the things that are God's" (Mark 12:13–17) answers a trap about paying tax to Rome. He asks whose image (eikōn) is on the coin. CONTESTED Readers have taken the answer as endorsing two separate spheres, as evading the trap, and as a challenge, since the hearers know whose image human beings bear (Gen 1:27).

Four things he kept doing

Authority. Crowds say he teaches "as one who had authority, and not as the scribes" (Mark 1:22), and officials keep asking "By what authority are you doing these things?" (Mark 11:28). He argues sabbath practice with the Pharisees (Mark 2:23–3:6), denounces scribes and Pharisees as "blind guides" and "whitewashed tombs" (Matt 23:16, 27), and drives the money changers out of the temple court (Mark 11:15–17).

Bodies. He touches a man with a skin disease (Mark 1:41) and takes a dead girl by the hand (Mark 5:41). The woman with the hemorrhage touches him first, without asking, and he commends her faith (Mark 5:25–34, Part III). INTERPRETATION In these stories the contagion runs the other way. He doesn't become unclean, and they become well. CONTESTED Whether that amounts to opposing the purity system. Paula Fredriksen and Amy-Jill Levine (The Misunderstood Jew, 2006) warn that reading Jesus as against Jewish law is a Christian habit with an ugly history. The woman broke no law by being in a crowd, and Jesus sends the healed man to the priest with the offering Moses commanded (Mark 1:44).

Women. Mary of Bethany sits at his feet in the place of a student and he defends her (Luke 10:38–42). Named women fund the movement (Luke 8:1–3). A Syrophoenician woman argues with him over healing her daughter, answers his refusal with "even the dogs under the table eat the children's crumbs," and he grants it "for this saying" (Mark 7:24–30). She wins the exchange. He has a long theological conversation with a Samaritan woman (John 4) and is anointed by a woman in a room of men who call it waste (Mark 14:3–9). No gospel records him telling a woman to be silent.

Money. He tells a rich man to sell everything and give to the poor, and the man goes away grieving (Mark 10:17–22). Luke pairs blessings on the poor with woes on the rich (6:20–26) and adds the rich fool (12:13–21) and the rich man and Lazarus (16:19–31). In his first sermon at Nazareth he reads Isaiah 61, good news to the poor, release to the captives, "the year of the Lord's favor," which echoes the Jubilee release (Lev 25, II.3), and says it's fulfilled today (Luke 4:16–21). Debt forgiveness is written into the prayer (below).

> Correction to the old Companion: it says the room at Nazareth "turns on him" over the year of release. The congregation first speaks well of him (4:22). They try to throw him off a cliff after he says Elijah and Elisha were sent to foreigners, a widow of Sidon and a Syrian general, and not to Israel (4:24–30).

Thy kingdom come: the Lord's Prayer

The prayer appears twice, in different settings and different forms. In Matthew it's part of the Sermon on the Mount, taught as the right way to pray instead of heaping up empty phrases (6:7–13). In Luke the disciples ask "Lord, teach us to pray, as John taught his disciples," and he gives a shorter version (11:1–4). Every pronoun for the people praying is plural: us, our. There's no "I" in it.

CLAUSE	MATTHEW 6:9–13	LUKE 11:2–4	COMMON LITURGICAL FORM
Address	Our Father in heaven	Father	Our Father, who art in heaven
Name	Hallowed be your name	Hallowed be your name	Hallowed be thy name
Kingdom	Your kingdom come	Your kingdom come	Thy kingdom come
Will	Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven	Absent in the earliest manuscripts	Thy will be done, on earth as it is in heaven
Bread	Give us this day our daily bread	Give us each day our daily bread	Give us this day our daily bread
Forgiveness	Forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors	Forgive us our sins, for we ourselves forgive everyone indebted to us	Forgive us our trespasses, as we forgive those who trespass against us
Testing	Lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil (or "the evil one")	Lead us not into temptation	Lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil
Doxology	Absent in the earliest manuscripts	Absent	For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, for ever. Amen.

Clause by clause.

"Our Father in heaven." A shared parent makes the people praying siblings. **INTERPRETATION** Authority is placed where no earthly office can occupy it.

"Hallowed be your name." A request that God's name be treated as holy. **INTERPRETATION** It implies that no other name is, imperial or dynastic.

"Your kingdom come." The title line, in both gospels. It asks for the kingdom's arrival, which assumes it isn't fully here. The Jewish Kaddish, an Aramaic prayer whose core many scholars date early, also pairs the hallowing of God's name with a prayer that God's kingdom be established soon, and the two prayers are often compared.

"Your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven." This clause is Matthew's. It's absent from Luke in the earliest manuscripts (P75, Codex Vaticanus) and was added to Luke by later copyists. **INTERPRETATION** In Matthew it ties the kingdom to the earth, to the place where taxes are collected and soldiers are stationed.

"Our daily bread." The Greek word translated "daily," epiousios, appears nowhere in Greek literature before the gospels, and its meaning is uncertain. Proposals include "for today," "for tomorrow," and "necessary for existence." Jerome translated it two different ways in the Vulgate: "supersubstantial" in Matthew and "daily" in Luke. It asks for enough, and for "our" bread, not "my" bread.

"Forgive us our debts." Matthew uses opheilēmata, debts, and Luke uses hamartias, sins, though Luke's second half keeps the debt language ("everyone indebted to us"). Both versions tie the request to the one praying it: forgive us as we forgive. "Trespasses" isn't in either gospel's version of the prayer. It comes from William Tyndale's English translation of Matthew (1526) and from the Book of Common Prayer (1549), and it passed from there into Anglican and Catholic English liturgy. Matthew's very next verses use a word that does mean trespasses, paraptōmata (6:14–15).

> Correction to the old Companion: it says institutions render the clause "trespasses" to blunt its financial sense. The difference between "debts" (Matthew), "sins" (Luke) and "trespasses" (the liturgy) tracks which text and which translation tradition a church inherited. It isn't evidence of anyone's motive. Churches that say "debts," Presbyterian and Reformed ones among them, follow the King James Matthew.

"Lead us not into temptation." Peirasmos means testing or trial as well as temptation. **INTERPRETATION** It's a request to be spared the test, not to pass it heroically. In 2017 Pope Francis criticized the traditional wording, and the French Catholic liturgy (adopted 2017) and the Italian (approved 2018, confirmed by Rome in 2019) changed it to "do not let us enter into temptation" and "do not abandon us to temptation." "Deliver us from evil" can also be read "from the evil one," since the Greek tou ponērou is ambiguous.

"For thine is the kingdom." The doxology is absent from the earliest manuscripts of Matthew (Codex Sinaiticus, Codex Vaticanus, Codex Bezae) and from every early manuscript of Luke. A shorter form, "for yours is the power and the glory forever," appears in the Didache (8:2), an early Christian manual from around 100 CE. Later manuscripts of Matthew added it, the King James Version printed it, and most modern translations put it in a footnote. Protestant churches generally say it. The Catholic Mass has said it since 1970, but separately, after a prayer the priest inserts.

> Correction to the old Companion: it presents a single prayer and treats "on earth as in heaven" as part of the line the novel is named for. "Thy kingdom come" is in both gospels. "On earth as in heaven" is Matthew's alone, the doxology is a later addition, and the prayer most people recite is a composite of Matthew's text with a liturgical ending.

The Gospel Grid

There are four gospels, written for different communities over several decades, and they differ on the order of events, the wording of sayings, the day Jesus died and what happened at the tomb. All four are formally anonymous. The names were attached by tradition, generally in the second century. Every date below is a mainstream range and every one is argued.

	MARK	MATTHEW	LUKE	JOHN
Usual date	About 65–75	About 80–90	About 80–95	About 90–110
Length	16 chapters, the shortest	28 chapters	24 chapters, continued in Acts	21 chapters
Opens with	John the Baptist in the wilderness	A genealogy from Abraham	A dedication to Theophilus claiming orderly research	"In the beginning was the Word," before creation
Birth story	None	Magi, Herod's massacre of the children, flight to Egypt	Shepherds, Mary's song, presentation at the temple	None
Genealogy	None	Abraham to Joseph, naming Tamar, Rahab, Ruth and "the wife of Uriah"	Back to Adam, through a different line after David	None
Teaching	Short, often private explanations	Five large blocks, the Sermon on the Mount first	The Sermon on the Plain, and the most parables	Long first-person discourses, the "I am" sayings
Parables	Several	Many	The good Samaritan and the prodigal son are only here	None of the familiar kind
Exorcisms	Central	Frequent	Frequent	None
Lord's Prayer	Absent	6:9–13	11:2–4	Absent
Length of ministry	Can be read as about a year, one trip to Jerusalem	Same	Same	Three Passovers, several trips, the source of "three years"
Temple action	Final week, the trigger for the arrest	Final week	Final week	At the start of the ministry (ch. 2)

	MARK	MATTHEW	LUKE	JOHN
Last meal	A Passover meal	A Passover meal	A Passover meal	Before Passover. He dies as the lambs are slaughtered.
Last words	"My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" then a loud cry (15:34–37)	The same cry (27:46–50)	"Father, into your hands I commit my spirit" (23:46)	"It is finished" (19:30)
At the tomb	Three women find the stone rolled away and a young man inside. They flee and tell no one.	Two Marys, an earthquake, an angel who rolls the stone, guards. The women meet Jesus on the way.	Several named women and two men in dazzling clothes. The apostles think it's nonsense.	Mary Magdalene, then Peter and another disciple. Jesus appears to her first.
Ending	The earliest manuscripts end at 16:8 with the women afraid. The longer ending (16:9–20) is a later addition.	A commission on a mountain in Galilee	Appearances near Jerusalem, then the ascension	Two endings (20:30–31 and ch. 21)
Leans toward	Disciples who fail to understand. His identity is kept quiet until a Roman soldier names it at the cross.	Fulfillment of scripture, the law, community discipline, judgment	The poor, reversals of status, women, foreigners	Who Jesus is, and belief

> Correction to the old Companion: it says "no two of the four give the same last words." Mark and Matthew give the same cry, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?", in slightly different forms (Eloi in Mark, Eli in Matthew). Luke's "Father, forgive them" (23:34) is missing from some of the earliest manuscripts, including P75 and Codex Vaticanus, and its originality is CONTESTED.

Who used whom. Matthew, Mark and Luke run parallel closely enough to print in columns, sometimes with identical Greek for long stretches. Some literary relationship is certain. Which one is CONTESTED.

PROPOSAL	WHAT IT CLAIMS	ITS WEAK POINT
Two-source (the majority view)	Matthew and Luke each used Mark, plus a lost collection of sayings called Q, plus material of their own	Q has never been found and is reconstructed from the texts it explains
Farrer (Mark Goodacre, The Case Against Q, 2002)	Luke used both Mark and Matthew, so no lost source is needed	It has to explain why Luke broke up Matthew's sermons and moved the pieces

PROPOSAL	WHAT IT CLAIMS	ITS WEAK POINT
Matthew first (Griesbach and later forms)	Matthew is earliest, and Mark condensed the others	It has to explain why a condenser would add rough Greek and unflattering details

Whether John knew the other three, knew a tradition behind them or wrote independently is a separate dispute.

What only one gospel has. Mark: a healing that takes two tries (8:22–26), and a young man who runs away naked at the arrest (14:51–52). Matthew: the magi, the massacre of the children, the guard at the tomb, and the sheep and the goats (25:31–46). Luke: the shepherds, the Magnificat, the good Samaritan, the prodigal son, the rich man and Lazarus, the road to Emmaus. John: the wedding at Cana, Nicodemus at night, the Samaritan woman, the raising of Lazarus, the foot washing and the long farewell discourse.

What all four keep. Women are at the tomb first in every gospel, in a culture where women's legal testimony carried little weight. INTERPRETATION Some scholars argue that's a detail a community inventing the story wouldn't have chosen. It's an argument from plausibility, not a proof.

For TKC

- **The title, twice.** Elias Vane's 2033 sermon is called Thy Kingdom Come, and it's been required curriculum in every Dominion school since 2061 (TL). The novel takes the same words. INTERPRETATION Every character who prays the line is asking either for the Empire to last or for something to replace it, and may not know which. The same line can be said twice in one scene by two people meaning opposite things.
- **The Empire's text of the prayer.** INFERENCE: The Book of Covenant uses King James wording (DR3, I.7), so the Temple's base text is probably Matthew 6 as the KJV prints it: "debts," "Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven," and the doxology. OPEN QUESTION Does the Temple say "debts" or "trespasses" in public worship, and does it print Luke's shorter version anywhere? (VIII, working question 3.)
- **Relocating the kingdom.** POSSIBLE: The Temple makes "My kingdom is not of this world" its favorite verse, teaching the kingdom as an inner state or a reward after death, and then names the Empire as the kingdom come. The old Companion called this move the engine of the novel (AM). It needs both halves: the kingdom emptied of territory, and the Empire claiming the territory.
- **"On earth as it is in heaven."** POSSIBLE: The clause the Temple can't spiritualize, because it names the earth. Someone who's read Luke knows the prayer works without it, and someone who's read Matthew knows it doesn't.
- **Debts and levies.** In Aurem, families of the top five Assessment finishers get the kind of review where unpaid levies disappear (DR3). INTERPRETATION The Empire forgives a household's debts in exchange for its daughter. The prayer ties forgiveness to forgiving others. POSSIBLE A character notices that the Temple says "trespasses" in the same building where the levy office is.

- **Lead us not into testing.** INTERPRETATION: Twelve Covenant Daughters pray every week to be spared the test while the Empire tests them for four months. **POSSIBLE** The Temple teaches the clause as a prayer for the strength to pass.
- **Women at the tomb.** All four gospels put women at the tomb first, and in Luke the apostles call their report nonsense. In Mark the earliest text ends with the women saying nothing to anyone because they're afraid. Eden's Theological Interview report runs three pages longer than anyone else's, and the officer can't tell whether she's the most aligned woman in twenty years or the most clear-eyed (**TR**). **POSSIBLE** The question of whose testimony counts is the Trials' question too.
- **The Syrophoenician woman.** She wins an argument with Jesus and gets what she came for "for this saying." POSSIBLE: The scriptural precedent for Eden's Public Testimony, where every sentence is defensible and the cumulative argument is incendiary (**TR**).
- **The donkey and the Boulevard.** The Opening Procession gives Aurem's Covenant Daughter forty-seven seconds on Sovereign Boulevard (**DOM**), and every candidate's walk is choreographed (**CR**). **POSSIBLE** Someone in the cast knows the entry into Jerusalem was read as a parody of a governor's procession, and walks the Boulevard thinking about it.
- **Rank turned over.** "It shall not be so among you." POSSIBLE: Judah knows Mark 10:42–44 and it's part of why he doesn't perform (**WR 36**). In the Pairing Introduction he sends the officials out (**TR**), which is the closest thing in the Trials to washing feet.
- **Four gospels and one Broadcast.** The Broadcast edits the Civic Debates for Dominion release, cutting some exchanges and building narratives decided in advance (**TR**). **INTERPRETATION** The gospels show four communities shaping one story, openly and in the canon. The Broadcast does it in secret and calls the result the record.
- **Keeping the anti-Jewish trope out.** The Temple of TKC is the Empire's institution. When Jesus argues with Pharisees and scribes in the gospels, the argument is inside first-century Judaism. If the novel uses those scenes against the Temple, the narration has to know the difference, or it repeats an old Christian slander (**WR 38–39**).
- **Luke 4.** The Nazareth congregation turns on Jesus when he says God sent prophets to foreigners. **POSSIBLE** The Temple preaches the release of Luke 4:18 as spiritual and leaves out 4:25–27 entirely, because favor to outsiders is what the Empire can't afford in any Dominion.

Working Questions

1. What's the Empire's official text of the Lord's Prayer? Which gospel, which translation, and is anything cut or added?
2. Who in the cast says "debts" and who says "trespasses," and does anyone notice?
3. Write the passage of Elias's 2033 sermon that explains what "Thy kingdom come" means. Which line does every schoolchild know?

4. What does Celeste say the line means, at the kitchen table, when Eden is small?
5. Which of the four gospels does the Temple read from most, and which is almost never read aloud?
6. Does the Temple teach that Mark ends at 16:8? Would a girl with Eden's scores have found out on her own?
7. Who in the Crownward has read the Magnificat as a political text, and what happened to them?
8. Which saying of Jesus would get a Covenant Daughter flagged if she quoted it in the Civic Debates?
9. When Eden prays "lead us not into temptation" during the Trials, what does she mean by it?
10. What does the Empire do with "the rulers of the nations lord it over them"? Is it carved anywhere, or kept out of the readings?
11. What is Judah's private reading of "my kingdom is not of this world"?
12. Whose testimony does the Empire refuse to count, and what did that person see?

Working pages

PART IV

DECIDED

DATE

PART V

Christianity and Power

Almost the whole Bible was written by people living under someone else's government, and most of its later history has been read aloud by people holding one. This part covers the empires inside the text, the separate powers that decide what a text means, the passages states and churches have leaned on, and American history from the Puritans to the present, which is the history the Covenant Coalition grew out of (TL). The American sections are new research, and they describe what movements said and did. Where a characterization of a living movement is disputed, it's marked CONTESTED.

Empires of the Bible

EMPIRE	WHAT IT WANTED	HOW IT GOT IT	WHERE TO READ IT
Egypt	Labor	Forced labor, rising quotas, and a decree controlling births (Exod 1, 5). Unrest is answered with more work.	Exodus 1–14
Assyria	Submission, advertised	Terror and deportation. Conquered peoples were broken up and resettled among strangers, and the northern kingdom disappeared this way (2 Kgs 17). Its envoy shouts terms at Jerusalem's wall in the local language so the people on the wall can hear (2 Kgs 18:26–28).	2 Kings 17–19, Nahum
Babylon	The top of a society	It deported the educated and skilled, trained young men in its own language and literature, gave them new names and careers (Dan 1:3–7), and left the poor to work the land (2 Kgs 25:12).	2 Kings 24–25, Daniel 1–6, Lamentations
Persia	Order at low cost	Licensed and funded local religion. It sent the exiles home, paid for the temple and authorized its law (Ezra 1, 6–7). Its decrees can't be revoked (Esth 8:8, Dan 6:8). Its court gathers young women by search and removes a queen by legislation (Esth 1–2).	Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther, Daniel 6
Rome	Taxes and quiet	Governed through local clients: a client king, a temple aristocracy, a governor. Crucifixion was public and slow, by roads. The emperor was honored as divine and his rule called peace.	The gospels, Acts, Revelation

> Correction to the old Companion: it calls Babylon's method elite capture "far cheaper than terror." Babylon also besieged Jerusalem, burned the temple and blinded the king (2 Kgs 25:7–9). It used both methods.

Who gets to say what it means

Authority over a text is a set of separate powers. They're often held by different people, and a religious state becomes total when one institution holds all of them.

POWER	WHAT IT DECIDES	HISTORICAL CASE
Canon	Which books count	Settled for most churches long ago, and so invisible (I.2)
Translation	Which words	William Tyndale was executed in 1536, in part for translating the Bible into English without license.
Lectionary	Which passages are read aloud, on which days	Most worshippers hear only what the calendar of readings allows.
Commentary	What a passage is taken to mean	The Geneva Bible's margin notes (1560) were one reason James I wanted a new translation without them (I.4).
Pulpit	Who may stand up and speak	Licensing of preachers, and the withdrawal of a license
The copy	Who owns a book, and which edition	Abridged editions like the 1807 Slave Bible (below)
Literacy	Who can read it unaided	South Carolina's Negro Act of 1740 banned teaching enslaved people to write, and several Southern states tightened anti-literacy laws after Nat Turner's revolt in 1831.

INTERPRETATION Movements that broke a religious monopoly usually did it by attacking translation, literacy or the copy. Reform tends to show up as a printing problem before it's a theological one.

Passages put to work

These are passages that states and churches have leaned on to justify their own authority. Each is in the text, and each has been read more narrowly or more widely than the text requires.

PASSAGE	HOW IT'S BEEN USED	WHAT THE TEXT DOES
Genesis 3:16	As a charter for male rule in the household and in law	**CONTESTED** prescription or description (II.3). The woman isn't cursed in the chapter.
Romans 13:1–7	As a demand for obedience to whatever government holds power. Loyalist clergy preached it against the American Revolution, and in June 2018 the U.S. attorney general cited it to defend a border policy that separated children from their parents.	Written by a man repeatedly jailed by the authorities he describes, in a canon that includes prophets defying kings (I.6)

PASSAGE	HOW IT'S BEEN USED	WHAT THE TEXT DOES
Ephesians 5:22	As household law	Grows out of 5:21, "submit to one another," and is followed by a longer section demanding self-giving from husbands (I.7)
1 Timothy 2:11–12	As a permanent ban on women teaching	CONTESTED authorship (II.1). Named women teach elsewhere in the New Testament (Acts 18:26, Rom 16).
Deuteronomy 28	As a national scoreboard: prosperity proves virtue and disaster proves sin	One side of an argument the Bible has with itself. Job and Ecclesiastes refuse it (II.2).
Joshua 7	As a case for collective punishment, since one household's theft endangers the nation	Set against Deuteronomy 24:16 and Ezekiel 18 (II.2, II.3)
Numbers 16	As the standing sermon against challenging ordained leaders	Paired in the same book with the daughters of Zelophehad, whose petition succeeds (II.2)
Judges 21:25	As an argument for strong rule: without a king, everyone does as he likes	The book's own closing frame, after its worst chapters for women
2 Samuel 7	As a promise of an eternal dynasty	Followed in the same book by Nathan's "You are the man" (Part III)

> Correction to the old Companion: it calls Genesis 3:16 "a curse, not a command." The woman isn't cursed in Genesis 3 (II.3), and whether the line is a command is the disputed point. It also calls 1 Timothy "the most disputed letter in the collection." 2 Peter was the most doubted book in antiquity (II.1). 1 Timothy's authorship is disputed along with the other Pastoral letters.

American History

Puritan covenant theology and the city on a hill. The Puritans who settled Massachusetts Bay in 1630 understood their colony as a community bound to God by covenant, on the model of Israel in Deuteronomy. Blessing would follow faithfulness, and judgment would follow breach. The sermon "A Model of Christian Charity" is traditionally attributed to John Winthrop and dated to 1630, given aboard or beside the Arbella. **CONTESTED** Some scholars suggest another minister wrote it, and it wasn't printed until 1838. It says the colony "shall be as a city upon a hill," borrowing Matthew 5:14, and its point is that the whole world will watch, so failure will be public. It closes by paraphrasing Deuteronomy 30: "Therefore let us choose life." Daniel Rodgers (As a City on a Hill, 2018) argues the sermon was little known until the twentieth century. John F. Kennedy quoted it to the Massachusetts legislature as president-elect on January 9, 1961. Ronald Reagan made "a shining

city upon a hill" a theme of his speeches and the center of his farewell address on January 11, 1989, adding the word "shining." In Winthrop's use the image is a warning about being watched. In later political use it became a description of national greatness.

Proslavery and abolitionist readings of the same texts. Both sides of the American slavery debate read the same Bible and claimed it. Proslavery ministers cited Noah's curse on Canaan (Gen 9:25, read as a curse on Africans, II.3), the permanent slavery of foreigners in Leviticus 25:44–46, Abraham's household slaves, the instructions to slaves in Ephesians 6:5, Colossians 3:22 and 1 Peter 2:18, and Paul's return of Onesimus in Philemon. They argued that Jesus never condemned slavery. After the Denmark Vesey plot in Charleston in 1822, the Baptist minister Richard Furman wrote an exposition, dated that December, for the South Carolina Baptist Convention defending slavery from scripture, and its arguments were used by Southern defenders of slavery until the Civil War. Thornton Stringfellow, a Virginia Baptist pastor, published A Brief Examination of Scripture Testimony on the Institution of Slavery (Richmond, 1841).

Abolitionists answered with the Golden Rule (Matt 7:12), "God made of one blood all nations" (Acts 17:26, KJV), "there is neither bond nor free" (Gal 3:28), the capital law against kidnapping a person to sell (Exod 21:16), the refusal to return runaways (Deut 23:15–16) and the exodus itself. Angelina Grimké, from a South Carolina slaveholding family, published An Appeal to the Christian Women of the South (1836) through the American Anti-Slavery Society, and made the Bible her test. Frederick Douglass added an appendix to his Narrative (1845) to make clear that his attacks were on "the slaveholding religion of this land," which he set against "the Christianity of Christ." Mark Noll's The Civil War as a Theological Crisis (2006) argues that the conflict exposed a crisis in how Protestants read the Bible: both sides held scripture to be authoritative and plain, and neither could persuade the other from it.

The churches split along the same line. Methodists divided in 1844. The Southern Baptist Convention was founded in Augusta, Georgia, in 1845, after the national Baptist mission board refused to appoint slaveholders as missionaries. Presbyterians divided in stages, finally in 1861. In June 1995, meeting in Atlanta, the Southern Baptist Convention adopted a resolution repenting of its past racism and apologizing to African Americans.

The 1807 "Slave Bible." In 1807 a London missionary society published Select Parts of the Holy Bible, for the Use of the Negro Slaves, in the British West-India Islands. According to Anthony Schmidt, a curator at the Museum of the Bible in Washington, it kept 232 of the 1,189 chapters in a standard Protestant Bible, leaving out about ninety percent of the Old Testament and about half of the New. The exodus story is gone. Passages that reinforce slavery, including Ephesians 6:5, are kept. A copy on loan from Fisk University was exhibited at the museum in 2018–2019. The name "Slave Bible" is modern. **INTERPRETATION** It's the clearest case on record of controlling scripture without changing a word of it, by deciding which words are in the copy (I.7).

The Black church tradition. Under slavery, much Black Christian worship was what the sociologist E. Franklin Frazier called the "invisible institution," held in secret, often in woods and gullies known as hush harbors, beyond the reach of white supervision and of laws against Black gatherings. Albert Raboteau's Slave Religion: The "Invisible Institution" in the Antebellum South (1978) is the standard history. In Philadelphia, Richard Allen and other Black worshippers walked out of St. George's Methodist Church over segregated seating (Allen dated it

to 1787, and some historians argue for 1792). Allen founded Mother Bethel in 1794, and in 1816 the African Methodist Episcopal Church became an independent denomination with Allen as its first bishop. In Charleston, the African church that became Emanuel AME was burned by white authorities in 1822 after Denmark Vesey, one of its founders, was accused of planning a revolt. Its members worshipped in secret until 1865. On June 17, 2015, a white supremacist killed nine people at a Bible study in the same church. C. Eric Lincoln and Lawrence Mamiya's The Black Church in the African American Experience (1990) describes the seven historically Black denominations that grew from this history. The spirituals, the exodus as the central story (II.3), the preaching tradition, and the civil rights movement's base in churches, from the Southern Christian Leadership Conference (1957) to Martin Luther King Jr.'s last sermon, all come out of it.

Christian nationalism. CONTESTED, as a term and in its boundaries. The sociologists Andrew Whitehead and Samuel Perry, in Taking America Back for God (2020), define it as "a cultural framework... that idealizes and advocates a fusion of Christianity with American civic life," and argue that the "Christian" in it is more an identity than a faith. A 2023 PRRI and Brookings survey built a scale from five statements about Christianity and American law and society. It classed about 10 percent of American adults as adherents and 19 percent as sympathizers, with 39 percent skeptics and 29 percent rejecters. Among white evangelical Protestants, 29 percent were adherents and 35 percent sympathizers. Critics, including the political scientist Mark David Hall, argue the definitions are too broad and sweep in ordinary religious participation in politics. Some on the right have taken up the term themselves. Stephen Wolfe's The Case for Christian Nationalism (2022) argues for it openly.

Christian Reconstructionism. R. J. Rushdoony founded the Chalcedon Foundation in 1965 and published The Institutes of Biblical Law in 1973, a commentary on the Ten Commandments arguing that God's law in scripture, including the case laws of the Torah, should be the standard for civil law. Rushdoony called the program Christian Reconstruction. Greg Bahnsen's Theonomy in Christian Ethics (1977) gave the position its name, and Gary North, Rushdoony's son-in-law, extended it into economics. The movement's most distinctive claim is that the Mosaic civil penalties remain valid, and its writers listed the death penalty for offenses including adultery, homosexual acts, blasphemy, idolatry, witchcraft and incorrigible children. **CONTESTED** How consistently Rushdoony applied the penalties is argued, since he also wrote that nations not in covenant with God aren't bound to all of them. Most evangelical and Reformed theologians rejected theonomy. The faculty of Westminster Theological Seminary published Theonomy: A Reformed Critique (1990). Rushdoony's influence on the Christian school and homeschooling movements was large and is acknowledged by supporters and critics alike.

Dominionism and the Seven Mountains. CONTESTED, as a label. The researcher Sara Diamond described "dominion theology" in Spiritual Warfare (1989), and the journalist Frederick Clarkson and others used "dominionism" for the wider set of Christian Right groups that read Genesis 1:28, "have dominion," as a mandate for Christian control over public life. Critics, among them the evangelical writer Joe Carter, call the label a smear with conspiratorial overtones, and some who use it agree it's often used loosely. The Seven Mountain Mandate holds that Christians are called to influence or lead seven spheres of society, usually listed as family, religion, education, media, arts and entertainment, government and business. Its proponents trace it to a 1975 meeting at which Loren Cunningham of Youth With A Mission and Bill Bright of Campus Crusade for Christ each received

the same list. Francis Schaeffer is sometimes added to the story, and his involvement is disputed. Cunningham and Bright framed it as evangelism. After Lance Wallnau heard the story from Cunningham in 2000 and was mentored by C. Peter Wagner, the founder of the New Apostolic Reformation, the mandate took a more political turn, set out in Wallnau and Bill Johnson's Invading Babylon (2013). Some trace the idea further back, to the Dutch theologian and prime minister Abraham Kuyper's doctrine of "sphere sovereignty." Matthew D. Taylor's The Violent Take It by Force (2024) traces the New Apostolic Reformation's networks and their role in the events of January 6, 2021, including the Appeal to Heaven flag.

Headship, settled in 1987. I.7 flagged two dates to check. Both hold. The Council on Biblical Manhood and Womanhood drafted the complementarian Danvers Statement at a meeting in Danvers, Massachusetts, in December 1987 and published it in final form in November 1988. Christians for Biblical Equality was founded in 1987 and published its egalitarian statement, "Men, Women and Biblical Equality," in 1989, reaching a wide audience in Christianity Today in 1990.

For TKC

- **The composite empire.** POSSIBLE: The Empire uses the cheap methods: Babylon's elite capture, Persia's licensed religion and Rome's local clients. The Imperial Education Track takes exceptional common boys and makes them Crown-adjacent for life (**MEN**), which is Daniel 1. Governor-Prelates are Persia's licensed religion and Rome's client government in one office (TL, VII.6). Terror is kept for the edges: the Ungoverned, Azrael, the 2061 removal (**TL, FR 35–36**).
- **The seven powers.** The Empire holds the pulpit (the Temple and its ministers), the lectionary (what's read before the scores, DR3), the commentary (the Assessment's doctrine section, DR3) and much of literacy (the Designation, DOM). **OPEN QUESTION** Does the Empire hold the translation and the copy? Is the Book of Covenant a full Bible, and who may own another one (VIII.2, I.7)? The powers it doesn't hold are where the plot can move.
- **The city on a hill.** The Covenant Coalition's platform was "America was great when it was godly. Return to God. Return to greatness" (**TL**). **INTERPRETATION** The Coalition reads Winthrop's image the way later politicians did, as national greatness, and drops his point, which is that a covenant people is watched and judged by its failures. **POSSIBLE** Elias's 2033 sermon quotes Winthrop's "choose life" and Deuteronomy 30 together.
- **The Coalition and Christian nationalism.** INTERPRETATION: The Coalition, as the timeline describes it (megachurches, political action groups and militias running candidates at every level, TL), fits Whitehead and Perry's definition of Christian nationalism closely. This is a reading of your own invented history, and real-world use of the term is CONTESTED.
- **The Dominions and Genesis 1:28.** The Dominions are named after a stewardship verse (AM, II.3), and dominionism is the reading of Genesis 1:28 as a mandate for Christian control of public life. **POSSIBLE** Whoever named the Dominions held the dominionist reading and chose the word because of it.

- **The Triune Rule and the mountains.** The Seven Mountains name seven spheres. The Triune Rule puts three of them, religion, government and media, into the constitution as the Temple, the Crown and the Broadcast (**TL**). **POSSIBLE** The Coalition's strategists used a version of the mandate, and the Empire's founding generation thought of the Trials as taking the "family" mountain.
- **Reconstructionism and the law.** POSSIBLE: The Covenant Court (VII.7) cites theonomist arguments for Imperial penalties, and quietly declines the parts of the Mosaic law that would bind the Crown (Deuteronomy 17, Leviticus 25, II.3).
- **The Slave Bible and the Book of Covenant.** POSSIBLE: The Book of Covenant is an abridgment on the 1807 model, the full canon on paper and a selection in practice. OPEN QUESTION (VIII.2).
- **Two Christianities.** Douglass set "the slaveholding religion of this land" against "the Christianity of Christ." INTERPRETATION: Part VIII draws the same line between faith the Temple can use and faith that answers to something it doesn't control. Celeste's faith is on Douglass's side of it.
- **Aurem's own history.** The Southern Baptist Convention was founded in Augusta, Georgia, in 1845 over slaveholding missionaries, and apologized in Atlanta in 1995. Aurem's territory includes Georgia and South Carolina, home of Furman's exposition and of Emanuel AME (DOM, X.1). **POSSIBLE** Aurelia's outer districts remember the hush harbors, the burned church at Charleston and the walkout at St. George's, and the Temple teaches none of it.
- **Hush harbors.** INTERPRETATION: Worship held out of sight of the authorities, in places the cameras don't reach. The Grace Bridge (**CR**) and the outer districts' kitchens (**DOM**) are the Empire's hush harbors.
- **Danvers in the law.** The Temple's official theology of marriage (**CR**) is the complementarian position of the Danvers Statement, written into civil law and enforced at the counter (I.7, Part IX). **INFERENCE** Christians for Biblical Equality's position has no legal standing in the Empire. **OPEN QUESTION** Do the egalitarian arguments survive in Meridian's Reading Circles or in Heartland's theological inquiry (**DOM**)?

Working Questions

1. Which of the five biblical empires does Celeste compare the Covenant Empire to, and which one does the Temple compare it to?
2. Which of the seven powers over scripture does the Empire not control, and who in the cast has quietly taken it?
3. What does Elias's 2033 sermon do with the city on a hill?
4. Who in the founding generation read Winthrop, Douglass and Rushdoony, and what did they take from each?
5. What did Atlanta's Black churches do between 2033 and 2044, and what's left of them in Aurelia?
6. Is there a hush harbor in Sector Seven? Who leads it, and has Eden been?
7. Which proslavery argument does the Empire still teach, under a different name and about a different group?

8. Does the Covenant Court ever cite Leviticus 20 or Deuteronomy 22 in a sentence? Write the case.
9. Who chose the word "Dominion," and did they read Genesis 1:28 the way dominionists do?
10. Which of the seven mountains does the Empire think it hasn't taken yet?
11. If a character found a full, unabridged Bible in 2104, what would she read first, and what would happen to her for owning it?
12. What would a Douglass of the Empire write in her appendix?

Working pages

PART V

DECIDED

DATE

Sources

These are the pages behind the American history sections. This session could search the web but couldn't open pages, so each claim was checked against the search results for these pages and the links themselves still need a click-through at proofing.

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- The Southern Baptist Convention: Christianity Today on the 1995 resolution, SBC Racial Reconciliation Resolution, Baptist News Global
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PART VI

The Fall of the United States

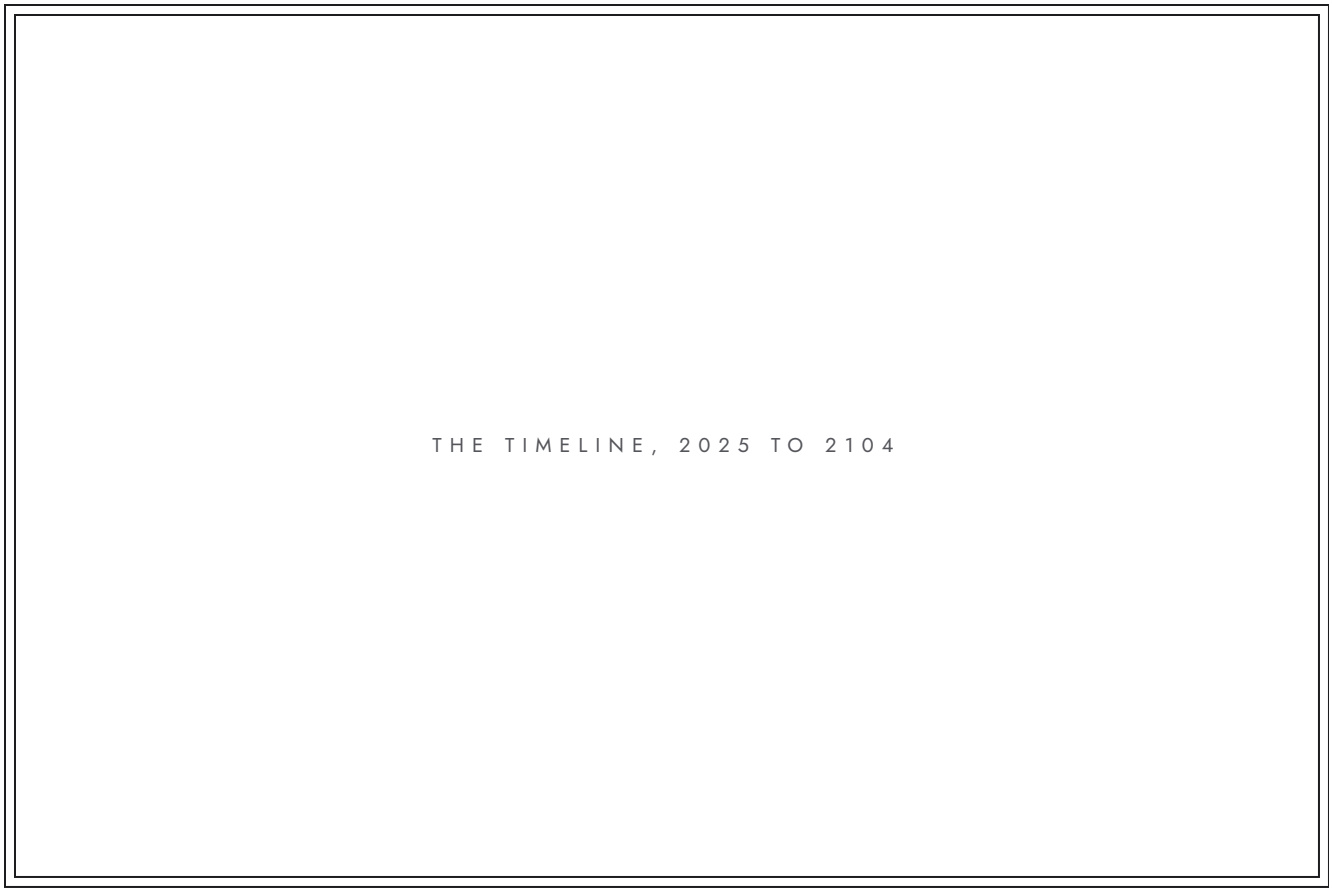
*The United States became the Covenant Empire of America over about eighteen years. It started with a stadium sermon in 2033 and ended in 2051, when the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast were written into the constitution as the three branches of government. Almost every step went through a vote, a referendum or an agreement (**TL**). Nobody in Eden's lifetime remembers the country before. The oldest person in her cast was born around 2035, into its last few years.*

VI.1 The timeline

YEAR	EVENT	SOURCE
2025–2031	The Fracture Years. A contested election leaves two men claiming the presidency at once. Automated labor wipes out forty percent of working-class jobs. Domestic attacks on federal buildings go uncontained, and a climate disaster makes the Gulf Coast uninhabitable. Faith in federal institutions collapses, and church attendance triples.	**TL**
2031	Evangelical megachurches, conservative political action groups and private militias organize as the Covenant Coalition. Their platform: "America was great when it was godly. Return to God. Return to greatness." They run candidates at every level of government at once.	**TL**
2033	Elias Vane, a little-known Georgia preacher, preaches Thy Kingdom Come for six hours to 400,000 people at The Gathering House, the former Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta. Every Coalition network carries it live.	**TL**
2035	Vane wins a Senate seat from Georgia. Within eighteen months he effectively controls the legislative agenda.	**TL**
c. 2035	Celeste Parish born	**INFERENCE from TL**
2039	California, Oregon and New York attempt to secede. The Coalition-controlled federal government calls it treason, and a two-year standoff follows.	**TL**
2041	The Partition Agreement brings the three states back with "regional autonomy." The autonomy is dismantled about four years later. Vane authors the Restoration Act, which passes Congress narrowly, under conditions later described as coercion.	**TL**
2043	Vane declares the United States dissolved and reborn as the Covenant Empire of America. He takes the title First Elector. The Crownward is formally established over Washington, D.C.	**TL, CR**

YEAR	EVENT	SOURCE
2044	The Dominion Act reorganizes the states into Twelve Dominions, each under a Governor-Prelate. Atlanta becomes Aurelia, seat of the Dominion of Aurem.	TL
2048	Elias Vane, 52, marries Sera Callum, 28, a Vowed woman and Temple scholar. It's the first Anointed marriage.	TL
2051	The Triune Rule makes the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast the three constitutional governing bodies.	TL
2054	Vane becomes Emperor by a referendum that returns 94 percent approval. He founds the House of Vane.	TL
2058	The Commonwife quota system is piloted in Red Earth.	DOM
2061	Elias Vane dies of heart failure at 65. The Temple canonizes him within the year. His face goes on the currency, and his sermon becomes required curriculum in every Dominion school. The same year, Elias's elder child, the rightful successor and Dorian's parent, is removed.	TL, FR 35–36
2062	Crest Vane takes the throne at 34. The Commonwife quotas are introduced, and the Ungoverned are designated criminal.	TL
2065	The first Covenant Trials	TL
2077	Azrael Vane born	TL
2079	Judah Vane born	TL
2085	Crest dies mid-cycle. Dorian takes the throne at 40, and that year's Trial is cancelled.	TL, FR 39
2098	Azrael, 21, finds a ledger in the east wing archive	TL
2100	Azrael is officially declared dead. The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent vanish the same week.	TL
2104	The 39th Covenant Trial	TL

CONFLICT The timeline introduces the Commonwife quotas under Crest in 2062, and the Dominions file says Red Earth piloted them in 2058. **INFERENCE** Both can be true if the 2058 pilot ran under Elias in one Dominion and Crest took it Empire-wide in 2062.



THE TIMELINE, 2025 TO 2104 *the Fracture Years as one band, the four rulers along the bottom*

VI.2 How the Empire tells it, and what the record shows

Everyone in Eden's world learned the left column in school. Where a character sits between the two columns says a lot about who she is. The Empire's phrasing is also what people would actually say out loud, so it's the version to use in dialogue (**AM**).

WHAT THE EMPIRE CALLS IT	WHAT HAPPENED
The Fracture Years, which God ended	Six years of overlapping disasters that a well-organized coalition was ready to inherit
The Restoration	A 400-page law that made rights conditional, passed under coercion nobody had to name
Regional autonomy, granted in mercy	A four-year holding pattern for three states that tried to leave, dismantled once the leverage was gone
Public mandate, 94 percent	A referendum controlled tightly enough to produce the number it wanted
Reorganized for accuracy and unity	The press became a branch of government

WHAT THE EMPIRE CALLS IT	WHAT HAPPENED
Citizenship clarified through covenant	A woman's legal standing became dependent on whether a man has married her
A celebration of the Empire's finest women	A televised selection that produces one Anointed Wife a year, and eleven women married down the elite ladder (**FR 19**)
A sudden medical event	The phrase the Empire uses for Azrael in 2100 and for Petra in 2104

VI.3 The Restoration Act

The Restoration Act of 2041 is the legal root of almost everything in Eden's life. The timeline gives four things it did (**TL**).

- **Rights become conditional.** They depend on standing, compliance and designation.
- **Marriage becomes a legal and theological designation.** The Binding, the Commonwife quota and the Anointed marriage all descend from this line.
- **Women's citizenship is reclassified as dependent on marital status.** This is why Unbound is a legal category with a file and not a description of someone's life.
- **The press is "reorganized for accuracy and unity."** Ten years later the same apparatus is a branch of government, and today it controls forty percent of a Covenant Daughter's score.

The act passed Congress, so the Empire's founding argument is that nothing illegal happened (**TL**).

OPEN QUESTION What does the Act's preamble say? You'll want the actual wording for any scene where a character quotes the Restoration.

VI.4 Living memory

Nobody in the cast lived through the Fall as an adult. What survives comes down through grandmothers and through the House of Vane's own documents.

Celeste Parish (TL). She was about nine in 2044 and remembers the renaming of Atlanta. She remembers her own grandmother crying when they changed the signs. She watched the Empire take her mother's identity through a Commonwife marriage, then raised Miriam alone under Unbound designation rather than let it happen again. The real name of the city is the last thing she says to Eden before the Crownward. She has no proof that Miriam is alive: the one letter Miriam sent, in 2094, was intercepted before it reached her, and she never knew it existed (**FR 16**). (Volume Two, Celeste.)

Sera Montoya's grandmother (TR). She was at the last protest before the Partition Agreement ended Pacific's resistance in 2041. She tells it to Sera as a warning, not a hero story: the difference between impact and loss is knowing when and how. (Volume Two, Sera.)

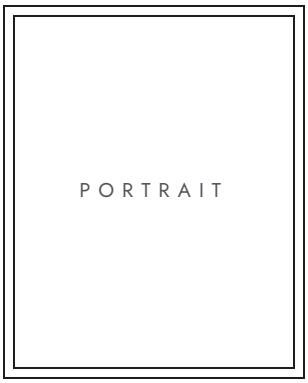
Pacific's generations (DOM). The people who remember trying to leave raised children who grew up with parents who'd tried and failed. Their grandchildren grew up knowing the story. The Empire still checks every Pacific girl's Designation for signs that the secession story survived in her.

Zara Voss's grandmother (TR). She has a real name the desert knows and the Empire doesn't. She raised Zara in Sable Reach and in the desert beyond it. (Volume Two, Zara.)

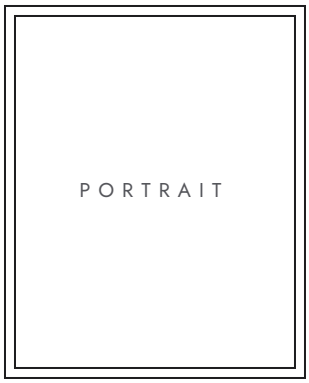
The House of Vane (TL, FR 35–44). The family keeps documents instead of grandmothers' stories, and those documents are the most dangerous things in the Crownward. See VI.5.

VI.5 Founder files

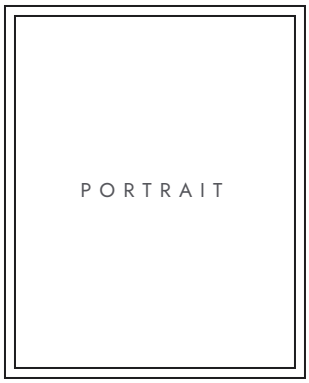
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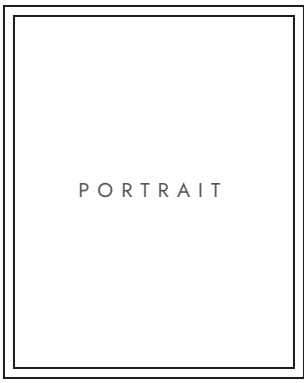
Elias Vane
First Elector and first Emperor, c. 1996–2061



Sera Callum Vane
Elias's wife, the first Anointed Wife



Crest Vane
Emperor 2062–2085



The removed heir
Elias's elder child, removed 2061

Elias Vane (c. 1996–2061). A relatively unknown Georgia preacher until the 2033 sermon (TL). His dates put his birth around 1996 (INFERENCE, from his ages in 2048, 2054 and 2061). He won his Senate seat in 2035, authored the Restoration Act in 2041, became First Elector in 2043 and Emperor in 2054, and died in 2061. The Temple canonized him within a year. His face is on the currency, and *Thy Kingdom Come* is required curriculum in every Dominion school. The Temple teaches that God chose him specifically to restore the nation and that his descendants carry that anointing forward (CR).

INTERPRETATION The old Companion's reading of his method still holds. He never took anything until refusing him would cost more than giving in. He ran candidates everywhere, made himself the man every faction needed, outlasted the secession instead of winning it, and wrote the law himself (AM).

Sera Callum Vane. A Vowed woman and Temple scholar who married Elias in 2048, when she was 28. She became the most powerful woman in the Empire's history while appearing entirely devoted to her husband. She wrote most of his domestic policy, and no official record says so (TL). Her marriage is the template for the Covenant Trials.

CONFLICT The timeline says she came from "the Northern Dominion." None of the Twelve Dominions has that name.

Crest Vane (Emperor 2062–2085). Elias's son. He took the throne at 34, so he was born around 2028, twenty years before his father's Anointed marriage (INFERENCE). He's cold and procedural. He manages people instead of inspiring them, and under him the Empire grows both more efficient and more brutal (**TL**). He introduced the Commonwife quotas, criminalized the Ungoverned and created the Trials. His claim came through survivorship, not birth order (**FR 35, 39**). He knew about his elder sibling's removal, didn't arrange it and didn't prevent it (**FR 37**). The one thing he did was preserve the documents, leaving them where the east wing archive would someday be inventoried (**FR 40**).

The removed heir. Elias's elder child, and the rightful successor. Removed in 2061, when Dorian was still a child (**FR 35–36**).

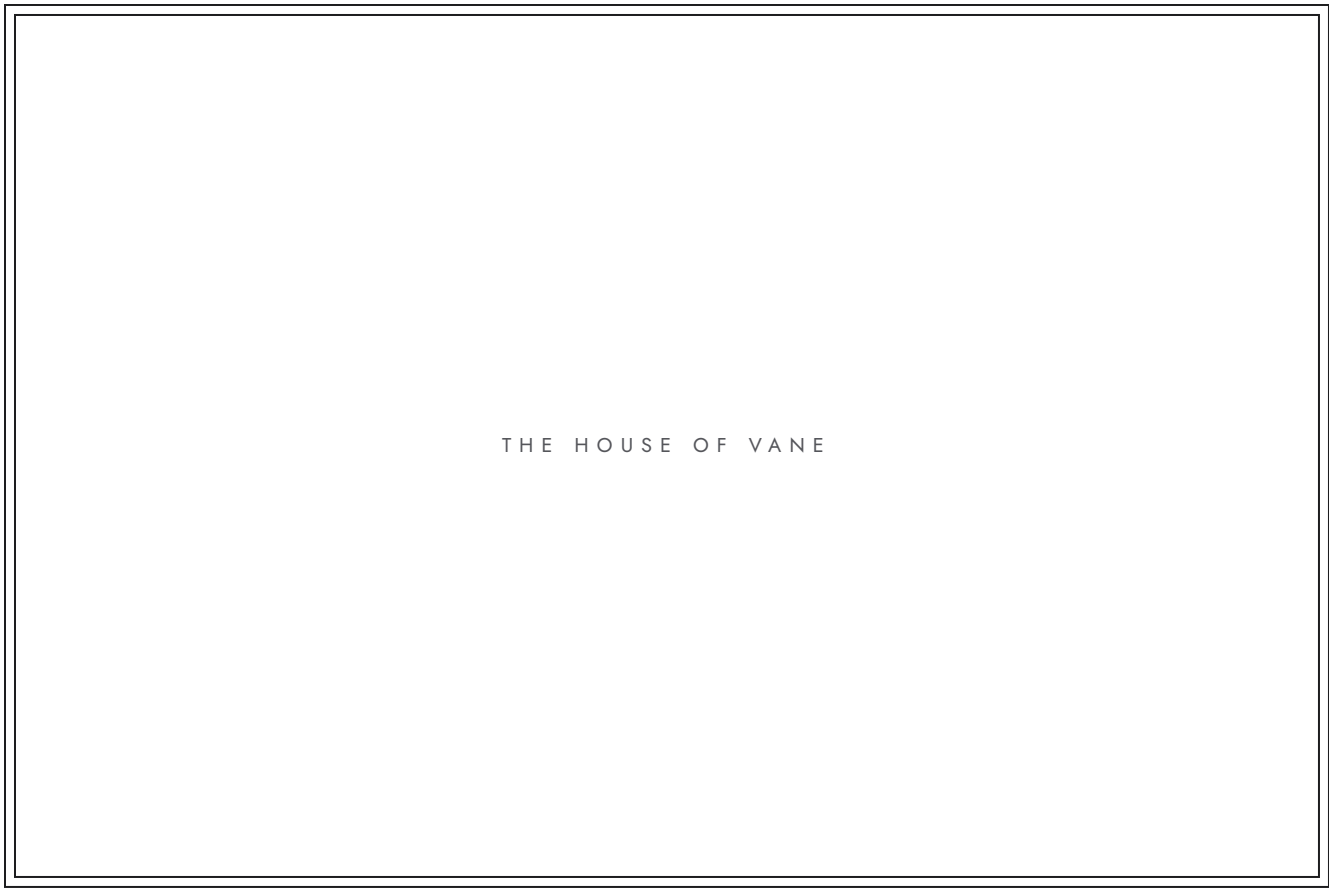
Dorian Vane (Emperor since 2085). The removed heir's son. He took the throne at 40 and is 59 in 2104 (**TL, Ruling**). He was spared because a child's claim can be supervised. Removing him would have needed a public reason, while raising him inside the house needed none (**FR 38**). He has known since 2061 that the documents name Elias (**FR 44**). Under him the Broadcast became genuinely sophisticated, and the Trials became the most-watched event of the year (**TL**).

OPEN QUESTION Who was the mother of Elias's children? Crest was born about twenty years before Sera Callum, and his elder sibling earlier still.

SUPERSEDED The Crownward file gives Dorian's age as 61. Your ruling uses 59, which matches the timeline and the Audit Master.

The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent (TL, FR 40–44). In 2098, during a Crown advisory access period, Azrael found a ledger in the east wing archive. It ties the Empire's founding documents to a series of deliberate removals, which the Covenant of Purpose describes as God's order and the ledger describes as something else. It had sat there unmoved since 2085, because nobody was looking (**FR 41**). He took it to his father, who told him to put it back. Azrael kept it and went looking for its companion, the Covenant of Dissent. Elias wrote it in the same year, in the same hand, as the theological counter-argument to everything the Empire was built on.

Dorian removed both documents the week Azrael was declared dead (**FR 42**). He told Azrael to put the ledger back because a document Azrael had read and returned would be one Dorian controlled. Destroying it would have told Azrael it mattered (**FR 43**).



THE HOUSE OF VANE *Elias and his unknown first wife, the removed heir, Crest, Dorian and Lyris, Azrael and Judah, with the 2061 removal marked*

Working Questions

1. What exactly were the "deliberate removals" in the ledger: people, populations, records, or all three?
2. What does the Covenant of Dissent argue, in a sentence Elias could have preached? Why did he write it: doubt, insurance, vanity, or something else?
3. What did the removed heir know or do that made removal necessary in 2061? FR 35–38 cover how it happened and why Dorian was spared, but not why the heir had to go.
4. Who was Elias's first wife, and how does the Empire's official history treat her?
5. Where did Sera Callum come from, if not a "Northern Dominion"?
6. What does the Restoration Act's preamble say?
7. How do schools in Pacific teach the Partition, and how does that differ from what Pacific grandmothers say at home?
8. What did Celeste's grandmother lose when the signs changed? Who was she before the Fall?

9. Which lines from the 2033 sermon does every schoolchild know by heart?

Working pages

PART VI

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PART VII

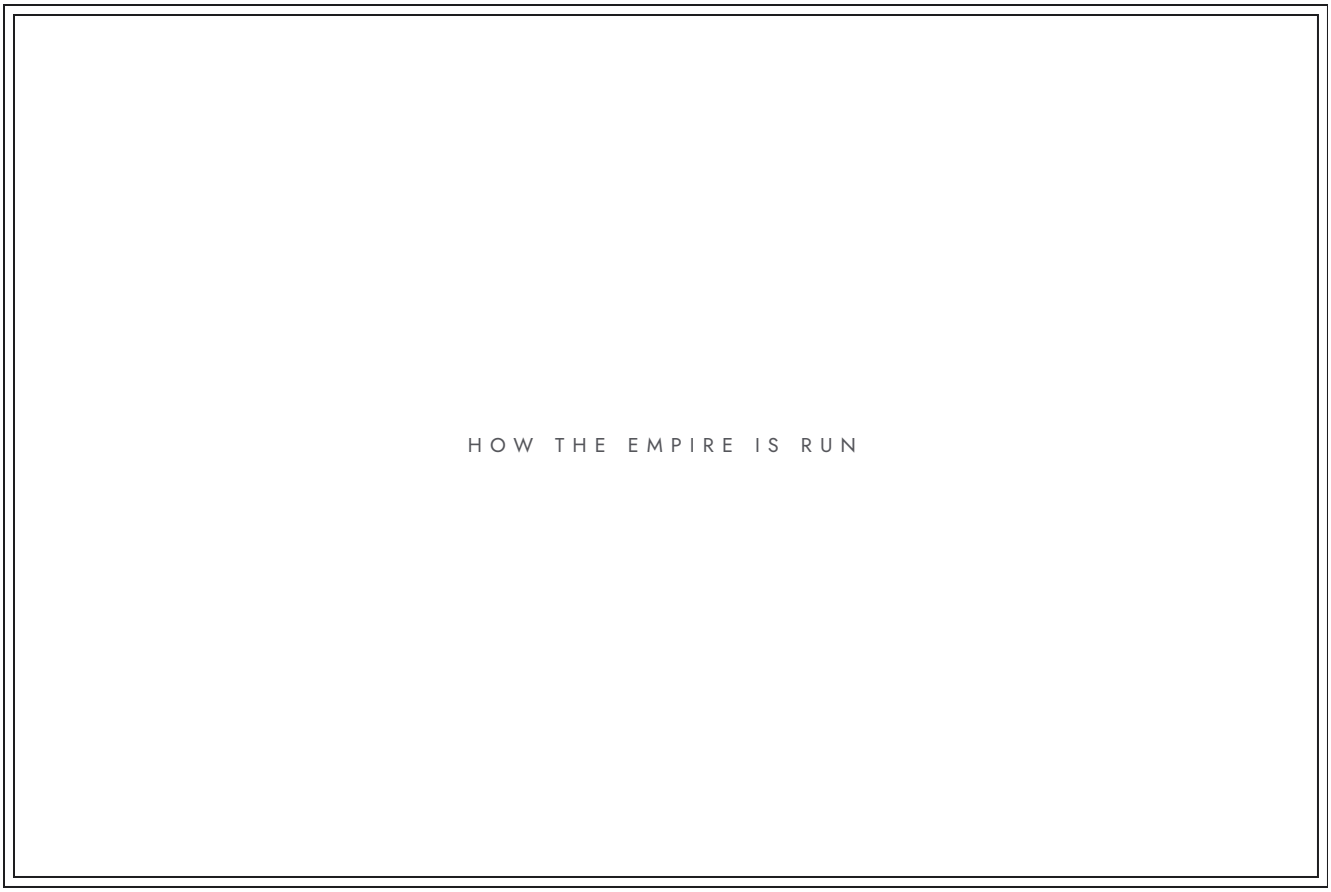
The Covenant Empire: government and institutions

*The Empire is run by three constitutional bodies: the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast, an arrangement called the Triune Rule of 2051 (**TL**). Underneath them sit twelve Dominions, each under a Governor-Prelate, along with a Registry that holds everyone's paper and a Vowed order that watches everyone's daughters. This part covers how those pieces fit together and where each one shows up in the book.*

VII.1 The Triune Rule

In 2051 the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast were made the three governing bodies of the Empire. What had worked informally since 2043 became constitutional, and the Broadcast stopped being a network of Coalition media companies and became a branch of government (**TL**).

The three bodies split the Covenant Trials between them. The Temple runs Phase One and the Crown runs Phase Two. Endurance belongs to the terrain. The Covenant Score is weighted 30 percent Temple, 30 percent Crown and 40 percent Broadcast (**TR**). The Broadcast's share is never disclosed, because the public would be angry to learn that a broadcaster outweighs the Church in choosing the Empire's most powerful woman (**TR**).



HOW THE EMPIRE IS RUN *the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast across the top, the Governor-Prelates, the Registry, the Vowed and the Covenant Court beneath*

VII.2 The Crown and the House of Vane

Every Emperor is a descendant of Elias Vane, who founded the House of Vane in 2054 (**TL**). The Temple teaches that God chose Elias to restore the nation and that the Vane bloodline carries that anointing forward. The family's status is theological, not just political (**CR**).

RULER	YEARS	HOW HE HELD POWER	SOURCE
Elias Vane	First Elector 2043, Emperor 2054–2061	Belief. A preacher who made people want what he wanted.	**TL, AM**
Crest Vane	2062–2085	Procedure: quotas, designations, criminal categories and the Trials	**TL**
Dorian Vane	2085 to now. 59 in 2104.	Performance. He brought back the spectacle and made the Trials the year's biggest event.	**TL, Ruling**
Judah Elijah Vane	Crown Heir, 25 in 2104	Not yet. Raised by the Temple as much as by his parents.	**TL**

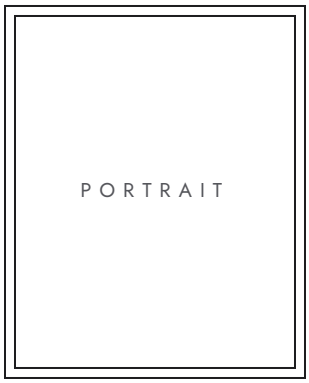
Succession runs by survivorship and the absence of any other recognized claimant (**FR 39**). Crest inherited after his elder sibling was removed in 2061. Dorian, that sibling's son, inherited after Crest died (**FR 35, 39**). When Azrael was declared dead in 2100, the line passed to Judah (**TL**).

SUPERSEDED The Crownward file calls Crest Dorian's father. Under FR 35, Crest is Dorian's uncle.

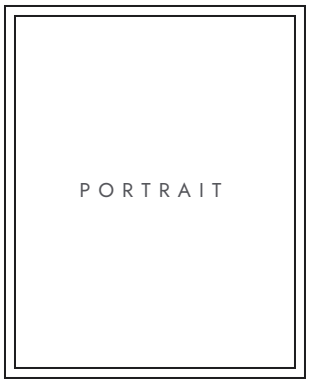
The Crown Heir's marriage is a matter of state. Dorian has pushed Judah toward an Anointed Wife since Judah turned 23, because an unmarried heir is an heir whose loyalties are still unwritten (**CR**). Elite men usually marry between 25 and 35. The Trials exist partly because of Judah's reluctance, to make the choice feel like an honor instead of pressure (**MEN**). Young members of the House take part in "Crown advisory access periods," which is how Azrael got legitimate access to the east wing archive (**TL, FR 41**).

Lyris Vane is 58. She's the Empress and the most sophisticated political operator in the Empire, and she's spent thirty years performing perfect Anointed Wifehood while running the Crownward's domestic and diplomatic machinery. She lobbied through Dorian for a decade to shape the Anointed Wife's legal protections, and she framed every gain as his gift (**CR**). She came from Mountain Dominion (**WR**). (Volume Two, Lyris.)

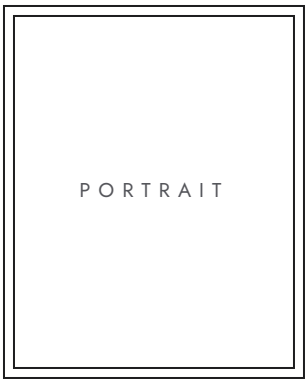
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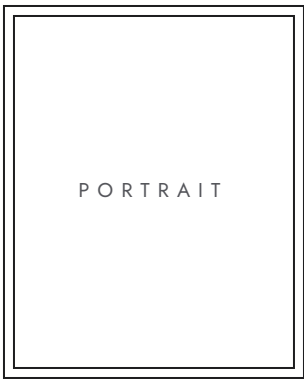
Dorian Vane
Emperor since 2085, 59



Lyris Vane
Empress, 58



Judah Elijah Vane
Crown Heir, 25



Azrael Vane
declared dead 2100

VII.3 The Crownward

The Crownward is the capital, built over Washington, D.C. and formally established in 2043. Elias chose to occupy the old capital instead of moving it, because you don't abandon the seat of the thing you claim to restore (**CR**). Most people in 2104 have never seen a photograph of Washington (**CR**).

The Potomac is now the Covenant River, and it divides the city (**CR**).

- **The Sovereign Side (west bank)** is where power lives: white stone, dark iron and formal rows of magnolias. The Crown Palace sits at its highest point. The Temple Sanctum stands at a right angle to it, joined by a covered walkway called the Covenant Bridge. The Broadcast Citadel sits on the northern edge, placed so its cameras can see the Palace and the Sanctum at once. Sovereign Boulevard runs half a mile from the Palace

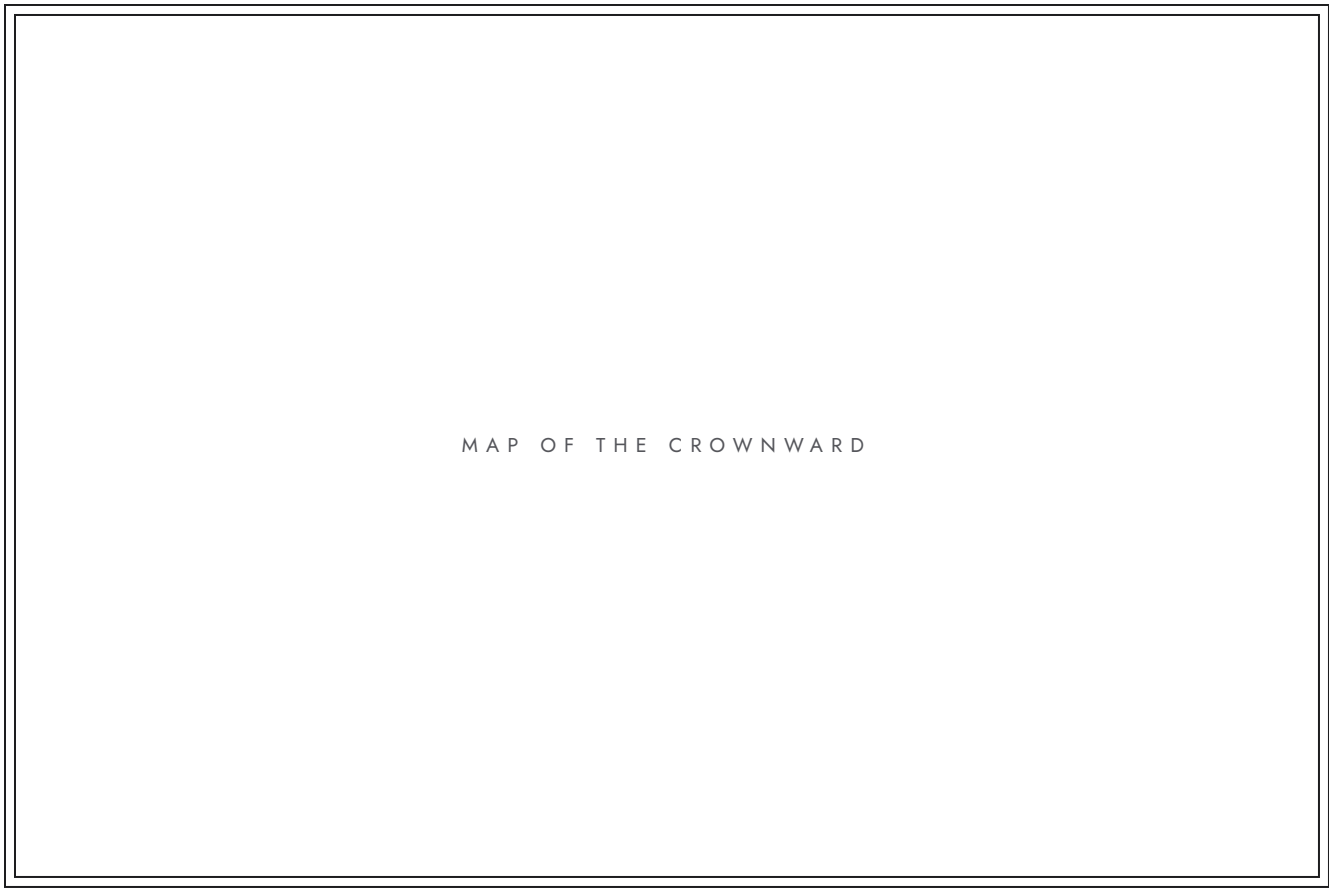
gates to the river, lined with Broadcast screens that show the Covenant Scores during Trial season. Covenant Row runs parallel to it and holds the twelve Covenant Houses, one per Dominion.

- **The Administrative Side (east bank)** is where the Empire does its actual work. It holds the Covenant Court's offices, the Crown's administrative apparatus, staff housing, the Vowed training facilities, the registration bureaus and the Registry. It also has market streets, Temple-adjacent schools and small restaurants serving food from across the Dominions.
- **Three bridges** cross the river. The Sovereign Bridge is the widest and appears on the currency. The Covenant Bridge, the river one, is narrower and used by staff. The Grace Bridge is the oldest, never fully renovated, and has blind spots in Broadcast coverage, so it's where people go when they don't want to be filmed.

RESEARCH In the real city, central Washington sits on the Potomac's east bank, and the west bank is Arlington, Virginia. Read literally, the Sovereign Side stands where Arlington National Cemetery and the Pentagon are now.

POSSIBLE Somebody in the Crownward knows the Crown Palace is built over the old national cemetery.

The Crownward has a rigid social order that nobody writes down and everybody enforces (**CR**). The House of Vane is at the top. Below it is the Anointed Court, about forty families whose standing is measured by how close they live to the Palace, and who must attend quarterly audiences with the Emperor. Below them is the Administrative Class, the senior staff of the Crown, Temple and Broadcast, most of whose wives hold Stewardwife designation. The Crownward's daughters who enter the Trials are rarely the most celebrated candidates, and they're almost always the most dangerous (**CR**).



MAP OF THE CROWNWARD *the Covenant River, both banks, the three bridges, the Palace, the Sanctum, the Citadel, Sovereign Boulevard, Covenant Row and the Registry*

VII.4 The Temple and the Vowed

The Temple is both a church and a branch of government. In Eden's world it shows up as ministers, Vowed women and doctrine. Its scripture is read from a book called the Book of Covenant (**DR3**), and the Temple Sanctum in the Crownward is its seat (**CR**).

Ministers. Senior Minister Bell is the model: a man who signs Binding certificates, sponsors Assessment candidates, and prays God will close every door not intended for a girl (**DR3**). The Temple High Prelates sit in the Anointed Court (**CR**).

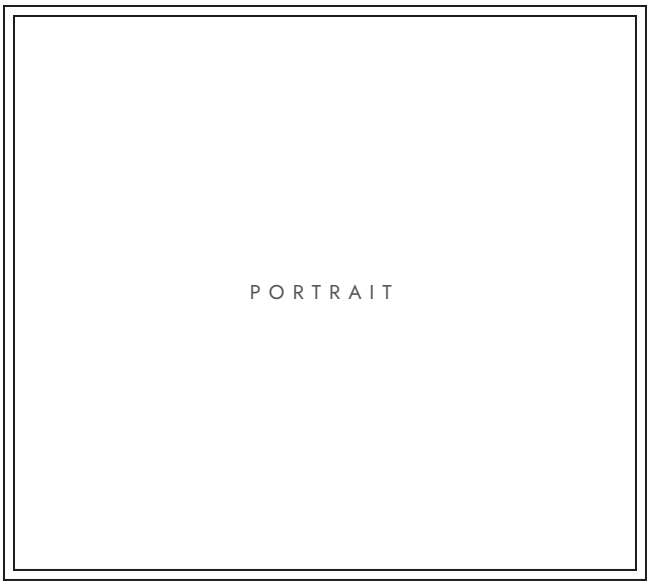
The Vowed. These are women in Temple service, and they run most of the Empire's contact with women. A Vowed officer assesses every Aurem girl at eighteen (**DOM**). Vowed officers conduct the quarterly household assessments in Aurem's Commonwife households (**MEN**), run the Regional Assessments (**TR**), and observe, examine and interview the Covenant Daughters (**TR**). The Crownward Vowed are the Temple's elite. They're also the Empire's most efficient intelligence network. The Temple calls it spiritual discernment and the Crown uses it as surveillance, and it's never written down anywhere the Empire could confiscate it (**CR**). In Red Earth, Vowed officers attend school performances as "pastoral care" (**DOM**).

The Vowed designation can be left behind through marriage. Delphine's mother went from Vowed to Bonded Wife, and Hannah was Vowed before she became House Mother (**TR, FR 30**). Sera Callum was Vowed when Elias married her (**TL**). Girls train through a Vowed education program, which Hannah's daughter Naomi has one year left in (**TL**).

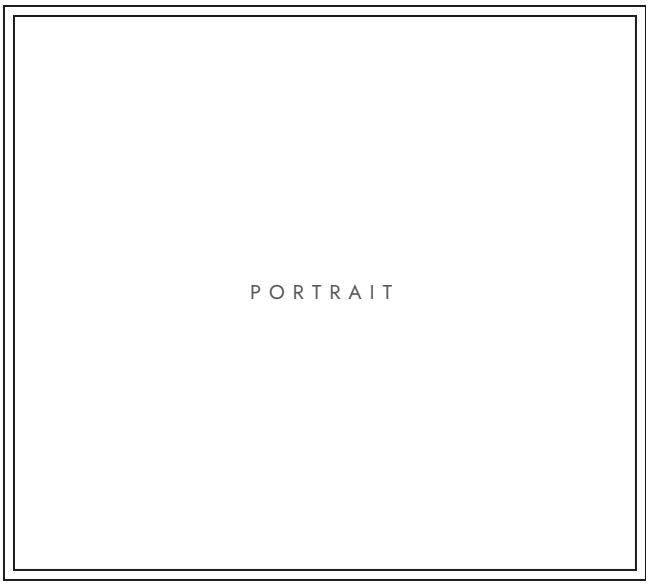
The Prelate. She heads the Crownward's Vowed. She's 67, has served three Emperors, and is the most institutionally knowledgeable person in the city about how power actually works. She assessed Judah's spiritual formation personally. In the first week of the Trial she'll reach a conclusion about Eden that she shares with no one, the Emperor included (**CR**). She anoints the Crown Heir's bride (**CR**). The files call her Prelate Naomi, but FR 33 renames her so Hannah's daughter can keep the name.

POSSIBLE "Prelate Aurelia" is the working name until you choose one (**FR, closing note**).

PORTRAITS



The Prelate
head of the Crownward Vowed, 67, working name Prelate Aurelia



Senior Minister Bell
Aurelia Temple

VII.5 The Broadcast

The Broadcast is the Empire's state media and its third branch of government. Its Citadel stands in the Crownward (**CR**), and its studios, the ones where Trial scores are announced, sit in old Midtown Manhattan in Saint Meridian, the Empire's Broadcast capital (**DOM**). It holds 40 percent of the Covenant Score. Its share includes "narrative priority decisions" by the Broadcast Director that shift weight toward the candidates it favors (**TR**). It edits the Civic Debates for Dominion release and builds a story around every candidate in real time (**TR, CR**). When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, it runs the "Eve narrative," which implies and never accuses (**TR**). See Part XI.

VII.6 Governor-Prelates and the Dominions

Each Dominion is governed by a Governor-Prelate, a single political and religious office (**TL**). Governor-Prelates choose each Dominion's Covenant Daughter from the top three of the Regional Assessment, and in practice they take whoever the Crown has quietly signaled it prefers (**TR**). How much each one actually controls varies a lot (**DOM**).

- Gulf's first Governor-Prelate lasted fourteen months.
- Lone's has always been born in Texas and has more independence than the rest.
- Pacific's was personally appointed by Dorian.
- Ardenne's has mostly stopped trying to fix the marriage records from outside Ashford.

See Part X.

VII.7 The Registry, the law and the paperwork

The Registry, on the Administrative Side, holds every citizen's Imperial record: birth designations, marriage registrations, Covenant Scores, Designation results and death records. Only the Crown Palace is guarded more heavily. Whoever controls what the Registry says about you controls something more basic than law, faith or the Broadcast (**CR**). Eden will understand this before most people in the story (**CR**).

Imperial law is interpreted by the Covenant Court. It keeps offices on the Administrative Side and secondary chambers in Blessed Shore, where the law "gets interpreted, refined, and weaponized" (**CR, DOM**).

In daily life the law arrives as forms.

- Household forms demand an adult male authority. Celeste wrote "deceased" on the line, and the form came back with the word circled and a request for the next adult male (**DR3**).
- A woman reclassifying her household under her own registration has to prove the arrangement is permanent (**TL**).
- Moving between Dominions requires Crown authorization. It's technically available and practically difficult (**MEN**).
- Any Ungoverned citation disqualifies a woman from the Covenant Registry (**TR**).
- Deaths are registered within 48 hours in the Crownward and within 24 in Meridian (**CR, DOM**).

OPEN QUESTION What does an Ungoverned citation actually do to a person beyond disqualifying her? Is it criminal record, designation, or both?

VII.8 Surveillance

Cameras and Broadcast screens are everywhere in the seat cities. The Covenant Houses are wired in every common area, entrance and garden, but not the bedrooms. Leaving bedrooms unwatched is a deliberate choice to give candidates the illusion of privacy, which keeps them manageable (**CR**). Pacific has more cameras per block than any other Dominion (**DOM**). Red Earth embeds its Vowed in community life (**DOM**).

Records can be flagged. Eden's file reads "Exceptional intellect. Monitor closely," later updated to "Selected for Trial. Monitor closely" (**TL**). Sera's file was flagged before she arrived (**TL**).

The gaps are just as much a part of the world: the Grace Bridge (**CR**), the hollows of Ardenne (**DOM**), the Sable desert (**DOM**), west Lone's distances (**DOM**), and Saint Meridian's density (**DOM**). Endurance in Mountain terrain runs mostly without cameras (**TR**).

VII.9 Men, Labor and the Economy

The Empire controls women through designation and men through structure. Men are told they're free, and the control sits in housing, careers and marriage approvals (**MEN**).

CLASS	WHO THEY ARE	MARRIAGE	SOURCE
Common men	The labor and service class, registered to their Dominion	Expected by 21. Unmarried men past 22 stay in labor dormitories. They marry within their caste and region.	**MEN**
Bonded men	Mid-tier administrators and skilled professionals, steered by Crown labor allocation	Between 21 and 25, from Unbound and Commonwife-eligible women, with Crown approval of the match	**MEN**
Covenant men	Elite: Crown officers, Temple leadership, Broadcast directors, senior military	Between 25 and 35. Their wives are Anointed.	**MEN**
Conscript men	Common boys whose scores flag them. Officially they don't exist.	Crown approval required at the Covenant Man level, for life	**MEN**

A common boy whose Designation scores come back exceptional gets a visit from a Crown education officer within three months, offering a scholarship to the Imperial Education Track. The family can decline. Declining routes the boy to the worst labor assignments for the rest of his life. Accepting makes him Crown-adjacent for life (**MEN**). (Volume Two, Solomon.)

At 18, common men register a Covenant Declaration with the Crown: a public statement of loyalty and readiness for service and marriage. Elite men register theirs when they finish the Imperial Education Track (**MEN**). Every Dominion layers its own rites over it. See Part VIII.4.

Each Dominion has its own economy (**DOM**).

- Irongate: manufacturing
- Lone: oil and space infrastructure
- Mountain: classified operations, resource extraction and military capacity
- Gulf: tourism, rebranded as "cultural pilgrimage"
- Meridian: law and administration
- Vane: the Broadcast

INFERENCE The forty percent of working-class jobs lost to automation during the Fracture Years never came back, which is why Imperial service looks like opportunity to a common man.

Working Questions

1. Who sits on the Trials Commission, and is it the same body as the TR file's "joint oversight committee"?
2. What does the Book of Covenant contain? Is it a full Bible, an edited one, or a separate collection with the Empire's own texts added?
3. What does it mean, legally, to be designated Ungoverned? What happens to a woman's children?
4. What does a Crown advisory access period involve, and who else in the House of Vane has had one?
5. How did Lyris, a woman from Mountain Dominion, become Dorian's wife? What did the Trials have to do with it, if anything?
6. What will the Prelate conclude about Eden in the first week, and what will she do with it?
7. What does a Stewardwife in the Administrative Class know that an Anointed Wife doesn't?
8. What can someone on the Grace Bridge do that they can't do anywhere else?
9. Who runs the Registry, and who has ever changed what it says about a person?
10. How does an Aurem common man get Crown authorization to move to another Dominion? How often is it actually granted?

Working pages

PART VII

DECIDED

DATE

PART VIII

Doctrine and lived religion

The Temple's official religion fits in one line. Private religion lives in kitchens, back rooms, deserts and mountains, and it's different in every Dominion. This part covers what the Temple teaches, what texts it rests on, how it uses scripture, and what people actually practice that the Empire doesn't know about or has decided to tolerate.

VIII.1 What the Temple teaches

The official theology of marriage is the center of it: "the husband leads, the wife supports, the household reflects divine order in miniature." It's preached every week in every Temple, taught from the time children can read, and assumed by every law that governs women (**CR**). See Part IX.

The rest of the official teaching comes through in what the files show the Temple saying.

- **The Vane anointing.** The Temple teaches that God chose Elias to restore the nation and that the Vane bloodline carries divine sanction (**CR**). Elias was canonized within a year of his death, "not quite sainthood but close enough" (**TL**).
- **The House judges fairly.** Bell tells Celeste "The House always judges fairly," and Celeste answers "The House calls whom it calls" (**DR3**). Before scores are revealed, Bell speaks about "divine order, talent as stewardship, and elevation as burden." He closes with "May every daughter receive with grace the portion appointed to her" (**DR3**).
- **The House virtues.** The banners in the Aurelia Temple atrium read obedience, discernment, modesty, stewardship and endurance (**DR3**).
- **Selection as revelation.** The Broadcast frames the Trials as a revelation and never as a competition, using words like anointing, covenant, calling, worthy and chosen. A competition can be rigged, while a revelation can't be (**TR**).
- **Being Bound as service.** "Every girl in Aurem wanted to be Bound. It was the only way they knew how to serve" (**DR3**). Covenant Candidacy is "the closest thing a woman could get to godliness" (**DR3**).

VIII.2 The founding texts

The sermon, *Thy Kingdom Come* **(2033).** Six hours long, preached by Elias Vane at The Gathering House. Since 2061 it has been required curriculum in every Dominion school (**TL**). It's named for the line of the Lord's Prayer that the Empire was built on. The novel takes its title from the same words.

INTERPRETATION The old Companion reads the sermon as a familiar prayer taken literally in public for the first time, and that reading is useful. Nobody in the stadium heard a coup. They heard their own prayer said aloud by a man who wasn't embarrassed by it (**AM**).

The Covenant of Purpose. A founding document of the Empire. It describes a series of deliberate removals as God's order, and the east wing ledger describes the same removals as something else (**TL**). Celeste can recite it (AM, Celeste dossier).

The Covenant of Dissent. Written by Elias in the same hand and the same year as the Empire's founding, as the theological counter-argument to everything the Empire was built on. It was catalogued in library holdings until 2100, when it disappeared the same week as the ledger (**TL**). Judah has been looking for it since before his brother's exile (**TL**).

The Book of Covenant. The book Bell reads from at the Assessment. It includes Proverbs 31:29, "Many daughters have done virtuously, but thou excellest them all," in King James wording (**DR3**).

OPEN QUESTION Is the Book of Covenant the full Protestant Bible, an abridged edition (see I.7 and Part V on the 1807 Slave Bible), or scripture bound together with the Empire's own founding texts?

VIII.3 Scripture in the Empire's Hands

Draft Three shows the method directly. The Assessment's doctrine section turns scripture into House policy (**DR3**).

PASSAGE	WHAT THE ASSESSMENT MADE OF IT
"Honor thy father and thy mother" (Exodus 20:12)	A question about reporting an Unbound woman who housed her children without male authority
The widow's oil (2 Kings 4)	An argument for household rationing
Esther's crown	Proof that a woman could influence government, "so long as she was beautiful, obedient, and prepared to die for the privilege"
Proverbs 31	The verse printed on the first page of the Assessment and read aloud before the scores

Eden's own read on this: "Facts might earn professional placement. Knowing which facts the House needed her to believe could carry her farther" (**DR3**).

Your Writing Rules ask that biblical truth in the narration be accurate and that the Empire's distortions be deliberate (**WR 38–42**). The research behind that line lives in Parts I–V. The household code (Ephesians 5) is worked through in I.7.

VIII.4 Lived religion: what people actually practice

In every Dominion, people do things around the official rites that the Empire either doesn't know about, tolerates because stopping them would cost too much, or eventually approves because it already lost (**DOM, MEN**).

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
Aurem	The Salt Ceremony	The bride's mother or grandmother washes her hands in salt water the night before her Binding and tells her the truth about marriage	Doesn't know it exists
Aurem	The old way of burial	Three days, family-led, no Empire officiant: the Telling, the Feeding, the Release. Red clay packed down by family hands.	Doesn't know. The paperwork is filed anyway.
Aurem	The Speaking	The night before a boy's Covenant Declaration, each man present tells him one true thing about being a man in Aurelia. The boy can't speak.	Unregulated
Aurem	Kitchens	Recipes that "looked like submission and tasted like memory." Women cook what they don't write down.	Never thought the kitchen was worth watching
Gulf	Music in worship	Live music at Bindings, against three ordinances, classed as "ceremonial expression within approved parameters"	Tolerated for tourism money
Gulf	The Last Free Night	The women of the family dance, drink and tell the bride the truth the night before her Binding	Never on paper
Gulf	The Procession	At 14, girls walk the boulevard in white, and the crowd turns it into a second line	Can't be stopped without a Broadcast incident
Gulf	Funerals	Three days of open house, a second line to the grave, then the Quiet, one hour of complete silence	Approved in 2052
Ardenne	Hollow marriages	A community declaration and a broom jump	Records left incomplete
Ardenne	The First Winter Work and the Sitting	A real job in the community's survival at 13 or 14. Sitting with the dead through the night.	Unregulated
Meridian	Reading Circles	Officially Temple Bible studies. Actually a legal-literacy network for Stewardwives, running since 2069.	Doesn't know what they are
Meridian	The record	Before his Declaration, a father walks his son through the family's complete Imperial record	Within the rules

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
Vane	Ghost Marriages and the Ghost Declaration	Unions outside registration, and a boy's private statement of what he actually intends	Doesn't know they exist
Irongate	The Kitchen	The women's mutual aid network	Never mapped by the Vowed
Irongate	The Placement and the First Shift	Community assessments of a girl's work at 14 and a boy's first adult shift at 18	Unregulated
Irongate	Music	Blues and jazz, classed "morally ambiguous musical forms" in 2053	Officially suppressed, survives underground
Heartland	The Anointing	The women wash and braid the bride's hair, each speaking a private word over her	"The most tender thing the Empire accidentally preserved"
Heartland	Planting	After a burial the community plants something that will come back	Approved in 2058
Red Earth	The Second Covenant	The morning after a Binding, a mother tells her daughter what the first covenant means and what she's allowed to keep for herself	Unrecorded, word for word across the Dominion
Red Earth	Score coaching	For twenty years mothers have taught high-scoring sons how much ability to show	Never documented
Red Earth	Sitting with the dead	Women sit with the body in shifts, and burial is at midday	Never understood, so never regulated
Lone	The Giving and the First Ride	The bride receives something of her grandmother's. A girl navigates a long distance alone.	Never acknowledged
Lone	Boots	The dead are buried with boots on	Approved without being understood
Mountain	The Witness Walk	A couple walks alone in the mountains before the ceremony	Unregulated
Mountain	The name to the mountain	A death prayer said once, with the name spoken to the mountain itself	Unregulated
Sable	Desert names	Every woman has two names, one for the Empire and one for the house. A girl earns hers at the Finding.	Doesn't know they exist

DOMINION	PRACTICE	WHAT IT IS	THE EMPIRE'S POSITION
Sable	The Desert Walk and fire burials	A couple's night alone in the desert. The name said once into a fire that's left to burn out.	Unregulated
Pacific	The Real Binding	A private ceremony with the promises the couple actually means	Unregistered
Pacific	Facing West	A boy faces the ocean at dawn, then turns back to the city. The dead are buried facing west.	Burial rules ignored until the Empire gave up in 2078

INFERENCE Where the files don't say how the Empire treats a practice, the last column reads "Unregulated." The files give no sign the Empire has noticed those practices, but they never say so outright.

INTERPRETATION A pattern runs through the table. The Empire approves what it's already lost (Gulf funerals, Heartland planting), and it tolerates what makes money (Gulf music). What women do in kitchens, at bedsides and the night before a wedding mostly goes unseen, because the Empire never thought those places were worth watching. Celeste's whole faith is built in that blind spot.

VIII.5 Faith That Isn't Performance

The files are careful not to make every believer a dupe. Heartland faith is genuine, and real believers "have opinions about what faithfulness actually requires" (**DOM**). Heartland women questioning the Commonwife designation call it theological inquiry, and they mean it (**DOM**). Ruth Gideon "believes the Empire more than Eden does," and she's sincere without being foolish (**WR 26**). Eden's own faith is real and "required more maintenance" than Maribel Vale's (**DR3**). Celeste is, by the old dossier's description, the most religious person in the book and the least Imperial (**AM**).

INTERPRETATION The novel's religious line doesn't run between belief and unbelief. It runs between faith the Temple can use and faith that answers to something the Temple doesn't control.

Working Questions

1. What does the Covenant of Purpose actually say? Write the passage about the removals in the Empire's own voice.
2. What does the Covenant of Dissent argue, and which line in it would get someone arrested today?
3. What is the Empire's official text of the Lord's Prayer? Has anything been cut, added or re-translated?
4. Which verses are carved over the doors of the Aurelia Temple and the Temple Sanctum?
5. What happens to a woman caught performing a Salt Ceremony, if anyone ever has been?

6. Has Eden attended a Salt Ceremony, or only heard about one? Has she seen an old-way burial?
7. What did the men tell Zion at his Speaking? Pick one line Eden will never hear.
8. Is there an Aurem equivalent of Meridian's Reading Circles or Irongate's Kitchen, a network of women that Celeste belongs to?
9. What hymns does the Temple approve, and what do people sing in the outer districts instead?
10. What does a Heartland woman's "theological inquiry" into the Commonwife designation actually argue? This matters for Ruth.

Working pages

PART VIII

DECIDED

DATE

PART IX

Women, marriage and the household order

*Since the Restoration Act of 2041, a woman's citizenship has depended on her marital status, and marriage has been a legal and theological designation (**TL**). The Empire controls women by telling each one what she is and making that classification the frame of her whole life. It's visible, documented and enforced through paperwork, ceremony and public record (**MEN**). This part lays out the designations, how a girl gets sorted into one, how the Binding works, and what the household looks like on paper.*

IX.1 The designations

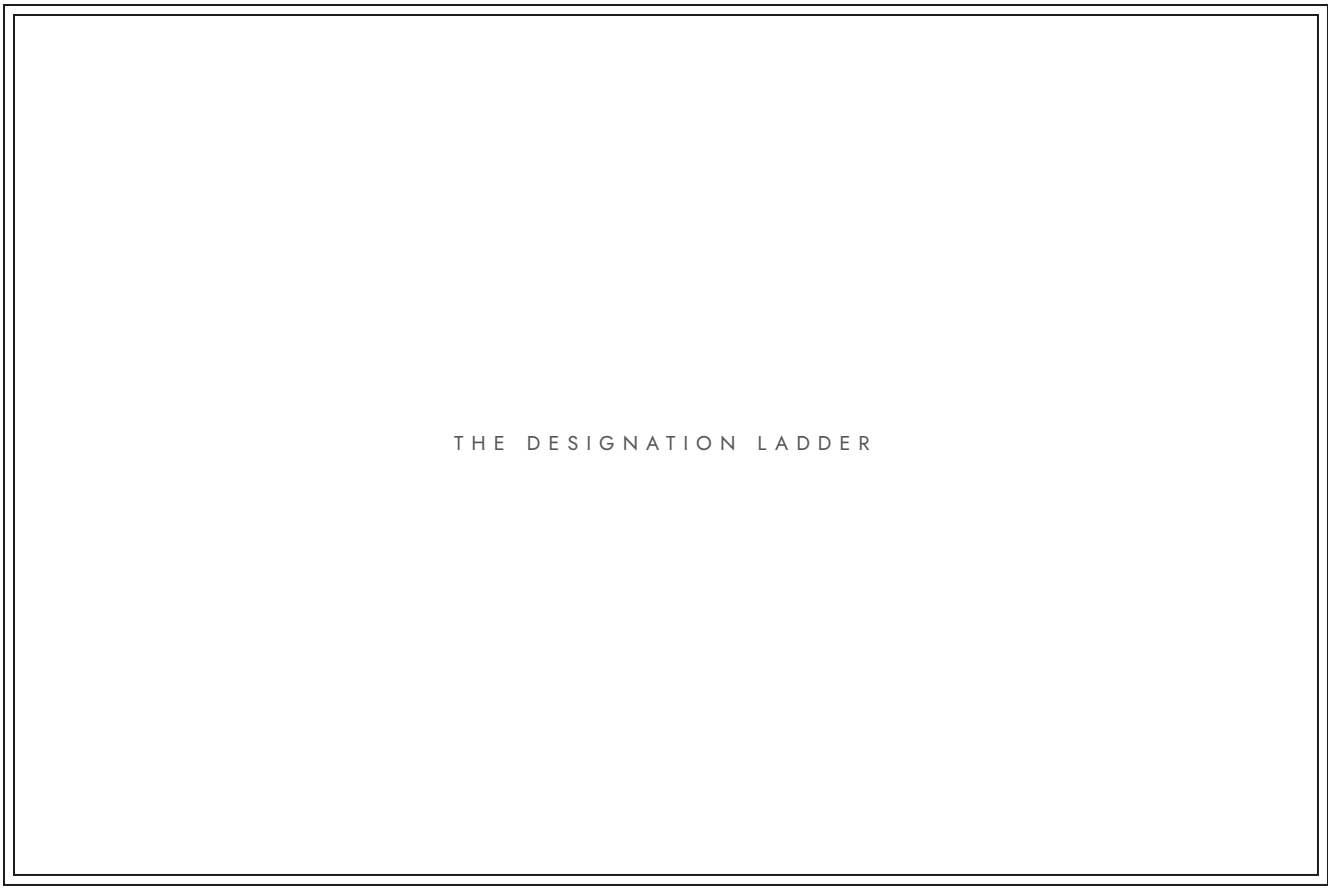
The files name these statuses for women.

DESIGNATION	WHAT IT IS	SOURCE
Anointed Wife	The elite tier. Wife of a Covenant man, and the status the Trials produce. It's attached to the marriage, so a widow loses it.	**CR, MEN, FR 19**
Stewardwife	Wife of the Administrative Class: elevated enough for status, constrained enough to be manageable. Aurelia has "Stewardwife districts."	**CR, DOM**
Bonded Wife	The tier Delphine's mother entered when she left the Vowed to marry. Probably the wife of a Bonded man (INFERENCE).	**TR**
Commonwife	A registration status, not a description (**FR 1**). Wife of a common man. Subject to quotas, the child quota and Temple review.	**TL, MEN, FR 1**
Vowed	Women in Temple service: assessors, officiants, observers. A woman can leave by marrying.	**CR, TR, DOM**
Unbound	Unmarried. Celeste has held it her whole life. "Difficult and surveilled."	**TL**
Ungoverned	Outside the system altogether. Women who chose exile over designation. Criminal since 2062.	**TL, DOM**

INFERENCE Older notes describe a six-tier caste system for women. Leaving out Ungoverned, which sits outside the system, there are six designations above: Anointed, Stewardwife, Bonded, Commonwife, Vowed and Unbound.

OPEN QUESTION Is that the six? If so, what's the official order, and where does Vowed rank?

The Widowed Covenant (**CR**) covers Anointed widows. Because the designation belongs to the marriage, a widow holds a temporary status for two years that keeps most of her protections. She's expected to remarry within the Anointed class, or she drops to Stewardwife. The senior Anointed Wives run a network so efficient that no widow has ever fallen below Stewardwife.



THE DESIGNATION LADDER *how a woman moves between designations, and where each door locks*

IX.2 Being sorted: Designation

Every girl is assessed and given an initial classification. In Aurem it happens at eighteen, by a Vowed officer, testing literacy, theological knowledge and "domestic aptitude." The result is a preliminary designation on the Unbound track or the elevated track. The elevated track means better education and a chance at Covenant Daughter consideration (**DOM**).

The age and method vary by Dominion (**DOM**).

DOMINION	WHEN AND HOW
Aurem	At 18, assessed by a Vowed officer
Gulf	At 14, the Procession, "a declaration of loyalty and readiness for designation"

DOMINION	WHEN AND HOW
Ardenne	Standard Designation in Ashford. Hollow children are tested only when they can be brought in.
Meridian	Three-day sessions: theology, written reasoning, policy and "relational compliance"
Vane	At 16, the Broadcast Assessment, partly filmed
Irongate	At 14, the community Placement. At 18, Imperial Designation.
Heartland	At 13, the First Covenant, where her track is publicly set
Red Earth	At 18, two weeks in Temple spaces, Crown facilities and "domestic simulation environments"
Lone	At 16 in Covenant Basin. The First Ride in the outer territories.
Mountain	At 16, with a physical assessment. Girls selected for classified Vowed service disappear from public life.
Sable	At 18 in Sable Reach. The Finding in outer communities.
Pacific	At 18. Every score is reviewed in the Crownward for signs of inherited resistance.

The Regional Assessment for the Covenant Trials is a separate process for women 18 to 25 on a Dominion's Covenant Registry. See Part XI. The placements on the Aurelia board in Draft Three show where an assessed girl can land: Administration, Education, Domestic Service, Housekeeping, Food Service, Binding Recommendation and Remedial Instruction (**DR3**). Strong doctrine scores can lead to Temple Administration. Strong household judgment can earn a Binding recommendation. Girls who test well everywhere can go on to professional placement (**DR3**).

IX.3 The Binding

The Binding is marriage as legal and theological designation (**TL**). In Aurem it's held in a Temple, witnessed by a Vowed officiant, and registered with the Crown and the Temple at the same time. The bride wears white and gold and takes a new surname hyphenated with her husband's. "Nobody asks if she consents. They ask if she is worthy. The correct answer is yes" (**DOM**). Ministers sign Binding certificates, adding their names beneath each husband's (**DR3**).

Every Dominion's version differs (**DOM**).

- **Meridian:** the most legally elaborate, with registration that can take three weeks.
- **Red Earth:** the most surveilled. Vowed officers witness every Binding, because the quota system needs real-time records.
- **Mountain:** Crown officers witness alongside Temple officiants.
- **Sable Reach:** Bindings happen at dawn.
- **Gulf:** keeps its music.

In the Crownward, a Commonwife Binding is a short registration at the Crown office, while an Administrative Class Binding is a dignified ceremony recorded for the Broadcast (CR).

The Imperial Binding for the Crown Heir has seven public stages (CR).

1. The Declaration
2. Covenant Week
3. The Anointing, a private ceremony on the sixth day in which the Prelate anoints the bride
4. The Binding Night
5. The Grand Binding, four hours in the Temple Sanctum
6. The Public Procession down Sovereign Boulevard
7. The Private Supper, five guests at most

The bride's vows are twice as long as the heir's. The Empire calls that theology. In practice it's a legal document spoken aloud in a sacred building (CR).

OPEN QUESTION Does the hyphenated surname apply only in Aurem, or Empire-wide? Celeste never took a Binding name, so she's still a Parish (AM). Miriam's name after her Binding would be something like Parish-Osei.

IX.4 Commonwife Marriage and the Quotas

Commonwife marriage is how the Empire marries off the labor class. Aurem has the highest Commonwife rate in the Empire, because the Empire deliberately made marriage look like the highest honor available there (DOM). The quotas were introduced under Crest in 2062 (TL), after a pilot in Red Earth in 2058 (DOM). They're the reason Red Earth Bindings are documented in real time (DOM).

A Commonwife is expected to conceive within the Covenant timeline. In Aurem, a Vowed officer conducts quarterly household assessments in Commonwife homes. Two years without a pregnancy brings informal comments first and then Temple review (MEN, TL). (Volume Two, Leah.)

CONFLICT The timeline makes Leah Eden's older sister (TL), and FR 5 calls Leah, Zion and Solomon "the younger three." FR 11 and FR 14, where Leah watched Miriam pack and remembers a decision, read most naturally for an older sister. This volume leaves it for you to decide.

When a husband abandons his Commonwife, she can be reassigned to another man's household, which is what happened to Miriam after Thomas left (FR 0). Thomas left voluntarily in 2084, for another Dominion and another woman, and the record that he relocated is accurate (FR 3). Solomon was born in that later household, kept the Osei name, and is sixteen in 2104 (FR 0).

SUPERSEDED The timeline gives Solomon's age as thirteen. FR 0 keeps him at sixteen.

SUPERSEDED Any framing of Thomas's 2084 departure as an Empire removal (FR 3). **INFERENCE** The timeline's line that Celeste "has always believed otherwise" can stand as her belief. FR 3 makes it mistaken.

OPEN QUESTION How does reassignment work? Who decides it, what is the woman's status during it, and why did Solomon keep the Osei name? FR 0 deliberately leaves these open.

IX.5 Anointed Wives and the Arrangement

The first Anointed marriage was Elias Vane's to Sera Callum in 2048. Every Trial since has tried to manufacture it again on camera (**TL, AM**). All thirty-nine Trials place Anointed wives, and the Crown contest is a layer on top. One woman goes to the heir. The other eleven are married down the elite ladder as designated, and nobody goes home unassigned (**FR 19**).

The elite husbands are chosen by the oversight committee and ranked by standing, not performance. A man can't reject the woman assigned to him, but he can decline the assignment altogether, which removes him from the ladder. It has happened twice (**FR 28**).

Among the Anointed Court, the official theology of male headship is mostly performance. The women run what they call the Arrangement. Wives manage the information, relationships and social intelligence that make their husbands' positions work, and they surface the right idea in private so their husbands can present it in public. They never take credit or contradict their husbands publicly. Their compensation is influence, access and the legal protections of the Anointed designation. New Anointed Wives learn it in their first year of marriage (**CR**). Lyris runs the whole network, which she inherited from the Anointed Wife who mentored her (**CR**). Celeste told Eden about the Arrangement before she ever left Aurem (**CR**).

INFERENCE Ladies in Waiting, the Trial's third- and fourth-place finishers, stay in the Crownward in supporting roles (**TR**). Under FR 19 they would also be married into elite households. The two rules fit together if Ladies in Waiting are placed in Crownward households and serve the Anointed Wife on top of that.

IX.6 Unbound Women and the Household on Paper

Unbound designation is "difficult and surveilled" (**TL**). An Unbound woman can head a household only through reclassification, and household paperwork still demands an adult male authority. Celeste's reclassification took six years, and Solomon's vocational form came back to the house until Zion, at eighteen, declared himself the authority (**TL, DR3**).

The Empire classifies children by household registration, not by parentage or appearance (**FR 32**). This rule applies Dominion-wide, beyond any one character. Hannah's daughter Naomi is eligible through Hannah's household and standing, whatever her father's status is (**FR 31**).

Home Instruction is an opportunity a minister can nominate a young woman for. Bell offered to nominate Leah "for Home Instruction the following year" as a consolation (**DR3**).

OPEN QUESTION What is Home Instruction? Training for wives, a teaching role, or something else?

OPEN QUESTION Bell's offer reads as if Leah sat an Assessment. The timeline has her Bound and under Temple review, so the offer has to date from before her Binding, or one of the two has to change.

The Ungoverned are women who chose exile over designation. Their deepest roots are in the Ardenne hollows, where some communities have lived outside the system for two or three generations. The Empire calls them criminals, and the mountain people call them something closer to saints (**DOM**). Ungoverned crossings happen through the Sable desert (**DOM**). Lone interprets "Ungoverned" loosely and never files a full report (**DOM**). Saint Meridian has the largest population of Ungoverned sympathizers, people embedded in the system who leave gaps in it on purpose (**DOM**).

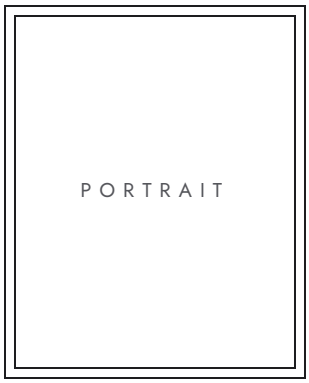
IX.7 What the Households Look Like

POSSIBLE The plainest way to keep the order straight while drafting is to picture the four households the book shows.

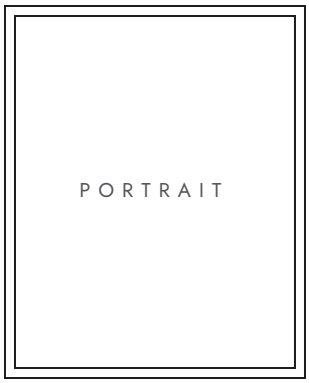
- Celeste's is Unbound, reclassified, with a young man on the authority line.
- Leah's is a Commonwife household under quarterly assessment.
- Hannah's is a former Vowed woman's household whose daughter is eligible through her mother.
- The Anointed Court households run on the Arrangement.

Each one is a different answer to the same law.

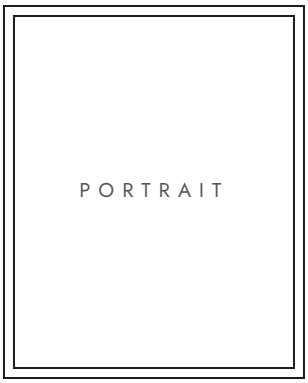
PORTRAITS



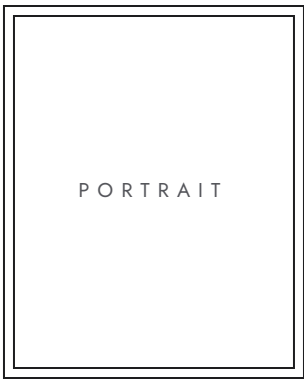
Celeste Parish
69, Unbound



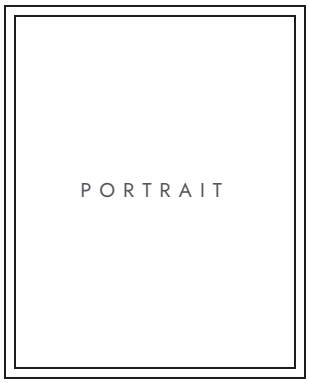
Miriam Osei
Eden's mother, gone since 2090



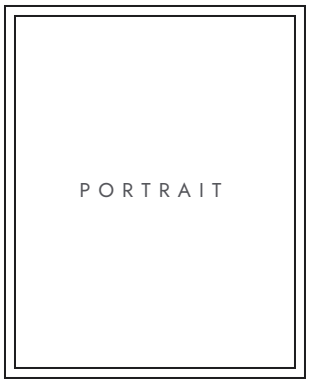
Thomas Osei
Eden's father, left 2084



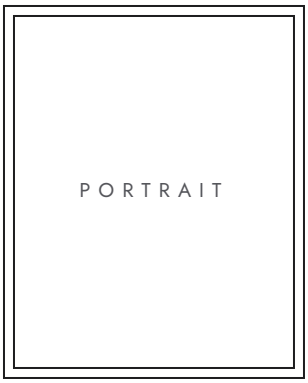
Leah Osei
Eden's sister, Commonwife



Eden Selah Osei
21



Zion Osei
Eden's brother



Solomon Osei
Eden's brother, 16

HOUSEHOLD	WHO'S ON THE PAPER	WHO ACTUALLY DECIDES	WHAT'S ASSESSED	WHAT'S HIDDEN
Celeste's				
Leah's				
Hannah's				
An Anointed Court household				

Working Questions

1. What are the six tiers officially called, and in what order? Can a woman move up, or only down?
2. What exactly is the Covenant timeline for conception, and what happens after Temple review? Is there a step beyond it?
3. How does Commonwife reassignment work, and who in Aurelia decides it?
4. Does the hyphenated Binding surname apply everywhere, or only in Aurem? What did Miriam's name become?
5. What is Home Instruction?
6. What can an Unbound woman legally own, sign or inherit?
7. What happens to a woman's designation if her husband is convicted of something, or declared Ungoverned?
8. Who are the two men who declined their elite assignments (**FR 28**), and what happened to them?
9. What do the senior Anointed Wives do for a Widowed Covenant woman in those two years?
10. What does an Aurem bride actually say when she's asked if she's worthy?
11. How does a girl in the Ardenne hollows end up Ungoverned instead of designated, and does anyone ever go back?

Working pages

PART IX

DECIDED

DATE

PART X

The Twelve Dominions

The Dominion Act of 2044 reorganized the states into twelve Dominions by region and economic function. The borders roughly follow the old state lines but not exactly, since some states were absorbed and some were split (TL). Each Dominion has a seat city renamed from an American city, its own Governor-Prelate, and a culture that's sometimes Imperial on the surface and sometimes all the way through. The rites of passage are collected in Part VIII.4. This part gives each Dominion's history, landscape, culture and record in the Trials.

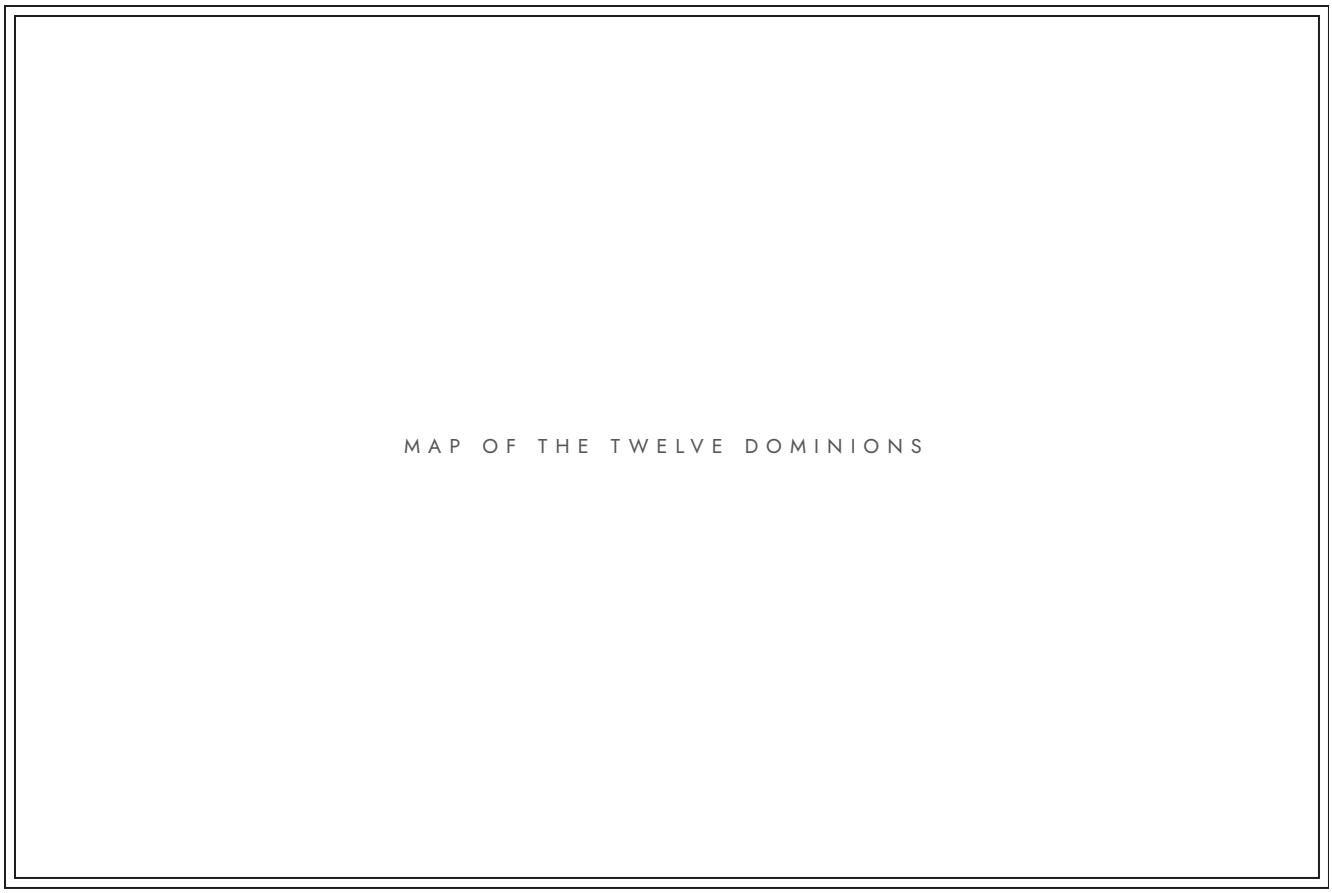
DOMINION	SEAT (FORMERLY)	TERRITORY	IN THE TRIALS
Aurem	Aurelia (Atlanta)	Georgia, Alabama, Mississippi, Tennessee, South Carolina, North Carolina	15 Anointed Wives in 38 Trials, the most of any Dominion
Gulf	Port Seraphine (New Orleans)	Louisiana, the Mississippi Gulf Coast, Florida	Historically penalized for warmth
Ardenne	Ashford (Charleston, WV)	West Virginia, Virginia, Kentucky, Appalachia	Rarely produces Covenant Daughters
Meridian	Blessed Shore (Philadelphia)	Pennsylvania, Maryland, New Jersey, Delaware	Extremely prepared candidates
Vane	Saint Meridian (New York City)	New York and New England	The legacy Dominion, with the most Anointed Wives after Aurem
Irongate	Iron Benediction (Chicago)	Illinois, Indiana, Ohio, Michigan, Wisconsin	Almost always administrative daughters
Heartland	Providence Cross (Kansas City)	Missouri, Kansas, Iowa, Nebraska, Minnesota, the Dakotas	The most theologically fluent
Red Earth	Canaan's Gate (Oklahoma City)	Oklahoma, Arkansas, eastern Kansas, southwestern Missouri	Often scored mid-pack until it's too late
Lone	Covenant Basin (Houston)	Texas, New Mexico, western Louisiana	Pragmatic about the outcome
Mountain	Crestfall (Denver)	Colorado, Wyoming, Montana, Idaho, parts of Utah and Nevada	Has never produced an Anointed Wife
Sable	Sable Reach (Phoenix)	Arizona, Nevada, New Mexico, parts of Utah	"Two Sable women are worth five from anywhere else"

DOMINION	SEAT (FORMERLY)	TERRITORY	IN THE TRIALS
Pacific	Westhold (Los Angeles)	California, Oregon, parts of Nevada	Watched before they arrive

Source for the table and everything in this part: DOM, unless tagged otherwise.

INFERENCE The overlaps (Mississippi, Kansas, Missouri, Louisiana, New Mexico, Nevada and Utah each show up in two Dominions) fit the timeline's "some states split."

OPEN QUESTION Washington, Alaska and Hawaii don't appear in any Dominion. Are they inside Pacific, outside the Empire, or something else?



MAP OF THE TWELVE DOMINIONS *over the old state lines, with the seat cities and the Crownward marked*

X.1 Aurem

Atlanta had Black wealth, Black culture, Black education and Black memory built so deep into the city that the Coalition couldn't flatten it without admitting what it was erasing. So the Empire dressed it up and called it restoration. The BeltLine became a ceremonial promenade lined with statues and Broadcast screens. Historic

neighborhoods became Stewardwife districts, and Peachtree Street became Covenant Way. Magnolias were planted everywhere because they photograph well and rot slowly. Aurelia is the Empire's favorite mirror, Atlanta wearing somebody else's clothes, and the most surveilled and showcased territory in the Empire (**TL**).

It's humid from May through October. Storms leave the streets smelling of pine and wet concrete, and the red clay keeps bleeding through the paving. Black culture went deepest underground here and survived most stubbornly. Imperial hymns play on Covenant Way, and something else plays in the outer districts. Food is the main vessel of memory, and the Empire never thought the kitchen was dangerous enough to watch.

Aurem has the highest Commonwife rate and the most elaborate marriage ceremonies in the Empire, on purpose. It's the Empire's favorite Broadcast Dominion, with fifteen Anointed Wives across thirty-eight Trials. Its Covenant Daughter gets forty-seven seconds on Sovereign Boulevard in the Opening Procession, more than anyone else, and every girl in Aurem knows that number before she can read. An Aurem candidate is expected to win. The outer districts watch the scores with the intensity of people who never see their names on anything. Death is the place where "the Empire lost completely and still has no idea" (see VIII.4).

X.2 Gulf

New Orleans was never going to be easy. The first Governor-Prelate lasted fourteen months and reported the city "resistant to spiritual reorientation." The Empire settled for managing it. Port Seraphine is loyal enough for the Broadcast and layered enough underground that the Vowed have learned to look away. Hurricane season takes half the year, and the city is "built on water and spite." Gulf is the most culturally intact Dominion: music survived here, standing in plain sight, because tourism, rebranded as "cultural pilgrimage," earns too much to lose. Gulf candidates arrive fluent in being watched, and the scoring system has historically penalized them for warmth, which Crown advisors read as performance. A Gulf woman who knows the gap between what she shows and what she keeps is one of the most dangerous women in the room.

X.3 Ardenne

Appalachia was never fully inside America's idea of itself, and it isn't fully inside the Empire's. Ashford is the city the Empire keeps as proof that Ardenne is pacified, and everything past the tree line says otherwise. It has real winters, hollows that cut communities off from each other and from surveillance, and fog thick enough to hide the next house. The Ungoverned have their deepest roots here. Outer Ardenne children who get assessed score extraordinarily well, since children raised to solve real problems do well on problem-solving tests. Ardenne rarely sends a Covenant Daughter, and when it does she's usually from Ashford and quiet about the gap.

X.4 Meridian

The Empire took Philadelphia for its symbolism. The city that held the Declaration of Independence now holds the legal architecture of everything the Declaration claimed to prevent. Blessed Shore houses the Covenant Court's secondary chambers. Meridian absorbed Imperial culture more completely than almost anywhere, because its administrators trust process. Its underground is made of lawyers and bureaucrats filing precise challenges that go nowhere and documenting them for a future someone is preparing. Stewardwives here are expert readers of Binding contracts, trained in Reading Circles. Meridian candidates know every rule and where the gaps are, which makes one who decides to move almost impossible to stop. Corinne Vale is from Blessed Shore (**TR**).

X.5 Vane

New York was the hardest cultural conquest and the one the Empire brags about most. It named the whole Dominion after its founding Emperor, which is both honor and leash. Saint Meridian is the Broadcast capital, and the studios that announce Trial scores sit in old Midtown. The skyline stayed, and everything underneath it changed. The city's density makes surveillance both total and porous, and it has the largest Ungoverned-sympathizer population of any seat city. Vane is the legacy Dominion. Some families have sent Covenant Daughters to three consecutive Trials, and high-scoring girls are prepared for candidacy from the time they can read. Calla Merritt is from Saint Meridian (**TR**).

X.6 Irongate

Chicago gave the Empire industry and political machinery, which it kept, and music, which it tried to dismantle. Blues and jazz were labeled "morally ambiguous musical forms" in 2053 and went underground. Iron Benediction is the manufacturing heart of the Empire. Irongate is the most class-divided Dominion, and its labor and administrative districts might as well be different civilizations. The labor-district women run a mutual aid network called the Kitchen that the Vowed have never mapped. Covenant Daughters are almost always administrative daughters, because selection rewards polish and polish costs money. Nadia Orin is the exception, the most working-class Covenant Daughter in Trial history (**TR**).

X.7 Heartland

The Heartland didn't need conquering, because the Coalition had been building here for decades. Providence Cross is the most genuinely loyal seat city in the Empire. People sing the hymns because they mean them. Their sincerity is the Empire's most valuable asset and one of its hardest to control, because real believers have opinions about what faithfulness requires. Some of the Empire's most serious theological debates happen here, including

Heartland women's "theological inquiry" into the Commonwife designation. Heartland sends the most theologically fluent Covenant Daughters, for whom devotion is both credential and liability. Ruth Gideon is from Providence Cross (**TR**).

X.8 Red Earth

Oklahoma's history of land taken and people removed came before the Empire. Canaan's Gate is built over a city that survived the 1995 bombing, and the Empire likes that resilience story. Red Earth piloted the Commonwife quota in 2058, and its women have lived under the full version longest. It's the most visibly religious Dominion in its architecture and the most privately exhausted, with scripture on every building and the Vowed embedded as "pastoral care." Under the performance runs a language of small signals refined over decades. Red Earth candidates are the best in the Empire at performing compliance while thinking something else. Delia Cross is from Canaan's Gate. Her family was transferred there from Aurem when she was six, and she carries a grudge against the Dominion she left (**TR**).

X.9 Lone

Texas negotiated its surrender. The Empire got the territory and Texas kept the attitude. Covenant Basin runs on oil wealth and space infrastructure. Its Governor-Prelate is always Texas-born and has more independence than any other. The distances leave real gaps in the surveillance grid, so west Lone is managed through local Vowed officers. People here perform loyalty loudly and then do what they were going to do anyway, and outer-territory women have a practical autonomy that would get them flagged in Aurem. Lone treats the Trials like any other Imperial requirement. Vivienne Hale is from Covenant Basin (**TR**).

X.10 Mountain

The Empire wanted the mountains for what's inside them: minerals, military installations, elevation and secrecy. Crestfall is the face, and the mountains are the truth. The classified operations there are the Empire's least documented and most important work: surveillance technology, resource extraction, Temple expansion funding and military capacity. Crestfall women are the most physically capable in the Empire and among the most watched. Girls selected at Designation for classified Vowed service disappear from public life. Mountain has never produced an Anointed Wife. Endurance was held in Mountain terrain for Trials 1 through 31, moved to a controlled facility for 32 through 38, and returned to the mountains for the 39th without explanation. Petra Solano is from Crestfall (**TR**). Azrael is hidden in Mountain Dominion, in a community whose patriarch owes the Vanes a debt (**TL**). Lyris is from Mountain too (**WR**).

X.11 Sable

The desert resists the Empire the way deserts resist everything, by not caring. Heat destroys equipment, sand gets into everything, and the distances defeat centralized monitoring. Sable Reach is the ornate Imperial city the Empire keeps as proof it can reach hard country. The desert beyond it is where Ungoverned crossings happen. The desert held civilizations long before the United States, and the Empire renamed the cities but not the land. Women in the outer communities carry plant and land knowledge the Empire has never catalogued. Every Sable woman has two names, one for the Empire and one for the house. Zara Voss is from Sable Reach, and her desert name is Tazaleh (**TL, TR**).

INTERPRETATION Sable's two-name custom and Celeste's house name for Eden are the same instinct in two Dominions. Eden and Zara's name exchange in the middle of the book rests on it.

X.12 Pacific

Pacific carries the memory of resistance like scar tissue. The secession attempt and the two-year standoff produced a generation that remembers trying to leave, and their grandchildren know the story. The Empire watches Westhold harder than anywhere: more cameras per block, more loyalty programming, and a Governor-Prelate Dorian appointed personally, who performs warmth while administering iron. Old Los Angeles's creative industries adapted instead of dying, and people still make what they actually want and pass it through networks the Empire can't map. Every Pacific girl's Designation is reviewed in the Crownward for inherited resistance, and every Pacific Covenant Daughter arrives already flagged. Sera Montoya is from Westhold (**TR**).

Working Questions

1. Where are Washington, Alaska and Hawaii?
2. How did Aurem get fifteen Anointed Wives? Which Trials were they, and does Aurelia remember their names?
3. What does the forty-seven seconds actually show, every year?
4. What is the real name of Aurelia's outer districts, and what do people in Sector Seven call their own streets?
5. What happened in the Gulf the year the Empire tried and failed to stop the music?
6. Who leads the Ungoverned in the Ardenne hollows, and what do they know about the Crownward?
7. What debt does the Mountain patriarch owe the Vanes, and from when?
8. What does each Dominion's Governor-Prelate want from the 39th Trial?
9. Which Dominion would Eden most fear being sent to, and why?

10. What do people in the other eleven Dominions think of Aurem, its forty-seven seconds and its fifteen Anointed Wives?

Working pages

PART X

DECIDED

DATE

PART XI

The Covenant Trials as an institution

*The Covenant Trials are a televised selection. Each Dominion sends one Covenant Daughter, and over about four months the Crown Heir's Anointed Wife is chosen from the twelve. The other eleven are married down the elite ladder (**TR, FR 19, 26**). The Empire presents the Trials as revelation, not competition, because "a competition can be rigged. A revelation cannot" (**TR**). This part covers how the Trials work in any year. What happens in the 39th Trial belongs to Volume Two.*

XI.1 History

WHEN	WHAT	SOURCE
2048	Elias Vane marries Sera Callum. The first Anointed marriage becomes the template.	**TL**
2065	Crest introduces the Trials as "a celebration of the Empire's finest women." The first cycle is rough, and the ratings are extraordinary.	**TL**
22nd Trial	Ladies in Waiting introduced, to keep high performers in the Crownward instead of sending them home with influence nobody can manage	**TR**
Trials 1–31	Endurance held in Mountain terrain	**DOM**
2085	That year's Trial cancelled after Crest dies mid-cycle and Dorian's accession forces an Imperial transition. The twelve are sent home with their designations intact and no placements.	**FR 34, 39**
From 2085	Under Dorian the Trials become the most-watched event in the Empire's calendar	**TL**
Trials 32–38	Endurance moved to a controlled facility with continuous filming	**TR, DOM**
2104	The 39th Trial. Endurance returns to Mountain terrain without public explanation.	**TR**

INFERENCE The Trials run every year. The first was in 2065, and with 2085 skipped, the 39th lands in 2104 (**FR 39**).

The 2085 cohort met while being assembled, prepared and measured against each other, and they're now scattered through their home Dominions. Their shared history makes a network possible, but it doesn't activate before Book Two (**FR 34**). The 2085 cohort is the thing Hannah has never said out loud (**FR 30**). **INFERENCE** She was one of the twelve. (Volume Two, Hannah.)

XI.2 Eligibility and nomination

Every Dominion keeps a Covenant Registry of women aged 18 to 25 who meet five requirements (**TR**).

- Unbound or elevated designation
- No prior marriage registration
- No Ungoverned citations
- Completion of the standard Imperial curriculum
- "Demonstrated covenantal aptitude," which means whatever the Governor-Prelate needs it to mean

Vowed officers, family members or community leaders can nominate a woman, or she can nominate herself. The Empire frames self-nomination as exceptional faith. In practice the process is built to exhaust anyone without institutional support, and most self-nominations fail for that reason alone (**TR**). In Aurem, self-nomination is "independent submission": a ten-dollar nonrefundable fee and a registration card printed in red instead of bordered in gold (**DR3**). Eden is the first Aurem candidate in the Trials' history to enter that way (**TL**).

Eligibility isn't entry. A House Mother can submit a name, but she isn't the only person who can (**FR 27**).

XI.3 The Regional Assessment and selection

Each Dominion runs a three-day Regional Assessment under senior Vowed officers, which produces a ranked list (**TR, TL**). In Aurem, results are posted in the Temple atrium on the third Monday of June at seven in the morning, and the top five are appointed to the Covenant. Their photographs hang in the atrium through the summer, and their families get the useful kind of formal review, the kind where unpaid levies disappear (**DR3**). Some sections, like Discernment and Spiritual Fitness, are graded by ministerial review, so a girl can know every answer and still fail for a lack of humility (**DR3**).

The Governor-Prelate chooses the Covenant Daughter from the top three. In practice he picks whoever the Crown has quietly signaled it prefers, then documents it as a choice from the top three regardless of the real ranking (**TR**).

XI.4 Arrival

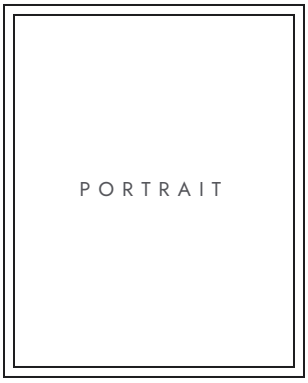
The twelve arrive in the first week of summer, staggered across seven days so each arrival can be released as its own day of content. Each travels by Dominion transport with two Appointed Officers and her House Mother (**TR**). Each walks Sovereign Boulevard on camera. The walk is choreographed, and candidates are told what pace to keep, where to look and how to hold their hands (**CR**).

XI.5 The Covenant Houses

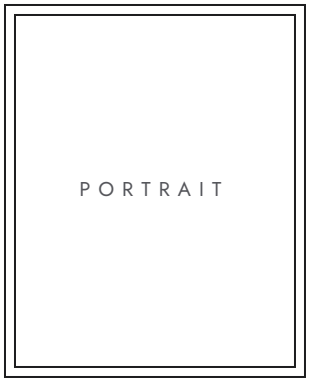
Twelve townhouses line Covenant Row, one per Dominion, close enough to walk to Sovereign Boulevard in under five minutes. Cameras cover every common area, entrance and garden, but not the bedrooms (**CR**). The candidates aren't sequestered. They're embedded in Crownward public life: Temple services, forums, the approved dining rooms, the Administrative Side markets (**CR**).

Each House has permanent staff. In House Aurem those are the House Mother, the House Coordinator, the stylist and the Debate and Protocol Advisor (**TL**). A House hosts one Covenant Daughter per Trial, and House staff serve across many Trials. Hannah's "six Trials, twelve girls" counts her whole career across several Houses and posts (**FR 26**).

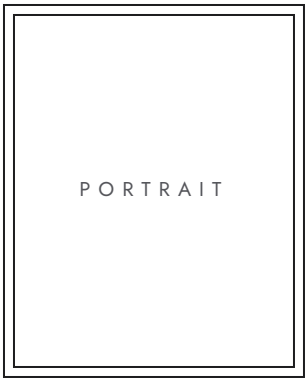
PORTRAITS



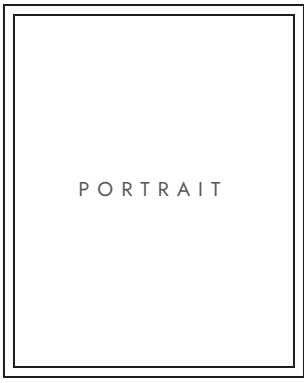
Hannah
House Mother, House Aurem



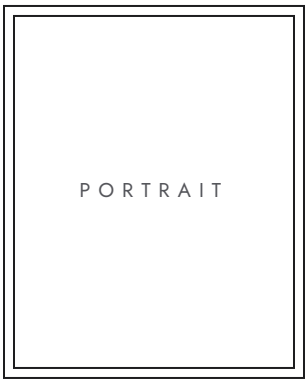
Naomi
Hannah's daughter



Abigail
Debate and Protocol Advisor



The House Coordinator
House Aurem



The stylist
House Aurem

XI.6 The three phases

The Trials run in three phases. Each belongs to a different power and asks a different question. The three phases also line up with the novel's Genesis, Exodus and Revelation (**TR**).

PHASE	DOMAIN	THE QUESTION	COMPONENTS	WEIGHT
One: the Covenant Examination (weeks 1–4)	The Temple (Genesis)	Who are you?	The Settling, the Doctrinal Assessment, the Theological Interview, the Public Testimony	30%
Two: the Governance Trials (weeks 5–10)	The Crown (Exodus)	How smart are you?	The Dominion Forum, the Civic Debates, the Anointed Evening, the Pairing Introduction	30%
Three: Endurance (three days)	The terrain (Revelation)	What are you willing to endure?	Coordinates to reach across three days, with no schedule, no handlers and no cameras after deployment	Feeds the Broadcast's 40%

Phase One. The Settling is presented as a grace period, and it's actually the most intensive assessment of all, because the Vowed watch everything. The Doctrinal Assessment is a six-hour written exam in the Temple Sanctum, set at each candidate's ceiling, so no two girls get the same questions. The Theological Interview is a conversation with a senior Vowed officer, who's told to pursue any rehearsed answer until she finds what's underneath it. The Public Testimony is a fifteen-minute statement of faith and purpose, broadcast live, and the first time the Empire hears each candidate speak unmediated. Candidates are given Vowed handlers to "ensure theological accuracy," and they can decline them (**TR**).

Phase Two. The Dominion Forum puts every remaining candidate in a room with an Empire-wide crisis and no assigned leader. The Civic Debates are three filmed debates on governance, theology and social policy, with the topics given an hour beforehand, and the Crown Heir moderates the social policy debate. The Anointed Evening is four hours with the Anointed Court in the Crown Palace, where the cameras can't follow into the side rooms. The Pairing Introduction is thirty minutes alone with the Heir, with a Crown advisor and a Vowed officer present and a camera outside the door. The room itself isn't recorded (**TR**). The Commission has been known to wire candidates before Pairing Introductions (**TR**).

Phase Three. Endurance tests what the Empire calls covenantal fortitude and the terrain calls survival. The Broadcast films the deployment and the final checkpoint. Everything in between is reconstructed afterward from the candidates' accounts and is always incomplete (**TR**).

SUPERSEDED The original Trials file used four phases: the Covenant Examination, the Governance Trials, the Public Season and the Declaration.

OPEN QUESTION The original file also had candidates sign a confidentiality covenant before the Crown's phase, with immediate removal and a permanent Ungoverned citation for breaking it (**TR-orig**). Does that rule still exist?

XI.7 Scoring

The Covenant Score is a composite. The weights are never disclosed: Temple 30 percent, Crown 30 percent, Broadcast 40 percent. The Broadcast's share includes narrative-priority decisions by the Broadcast Director (TR). Scores update on the Sovereign Boulevard screens every evening at seven, in a ritual the Empire named the Evening Reckoning (TR).

Every Trial produces a Broadcast antagonist narrative, and it's assigned to the candidate who most threatens a comfortable outcome, not to the eventual winner. When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, the Broadcast calls it internally the Eve problem. The narrative implies and never accuses. It moves the Covenant Score without changing a single formal assessment, and it has worked every time it's been used (TR).

XI.8 The Declaration and its rules

After the Endurance rankings are confirmed, the Crown Heir names his Anointed Wife in a public ceremony on Sovereign Boulevard, broadcast live in all twelve Dominions (TR). The rules around that moment come from your Final Rulings.

- **The ranked winner.** The heir may choose any of the twelve. "Without deviation" describes the record, not a rule (FR 20).
- **What winning means.** Being the choice that costs the Crown nothing. The rankings tell the heir which selection is free. Deviation is permitted and expensive, and no heir has ever paid it (FR 21).
- **Refusal.** The recommendation stands by default once the Declaration window closes. Refusing is abstention, not resistance, and produces the same result as complying (FR 22).
- **Cancellation.** Impossible once the Trial is announced, except in a public dynastic emergency: the Heir's death or incapacity, or the Emperor's death forcing an immediate transition. A candidate's death doesn't downgrade a Trial (FR 23).
- **A candidate's death.** Her status goes back to her family, with no compensation and no punishment, as though the designation had never been made (FR 24).
- **Rejected candidates.** Married down as designated. The rejection follows them "not in the record, in the room" (FR 25).
- **Ladies in Waiting.** The third- and fourth-place Endurance finishers stay in the Crownward in supporting roles to the Anointed Wife and the Crown household (TR).

The Imperial Binding that follows is covered in Part IX.3.

XI.9 The Covenant Daughters of the 39th Trial

For reference. Their stories are in Volume Two, Part III.

COVENANT DAUGHTER	DOMINION	FROM	AGE
Eden Selah Osei	Aurem	Aurelia	21
Delphine Fontenot	Gulf	Port Seraphine	22
Maren Cole	Ardenne	Ashford	23
Corinne Vale	Meridian	Blessed Shore	22
Calla Merritt	Vane	Saint Meridian	21
Nadia Orin	Irongate	Iron Benediction	20
Ruth Gideon	Heartland	Providence Cross	22
Delia Cross	Red Earth	Canaan's Gate	24
Vivienne Hale	Lone	Covenant Basin	23
Petra Solano	Mountain	Crestfall	22
Zara Voss	Sable	Sable Reach	21
Sera Montoya	Pacific	Westhold	24

Source: TR, Ruling (Calla's surname).

PORTRAITS



Eden Selah Osei
Aurem, 21



Delphine Fontenot
Gulf, 22



Maren Cole
Ardenne, 23



Corinne Vale
Meridian, 22



Calla Merritt
Vane, 21



Nadia Orin
Irongate, 20



Ruth Gideon
Heartland, 22



Delia Cross
Red Earth, 24



Vivienne Hale
Lone, 23



Petra Solano
Mountain, 22



Zara Voss
Sable, 21



Sera Montoya
Pacific, 24

Working Questions

1. Who sits on the Trials Commission and the oversight committee, and are they the same body?
2. What do Ladies in Waiting actually do day to day, and who has held the title?
3. What were the Trials like in the 2060s and 2070s, before Dorian made them spectacle?
4. Who chose to bring Endurance back to Mountain terrain for the 39th, and why?
5. What does a Doctrinal Assessment question look like at Eden's ceiling? Write one.
6. What does a House Mother do across a career of many Trials? What happens to House staff when their girl loses?

7. What has happened to the women the Eve narrative was used on in earlier Trials?
8. Has a Covenant Daughter ever died before Petra? How did the Empire handle it?
9. What does the Broadcast's narrative-priority decision look like inside the Citadel, and who signs off on it?
10. What does a girl's family in Aurem get, specifically, when she's appointed to the Covenant?
11. What do the men assigned to the eleven know about their brides before the Declaration?
12. Does the confidentiality covenant still exist?

Working pages

PART XI

DECIDED

DATE

Canon register

Everything this volume flags, collected so you can settle it in one sitting. Each line is the first sentence of the flag, with the section where it sits. The full flag is in the text.

The five sweeps from the Final Rulings

SWEEP	WHERE IT LANDS HERE	STATUS
Thomas is abandonment, not removal	IX.4, Part III name table	Done
Celeste no longer knows Miriam is alive	VI.4	Done in this volume. Celeste's and Eden's dossiers (Volume Two) still need it.
Eden placed 2085, alone	Volume Two (nothing in this volume contradicts it)	Consistent here
Twelve Dominions, one girl each	XI.5, XI.9	Done
Petra's death costs the Trial nothing	XI.8	Done

Conflicts between your sources

SECTION	THE FLAG
VI.1	The timeline introduces the Commonwife quotas under Crest in 2062, and the Dominions file says Red Earth piloted them in 2058.
VI.5	The timeline says she came from "the Northern Dominion."
IX.4	The timeline makes Leah Eden's older sister (**TL**), and FR 5 calls Leah, Zion and Solomon "the younger three."

Superseded material

SECTION	THE FLAG
II.3	The old Companion's Exodus page marks "Prelate Huldah's office" as canon and gives that office the Empire's handling of the liberation material.

SECTION	THE FLAG
VI.5	The Crownward file gives Dorian's age as 61.
VII.2	The Crownward file calls Crest Dorian's father.
IX.4	The timeline gives Solomon's age as thirteen.
IX.4	Any framing of Thomas's 2084 departure as an Empire removal (**FR 3**).
XI.6	The original Trials file used four phases: the Covenant Examination, the Governance Trials, the Public Season and the Declaration.

Open Questions

SECTION	THE FLAG
II.3	Who named the Dominions, and does the Temple teach the verse as rule or as care?
II.3	Does the Temple teach the curse of Ham?
III	Who in the Empire would be asked to authenticate the Dissent if it surfaced?
III	Does anyone in Dorian's court have Nathan's office, licensed or not?
IV	Does the Temple say "debts" or "trespasses" in public worship, and does it print Luke's shorter version anywhere?
V	Does the Empire hold the translation and the copy?
V	Do the egalitarian arguments survive in Meridian's Reading Circles or in Heartland's theological inquiry (**DOM**)?
VI.3	What does the Act's preamble say?
VI.5	Who was the mother of Elias's children?
VII.7	What does an Ungoverned citation actually do to a person beyond disqualifying her?
VIII.2	Is the Book of Covenant the full Protestant Bible, an abridged edition (see I.7 and Part V on the 1807 Slave Bible), or scripture bound together with the Empire's own founding texts?
IX.1	Is that the six? If so, what's the official order, and where does Vowed rank?
IX.3	Does the hyphenated surname apply only in Aurem, or Empire-wide?
IX.4	How does reassignment work? Who decides it, what is the woman's status during it, and why did Solomon keep the Osei name?
IX.6	What is Home Instruction? Training for wives, a teaching role, or something else?

SECTION	THE FLAG
IX.6	Bell's offer reads as if Leah sat an Assessment.
X	Washington, Alaska and Hawaii don't appear in any Dominion.
XI.6	The original file also had candidates sign a confidentiality covenant before the Crown's phase, with immediate removal and a permanent Ungoverned citation for breaking it (**TR-orig**).

Working pages

CANON REGISTER

DECIDED **DATE**